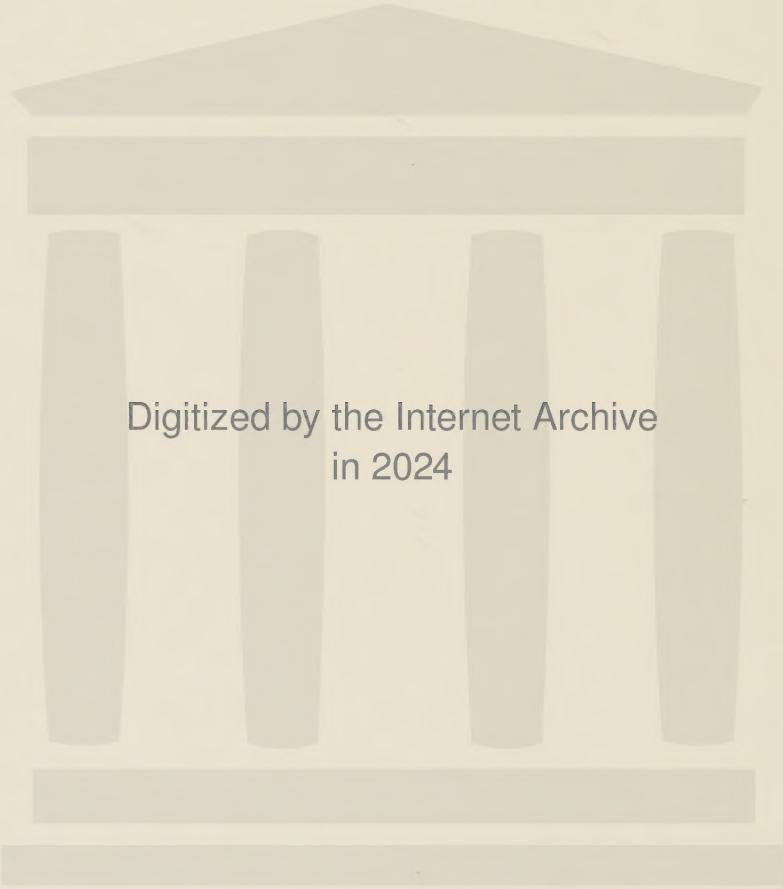




Digitized by the Internet Archive
in 2024

SICILY

The Insecure Base

SICILY

ms

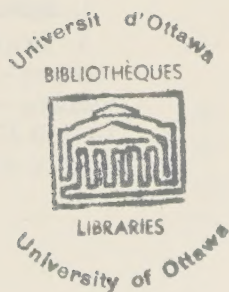
The Insecure Base

A History of the British Occupation
of Sicily, 1806–1815

Desmond Gregory



Rutherford • Madison • Teaneck
Fairleigh Dickinson University Press
London and Toronto: Associated University Presses



18170/19894
© 1988 by Associated University Presses, Inc.

DG

868.42

.G74

1988

Associated University Presses
440 Forsgate Drive
Cranbury, NJ 08512

Associated University Presses
25 Sicilian Avenue
London WC1A 2QH, England

Associated University Presses
2133 Royal Windsor Drive
Unit 1
Mississauga, Ontario
Canada L5J 1K5

The paper used in this publication meets the requirements
of the American National Standard for Permanence of Paper
for Printed Library Materials Z39.48-1984.

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Gregory, Desmond, 1916—
Sicily: the insecure base.

Bibliography: p.

Includes index.

1. Sicily—History—1806–1815. 2. Sicily—Foreign
relations—Great Britain. 3. Great Britain—Foreign
relations—Sicily. I. Title.

DG868.42.G74 1988 945'.808 86-46244
ISBN 0-8386-3306-4 (alk. paper)

Printed in the United States of America

Contents

Preface	7
Acknowledgments	9
Introduction	11
1 Getting a Foothold	15
2 Sicily as the British Found It in 1806	35
3 Problems of Defense in the Early Years of Occupation	45
4 The Court, William Drummond, and the British Generals	58
5 Threats of Invasion and Counterinvasion	71
6 Growing Impatience with the Court at Palermo	79
7 Lord William Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage One	88
8 Lord William Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage Two	104
9 Sicily as a Base for Offensive Operations, 1812–1814	109
10 Speculation on the Future of Sicily and Naples	121
11 The Dénouement	129
Appendix A: The Economic Implications of the British Occupation of Sicily	137
Appendix B: Attempts Made from Sicily to Rescue Pope Pius VII	141
Notes	147
Bibliography	165
Index	171

“Always operate from firm bases.”

—Field Marshal Lord Montgomery

Preface

In writing this short history of the British occupation of Sicily during the war against Napoleon, I lay no claim to originality. My debt to the two perceptive books by Dr. John Rosselli on Lord William Bentinck and to Dr. Piers Mackesy's masterly history of the war in the Mediterranean from 1803 to 1810 are, I need hardly add, enormous. I am also much indebted to the writings of Antonio Capograssi, Denis Mack Smith, Jacques Rambaud, Charles Auriol, R. M. Johnston, Angela Valente, and Harold Acton, though I have naturally had recourse to those primary sources available in this country.

But my aim has been to try to synthesize the findings and conclusions of others, in works in English, French, and Italian, and to attempt to answer these questions—what were the British doing in Sicily, and did they on the whole succeed in achieving what they set out to do there?

Acknowledgments

My thanks are due to the Department of Manuscripts at Nottingham University and to the trustees of the Duke of Portland for permission to include material from the journals of Lord William Bentinck and of Joseph Smith, and from the correspondence of Robert Fagan. I must also thank the Department of Manuscripts at the British Library for permission to quote from the Collingwood, Annesley, Hudson Lowe, Bunbury, Wellesley, Windham, Liverpool, Heytesbury, Fagan, and Pasley manuscripts and from the papers of Sir Alexander Ball. My thanks are also due to the National Library of Scotland for allowing me to see a Lynedoch manuscript and to the National Maritime Museum at Greenwich for permission to inspect letters from Captain Ball to Nelson. Any transcripts of Crown copyright records appear by permission of the Controller of Her Majesty's Stationery Office.

I also wish to thank Mrs. Joan Streatfield for permission to include quotations from the unpublished letters of Lady Dalrymple, Dr. John Rosselli for his guidance on several points, and Professor Francesco Brancato for some helpful suggestions on reading matter.

Finally I must thank Mr. Anthony Seymour for his help in recommending sources and for having made useful recommendations after kindly reading the first draft of this book.

Introduction

Throughout the whole of the period from 1793 to 1815 when Britain was at war almost continuously with the French republic and Napoleon's empire, she contrived to maintain one faithful ally—though one faithful sometimes only in name, and usually more from need than sentiment—Ferdinand, king of Naples and Sicily.

Those two kingdoms, with their long coastlines and their harbors both on the Adriatic and on the Tyrrhenian seas, required the help of a maritime power to preserve their independence from France. But they also needed a military power of the stature of Russia or Austria. Britain could provide them with naval protection, but never with troops in sufficient numbers to withstand the might of the armies of France, and if Russia or Austria or both failed to come to their assistance or made a separate peace with France, all that Britain was able to do was to carry the court to the safety of Sicily and thereafter safeguard that island by covering it with a naval squadron and stationing a garrison there.

The value of the Neapolitan-Sicilian alliance to the British fleet was considerable—the kingdoms' ports supplied the fleet with winter bases, fresh water and food, and during the war of the first coalition, Naples contributed battleships and small craft. Economically, the alliance was important in weakening Napoleon's stranglehold on British trade with the continent of Europe, and militarily, it provided a base for the launching of offensive operations in both eastern and western Mediterranean.

What King Ferdinand wanted from his ally Britain was a guarantee that his mainland kingdom (Naples), lost to France in 1806, would be recovered and returned to his rule at the earliest possible opportunity, and at the latest in a general peace settlement. This Britain was unable to give, although she was willing to guarantee him Sicily. This failure on the part of Great Britain, suspicions (fully justified) that Britain intended to ignore the claims of King Ferdinand to the sovereignty of Malta, and suspicions (that were in fact not justified, though the reason for them was understandable) that Britain intended to take over Sicily and turn it into a permanent protectorate, all put a strain on the alliance. The utter dependence of the court at Palermo on British support from 1806 onward was humiliating for the king and queen, who came to detest, if not Great Britain, at least most of its soldiers and diplomats. Britain, for her part, as the war continued, became increasingly

uneasy about the loyalty of the court at Palermo, and finally came to exercise a virtual dictatorship over Sicily. In the end it was an Austrian army that brought the king back to his capital after the final defeat of Napoleon and enabled him to free himself from his ten-year-old yoke of dependence on Britain. Throughout that period Britain alone prevented the French from taking Sicily, as she had already for a brief time done in the early months of 1799. Britain in her turn gained enormously from being able to use the island in her battle to keep the Mediterranean from turning into a Gallic sea, but she was in the end to find that Sicily became almost more of a liability than an asset, as it involved her in political obligations she found it difficult to discharge.

SICILY

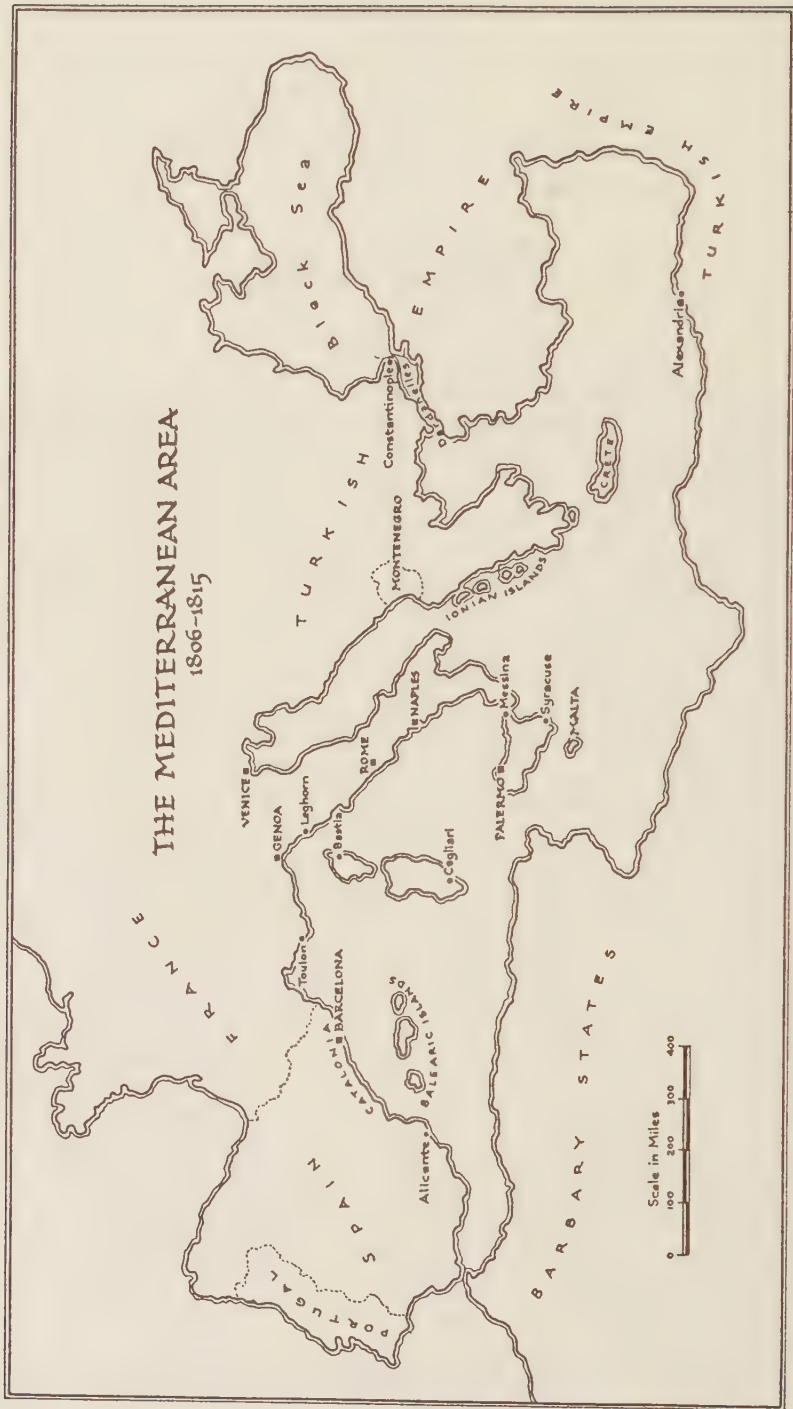
The Insecure Base

Getting a Foothold

During the greater part of the war she fought with revolutionary and Napoleonic France, Britain contrived to maintain a fleet in being in the Mediterranean, supplies for which were largely drawn from the ports of the Neapolitan kingdom, with which was included the kingdom of Sicily. In 1793 and 1798 Britain concluded treaties with Naples, entered into a secret agreement with the government of Naples in 1803, and signed further treaties with that government in Sicily in 1808, 1809, and 1812, all of which conceded to Britain the use of the harbors of the two kingdoms and from 1806, by necessity, those which were situated in Sicily only. The British preoccupation with Sicily, as indeed with nearby Malta, arose not only from her concern to keep her naval squadrons provisioned, but also from her realization of Napoleon's concern to extend his rule beyond Italy to the Levant. It requires no very deep grasp of strategy to see, from the briefest glance at a map, Sicily's importance to any naval power that sought to dominate the Mediterranean. When in the spring of 1793 Pitt decided, once France had declared war, to send a strong fleet to the Mediterranean, he hoped that the Italian states would join in opposing the general threat the French revolutionary government posed. Naples, which had the most to offer so far as naval help was concerned, was hesitant to commit herself until a British fleet had appeared, having been earlier forced by a French one into declaring an unwilling neutrality. However, by the middle of July, a treaty of alliance with Britain was signed, and ships, troops, and sailors were promised in return for British naval protection. Neapolitan troops and ships cooperated in the siege of Toulon and only a serious revolt in Naples, led by sympathizers with the Jacobin cause, prevented serious help being given to the British in their assault on Corsica. However, by 1795 four Neapolitan ships-of-the-line were successfully serving with the British fleet and, a year later, a squadron of gunboats; and when Napoleon seized Leghorn, the main supply base for Admiral Jervis, the ports of Naples gave vital assistance in providing all that the admiral required.

When the decision was made by Pitt at the end of 1796 to withdraw the fleet from the Mediterranean and the Austrian forces in northern Italy were driven out by Napoleon's army, Naples hastened to make peace with the

THE MEDITERRANEAN AREA 1806-1815



French and agreed to revert to her neutral status, though she was still allowed to admit to her ports, on the mainland and Sicily, British ships.¹

By 1798, however, the court of Naples grew so alarmed at the renewed threat of French aggression that it made appeals to Austria and Britain to come to its help if it were attacked and begged the British government to allow some warships to protect its coast. General Berthier in Rome, where the French army was now established, was making demands on the king of Naples that seemed a prelude to occupation, while naval preparations by the French in Toulon, Genoa, and Civit  Vecchia were seen to presage an attack on Sicily.² The British government at this time was trying to rebuild the allied front that had broken down in the past three years, and, as Grenville the secretary of state wrote on 16 January 1798, Europe could be saved from French domination only by the union of the four Great Powers.³

Austria expressed her willingness to assist in defending Naples from attack, but she pressed Britain to dispatch, at once, a fleet to the Mediterranean. Grenville, who had persuaded Pitt that this was the right course to adopt, informed Naples that a squadron under Nelson was shortly to arrive in the Mediterranean. But it was essential that all the king's ports be free to admit this naval force and allow it to buy what supplies it needed; and indeed if this request was not met, the fleet would be ordered to leave at once.⁴

When Nelson's squadron arrived off Naples on 24 June 1798 the attitude of the Naples government to granting these terms remained equivocal. It was divided into two factions, that of the foreign minister de Gallo, which did not wish to antagonize France, and that of Acton, who favored Britain. But in any case it was most unwilling to commit itself to a course of action that might give rise to a French attack until it was sure of Austrian support. The treaty that Austria had signed with Naples on 20 May 1798 was purely defensive in its terms, and not until 16 July was there added to it a clause that provided for Austrian military help, should Naples find herself under attack for opening her ports to the British fleet.⁵

Nelson's plea for the help of frigates was understandably turned down, and his request for the opening of ports to the whole of his fleet was also refused, albeit only officially—the terms of neutrality only allowing three to four warships at any one time to be given entrance to a neutral port. Unofficially, however, Nelson did obtain the agreement he sought, and Acton secretly signed, for the king, a letter instructing the governors of ports to permit free access to Nelson's fleet, see that it was supplied with provisions, and allow its sick and wounded ashore. Even so, this private letter was not dispatched to the governors at once, and Nelson later complained that the governor of Syracuse was ignorant of these terms. However, his fleet was fully provisioned when he called at Syracuse on 20 July in pursuit of the French fleet bound for Egypt, and had it not been, he would have been forced to return to Gibraltar for food and water. The government at Naples had of course been



The Straits of Messina with HMS *Foudroyant*, painted by Pocock, engraved by Hall. (Courtesy of the National Maritime Museum, London.)

waiting for the ratification of the Austrian treaty, with its vital clause affecting the ports, and Hamilton had to explain this to Nelson when he wrote to assure him that all was now well.⁶

In any event, Nelson's crushing victory at Aboukir Bay a few weeks later swung Naples firmly behind the British—her government already alarmed at the French occupation of the island of Malta. The welcome Nelson received from the court on returning to Naples was quite ecstatic and convinced, as he wrote, he had saved Sicily "in spite of Neapolitan councils," he urged the king and queen to attack and drive the French out of Italy. Sir William Hamilton, the British minister, also favored this rash course of action, while the queen hoped to force Austria's hand into making a full-scale offensive alliance, afraid that the emperor might otherwise come to terms with Napoleon and abandon the cause of the smaller powers.⁷ The decision that was made proved disastrous for Naples. Her army, which had advanced to capture Rome, was totally routed by the French, its incompetent Austrian commander Mack escaping south as best he could, its officers deserting, and its troops dispersing. Grenville, too late, had counselled caution, convinced that Naples should not risk going to war until sure of Austrian military support. Austria was extremely angry, having made clear five days before the advance on Rome was actually begun that she very strongly disapproved of Naples taking aggressive action. She also blamed the British government for trying to involve her in a war for which she was insufficiently prepared.⁸

Utterly dismayed at what had happened, the king, the queen, and the royal family took refuge on board Nelson's flagship *Vanguard* and, during the fourth week in December, sailed into temporary exile in Sicily. The people of Naples had begged the king to stay and fight it out with the French, but he

was unwilling to take the risk. Nelson also took away to Palermo two Neapolitan ships-of-the-line, but the rest of that navy having no crews were burned in the bay, on Nelson's orders, so that they should not fall into French hands—three ships-of-the-line, a frigate, a corvette, together with some smaller vessels.⁹ The kingdom of Naples, though not of Sicily, thus passed under the control of the French, and it was not long before they had set up a so-called Parthenopean republic, constructed on the best revolutionary model and with the active cooperation of members of the Neapolitan nobility.

The welcome the king received in Palermo from his subjects in Sicily was warm enough, though the latter detested the Neapolitans. "Down with the cowardly and treacherous Neapolitans" was a cry that echoed in the streets, and one that much offended the queen. But clearly concessions had to be made to the real strength of popular feeling (one with which Nelson was much in sympathy, writing that he thought a proud people had every right to be consulted in matters concerning their own defense). In consequence the king agreed to two Sicilian noblemen (Prince Trabia and Prince Cassaro) being given ministerial posts, though neither proved to be capable. But if the Sicilians loathed the Neapolitans, they detested the French as much, if not more. French émigrés who had fled from Naples on board British ships were refused admission and had to be sent away to Trieste; while a shipload of sick and wounded French soldiers, brought away from the army of Egypt and put ashore at the port of Augusta, were mostly murdered in cold blood by the fanatical local inhabitants.¹⁰

Meanwhile the second coalition, financed by Britain, was taking shape, and a month before the king left Naples his government signed a treaty with Russia. The latter was much concerned to prevent any further expansion of the power of France in the eastern Mediterranean—an expansion that threatened the Turkish Empire—and also concerned to prevent the British from dominating the Mediterranean. The Russians looked at the fate of Malta and of the Ionian islands (both of which Napoleon had seized) and for this reason they could not endure a French occupation of the kingdom of Naples or a French threat to the kingdom of Sicily. Seen from the point of view of Naples (or rather Palermo, for the time being), a Russian offer of military support, which neither Austria nor Britain could make, seemed to have many advantages; in fact the 15,000 troops that the queen had fondly imagined landing from Russian transports to liberate Naples were a figment of her imagination. The only force the Russians provided was a small force of 600 marines from a warship anchored off Manfredonia.¹¹

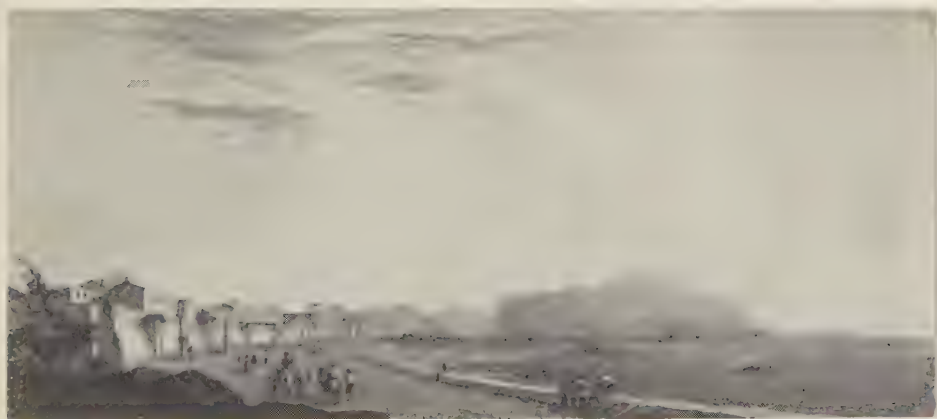
Nelson was personally very hostile to the presence of Russian ships in the area, though the British government welcomed it and reproved him later for taking this stance. Nelson thought the Russians had their eyes on Malta, and when Admiral Ushakov, who had arrived with his fleet off Palermo on 1

September 1799, agreed to assist in the bay of Naples, Nelson at once dispatched Troubridge's squadron to seize Ponza, Ischia, and Procida, enforce a blockade of the port of Naples, and finally land a force of marines and contingents of sailors from British warships to carry the war to the Roman states. But by that time Admiral Ushakov's fleet had been recalled to the Black Sea ports.¹²

Whatever the reasons (and the major one was his notorious attachment to Lady Hamilton), Nelson retained his ships off Sicily through 1799 to 1800, telling Ball, besieging Valletta, that he considered Sicily to be under Britain's special protection. His attention had already been drawn to the vulnerability of Messina, which he rightly saw as the key to Sicily. If the French were to march into Lower Calabria, they had only to cross a strip of water measuring at its narrowest point only a mile and a half across. Much depended on the strength of the fortress and the loyalty of the Messina garrison, and the queen had learnt that Danero, its commander, was neither competent nor even loyal, though this information was certainly false. What was true, and what worried Danero, was the feebleness of the garrison, made up as it was of deserters, criminals, vagabonds, and conscripted Calabresi. Nelson told Troubridge to inspect the defenses and, if need be, land 300 marines, but he changed his mind on the queen's intervention. Instead he transported 500 picked troops from the royal army at Palermo and put them into Messina citadel, but this he considered a temporary measure.¹³ He had in the middle of February written to General Sir Charles Stuart, commanding the British troops in Minorca (a place whose surrender he had recently taken), making it clear that a British force was badly needed in Sicily if the island was not to fall to the French. "What a state we are in here," Nelson had written, "with the enemy at the door and no troops" [to depend on]. The 4,000 Neapolitan troops were totally untrustworthy, while a force of 13,000 Sicilians was still in the process of being raised. Although Messina was a strong fortress, able to withstand a long siege, treachery would probably yield it without ever a shot being fired. Only 1,000 British troops would suffice to make the island secure and Stuart must surely see the need for them.¹⁴ Hamilton wrote in the same vein to his old friend Colonel Graham, then commanding a regiment in Minorca, and to Grenville, the foreign secretary in London. The Sicilians, he thought, might hate the French, but there were enough causes for discontent in towns like Catania, Milazzo, and Trapani (exploited no doubt by Jacobin agents) to have already provoked disturbances; while the garrison at Messina was so distrusted, it was being replaced by troops from Palermo. If action was not soon forthcoming to draw the French off in some other direction, the royal family would again be forced to take refuge on board HMS *Vanguard*, Nelson's flagship that had earlier borne them to safety in Sicily.¹⁵ Graham responded sympathetically. Were Sicily to fall, he told Hamilton, not only Malta but also Egypt would remain firmly in enemy hands. Though



View of the city and port of Messina. (*Courtesy of the British Library, London.*)



Bay of Palermo looking toward Monte Pellegrino. (*Courtesy of the British Museum, London.*)



View of the port of Palermo, engraved by R. and D. Havell. (*Courtesy of the British Library, London.*)

Stuart had no large force to dispose of, Graham was sure that it needed only a small detachment to “do the trick.”¹⁶

Stuart required no further urging. By the end of March he had crossed to Sicily and installed two weak regiments in Messina citadel, to the obvious delight of Nelson and Hamilton and of Ferdinand and his queen, who ordered the governor and troops at Messina henceforth to take their orders from Stuart. Stuart was able to dismiss the garrison of hated Neapolitan troops and to supplement his British force by enlisting 2,000 Sicilian recruits. In May, Colonel Graham was sent from Minorca to take over command of this force. He was even offered a seat on the council of the governing body of Messina, but he had to decline because the duties prescribed to him were purely military. Graham and the two British regiments remained in Messina until December, by which time the danger had long receded, and they were then sent to Malta to join Captain Ball and assist him in the siege of Valletta.¹⁷

There had been an attempt by the queen and Nelson, backed by Sir William Hamilton, when Graham first arrived at Palermo to assume command of Messina garrison, to persuade him to take the British troops there to help in the reconquest of Naples, Calabria being by that time free of any likely threat from the French. Graham replied he would have to see what

troops he could spare when he got to Messina, and on arriving there he made it clear that the British must all remain in the citadel. In this he received the full support of the officer commanding the troops in Minorca, General Sir James St. Clair Erskine. Later attempts were made that year, this time by Nelson, not the court, to get Graham to send his troops to help in the long drawn-out siege of Valletta. Nelson visited Erskine personally to try to get him to let the troops go, but again he met with no success. It was only when Erskine was replaced by Fox that orders arrived to let Graham depart, together with his Messina garrison.¹⁸

Stuart, when writing to Henry Dundas, the secretary of state for war, insisted that it had not simply been the urgent requests from Nelson and others that had prompted him to take the action he had, but a realization that possession of Sicily could help the cause of the allies in Italy by keeping French forces pinned down in Naples, and help also in the capture of Malta. It could also, he added, be a useful base for future offensive operations, either in Egypt or Italy.¹⁹ Stuart was right, and once Britain took Malta, Sicily became of great importance as a major source of supply for that island, which needed its cattle, grain, timber and wine, although the cattle and grain were not always forthcoming. And as the war with Napoleon continued into the nineteenth century and Britain and France became involved in a struggle of economic attrition, Sicily became like Malta an entrepôt for smuggling goods into Napoleonic Europe. Because Neapolitan customs officials were corrupt, almost without exception, communications between Sicily and the mainland were never broken throughout the war. The ports of Sicily, moreover, remained vital to the British fleet in its task of watching the French in Toulon, as well as for keeping open the trade routes from west to east in the Mediterranean.²⁰

Apart from the naval and military protection afforded King Ferdinand by the treaty with Britain, which was signed in December 1798, an *ex gratia* payment of £100,000 was made by the British government in March to help him recover Calabria and Naples.²¹ Thus financed, his patriot army under the command of Cardinal Ruffo succeeded in overrunning Calabria and, by mid-June, had retaken Naples. And when news of Russian victories against their armies in the north arrived, the French had already withdrawn from the city.

On the overthrow of the Parthenopian Republic, which had owed its existence to French military power, Ferdinand, with the assistance of Nelson whose services were rewarded with the duchy of Bronte and the very active support of the queen, took a terrible revenge on his disloyal subjects—one that was not forgotten in Naples and was to cast a lingering shadow over all later attempts the court was to make, when it was once more in exile in Sicily, to enlist the active support of those who had been its subjects on the mainland of Italy.

The British government was most anxious that the king himself should

return to Naples at the earliest possible opportunity, since it looked on the state of disorder there with a sense of continuing and growing disquiet. But the king was not eager to return, at any rate immediately, afraid of possible threats to his life and the lives of the royal family. While he had been exacting vengeance on his Neapolitan subjects, he had never set foot on the soil of Naples, preferring to address his orders from the safety of the cabin of Nelson's flagship.

Troubridge had written in a letter to Nelson of the appalling state of corruption, oppression, and economic stagnation he had encountered in the kingdom of Naples, and of the need for an act of oblivion in regard to the thousands who were being held for trial. And Sir Arthur Paget, the young British minister who succeeded Hamilton at Palermo but who had called in at Naples en route, made the same kind of report to Grenville. In pressing the court for the king's swift return and pressing the need for reform of the government, Paget made himself very unpopular. The queen called him "the detested Paget" and complained in a letter she wrote to de Gallo of Paget's hard and abrupt manner—"it is clear that Paget wants us to feel all the weight of his country's power." Acton greeted Paget's suggestion that the amnesty granted by the king on 31 May 1800 would have much more effect if the king in person were to supervise its enactment with what Paget described as a "degree of ill-humour." Acton told Paget the king had a right to be free of all outside interference in running his kingdoms' internal affairs, and that he must be free to choose how long he spent in either Naples or Sicily. Paget thought that the queen's opposition to the speedy return of the king arose more from pique than from principle, stemming, he believed, from the "effect of their own humiliating and dependent position." "The queen has been taught to believe that I was sent here to dictate, to use haughty language upon the subject, at which idea . . . she was violently irritated."²²

Paget was convinced, as he told Grenville, that nothing good or useful could be done in Sicily without some sort of direct intervention, and "the more I reflect upon it the more despondent I feel." As Harold Acton remarked, in his book on the subject of the Bourbons of Naples, this sounds like the voice of Lord William Bentinck speaking fourteen years before his time.²³

Napoleon's victory at Marengo and Russia's defection from the allied cause meant that Naples was once again threatened by invasion from a French army. The king begged Britain to send him troops, but Paget had to tell Ferdinand that only Austria could help him. The British government was in no position to send more than 15,000 men, and such numbers would be of little avail against the armies France could command. Any assistance Britain could give would have to be purely maritime.²⁴ When four months later at Lunéville Austria made a separate peace without any reference to her allies, the British government advised Ferdinand to make the best terms he could



Sir Arthur Paget by Count d'Orsay. (Courtesy of the National Portrait Gallery, London.)

with France, disregarding any engagement he might previously have made with Britain. If by such terms he was forced to exclude British ships from his kingdoms' harbors, this would be regarded by Britain as an act of necessity, not hostility.²⁵ With this advice, and in view of the fact that the French were preparing to land in Sicily where there was no longer a British garrison, the king, who was totally unprepared to put up resistance in the island,²⁶ hastened to make a separate peace.

In March 1801 King Ferdinand signed the Treaty of Florence with Napoleon by which he was permitted to recover his kingdom, shorn only of its Elban and Tuscan adjuncts; provided he maintained a strict neutrality and agreed to accept, feed, and pay for a French army of occupation, until a general peace should be signed. Not until then did he return to Naples. Sicily however remained exposed, and only the news that Addington's ministry had

finally signed the Treaty of Amiens prevented the French from seizing Messina.²⁷

By the Treaty of Amiens Britain agreed to leave Malta within three months and to hand it back to the Knights of St. John. But before leaving she was naturally anxious to ensure that the island remain friendly and capable of defending itself. To this end she persuaded Ferdinand to dispatch 2,000 of his troops to Malta, secretly agreeing to pay their cost to the tune of £50,000. Naples claimed sovereignty over Malta—a claim dating back to the sixteenth century—and King Ferdinand had been bitterly offended at the way by which in August 1800, after the French in Valletta had surrendered to the British, General Pigot had not allowed the hoisting of the Neapolitan flag beside that of the Knights of St. John. Ferdinand had also taken it ill when in January 1801 Malta had been declared a British protectorate without his even being consulted.²⁸ Now that it was to be handed back under the Treaty of Amiens, it was important to both Britain and Naples that it should not again fall prey to the French. Paget tried to impress on Ferdinand that the independence of Sicily could not be preserved if Malta was lost, and that as long as Malta was friendly or neutral, the island of Sicily could be defended.²⁹ When it rapidly became apparent that, in view of Napoleons' provocative actions, Britain intended to keep hold of Malta, whatever might have been said in the treaty, Napoleon made approaches to Ferdinand for a military alliance and the joint seizure of Malta. These approaches were tactfully rejected on the grounds that his kingdoms were too exhausted to take part in fresh hostilities, and that war with Britain (repugnant in any case, since that country had been a faithful ally) would only result in Naples being blockaded and her population reduced to starvation.³⁰

When in May 1803 Britain renewed the war with Napoleon, the latter sent an army once again to occupy the coasts of Apulia and Abruzzi within the confines of the kingdom of Naples. Not unnaturally this resulted in renewed tension between Naples and Napoleon, the former tacitly supporting Britain, bitterly resenting the French occupation, yet desperately anxious to maintain its neutrality. Sir John Acton, the British-born minister who still carried the most weight with the king and who really directed royal policy, made secret approaches to the British, very soon after war broke out. He urged them to occupy Messina and other ports in Sicily, if the French army of occupation showed signs of moving out of its bases. "We shall protest against the measure to save appearances," he told A'Court, the British *chargé d'affaires* in Naples, and if the French then attacked Sicily, Neapolitan forces would help to defend it.³¹ A'Court thought the French were still so dispersed that no immediate danger threatened, but he said he would inform Admiral Bickerton and the British governor of Malta (Ball) if the French started to concentrate, so that appropriate action could be taken.³²

Nelson, who was bringing out the new minister, Hugh Elliot, to the court

of Naples, had orders from Addington to act vigorously if the French tried to attack Sicily and to take good care of the royal family whom George III considered to be "the most faithful allies he ever had." Colonel Villettes, the officer who commanded the British garrison in Malta, had also received orders from London to provide as many as 2,000 troops (if he could spare them) to seize Messina, should Nelson decide it was necessary. Nelson, while fully appreciating the reservations of the king and queen, who had no wish to risk having to flee through premature action by the British in Sicily, urged Acton to take no risks. "Though Naples be lost, Sicily is secure; but if Sicily is lost so is Naples."³³ Nelson also impressed on Elliot the necessity for speedy action, if it looked as if Sicily would be attacked: "In a small degree we risk it every day, in hopes of preserving the kingdom of Naples." The danger, as he saw it, was that the enemy could ferry over some thousands of men in a very short time, if they had the boats. And no navy in Europe could stop them, with the current running at seven knots.³⁴

The trouble was, as Nelson realized, the very real fears of the king and queen that they might provoke Napoleon, who, deeply suspicious of the court of Naples, was shortly to demand and procure the dismissal of Acton on account of that statesman's notorious Anglophilism, the dismissal of the émigré French Count Damas (in command of the Neapolitan army) and even to demand, though unsuccessfully, the removal of Elliot from his post as minister. The queen was genuinely frightened that Nelson and Elliot between them might involve Naples again in a war. She wrote in September 1803, "It will be a real miracle of St. Januarius if, caught between Nelson and Elliot, we are not dragged into some adventure which will reduce us to the situation of the king of Sardinia," [now a puppet of the French republic]. And again in May of the following year she complained to her correspondent de Gallo, "The English accuse us of being pro-French and the French pro-English—all we want is to be neutral and get rid of French troops."³⁵

Yet Elliot had already become a spokesman for the queen's more cautious approach and he impressed the need for it on Nelson and Ball: "We are steering between Scylla and Charybdis, it is as dangerous to do too much as too little."³⁶ Ball, in Malta, when writing to Elliot, acknowledged the force of the latter's argument, that it was unwise to risk losing Naples by taking overhasty action in Sicily. Yet he remained extremely suspicious of the pro-French elements in the Naples cabinet, and he was worried that the Sicilians themselves, discontented with rule from Naples, would if not assisted by Britain turn to the French out of desperation.³⁷ For this reason he had ordered Villettes to have a force of 1,200 ready to move on Messina in an emergency.³⁸

Certainly Ball had extreme views about the future of Sicily and its relationship to Great Britain—views he shared with his correspondents William Miles, an agent of Pitt, Francis Leckie, the English consul at Syracuse and a

gentleman farmer in that area, and Granville Penn, the under secretary at the Colonial Office in London. He had, he wrote to Penn, told Nelson and Elliot that if Sicily should fall to the French, they would draw more wealth and resources from it than from the whole of Italy. Whereas, he went on, "a good proclamation and fifteen hundred troops would lay all Sicily at our feet—we must declare Messina an English port. We could then protect Sicilian trade from the Barbary states and turn all the inhabitants in our favour." Miles had already told Ball that the Sicilian people as a whole would favor an annexation by Britain, that the men of property said so privately, even if they dared not say so publicly, while "the lower and industrious class to a man would fight for our cause."³⁹

In August 1804 Ball was suggesting that since the king derived few advantages from the possession of Sicily, he might, rather than run the risk of having it taken over by France, be ready to accept compensation in the form of an annual pension from Britain, while the latter took over the island herself.⁴⁰ There is no reason to believe that these views were ever shared by any British cabinet, but when four years later they were first aired in the columns of the British press (although then Leckie, and not Ball, was responsible for their publication), they caused not unnaturally some alarm and also suspicion at the court of Palermo—suspicion that was to be deepened further by subsequent British publications and finally by the disclosure of the private views of Lord William Bentinck.

The difference of opinion between Elliot and the heads of the British armed services about taking action over Sicily was resolved in the end by a compromise, which took the form of a secret agreement between Britain and the court at Naples. Messina and Syracuse were to be garrisoned by the 2,000 Neapolitan troops sent to Malta in 1802 and returned to Sicily in July 1803; Messina's citadel was to be repaired; gunboats were to patrol the straits; the people of Calabria were to be armed; and the king's forces in Sicily were to be put on a footing for war. To meet the expenses incurred by all this, the British government promised Naples £170,000 and thereafter an annual subsidy of £150,000, which if Naples was involved in hostilities could be increased to £300,000. And to make sure it got value for its money, it sent an experienced British officer, nominated by Ball and Villettes, to report on the progress of the fortifications. This officer, Colonel Layard, stayed in Messina for nearly two years, keeping in touch with Elliot and Ball, and was ready to give them early warning of any hostile movements from Italy.⁴¹

Meanwhile it was agreed that Nelson should keep a warship in the Bay of Naples ready to take off the royal family, if the French started to advance on the capital; and a year later Villettes was instructed to send 2,000 of his troops to Messina if Elliot should deem it necessary.

The eventual enforced resignation of Acton meant in effect that the queen was once more in control of foreign policy. It was she who, against the king's

wish, was to turn to Russia and also to Britain for help in getting the French expelled, and to get the czar to dispatch to Corfu 10,000 troops for use in Italy. The court of Naples in 1805 was playing a dangerous double game. On the one hand, through its envoy in Paris, it had signed a treaty of neutrality with France, which the king in Naples then ratified, and that got the French army withdrawn from its territory. Yet at the moment of that ratification it signed a military alliance with Russia and invited a Russian army to land, supported by a very much smaller British one. This was to be an act of bad faith that Napoleon was never to forgive, and it was to cause him to proclaim the end of Bourbon rule in Naples.

The ever-present threat by Napoleon, once he crowned himself king of Italy, to take over the kingdom of Naples had been a source of continuing anxiety not only to Britain but also to Russia, now firmly based in the Ionian islands with 11,000 troops and a large naval force and ready to resist any French threat to Turkey. Russia had throughout 1804 been urging Britain to send troops to Calabria, while Britain in turn had been pressing Russia for a force of 15,000 men to join with her in a joint expedition to free all of Italy from the French.⁴² But the signing of any sort of agreement had been inhibited by several factors: the British inability to provide a force of more than 5,000 at a time when their own shores were faced with invasion, and Pitt's recent policy decision to commit no large force to the Mediterranean; the Russians' dislike of committing themselves until Austria had shown her hand; and above all the Russians' suspicions that the British were only concerned with Sicily, where British troops would be little use in helping the allied cause on the mainland. Back in the summer of 1803, the Russian *chargé d'affaires* in Naples had warned Acton against British ambitions,⁴³ and eighteen months later the queen had shown Elliot letters received from her envoy in Petersburg urging her to distrust the British. It seemed to the czar they were interested only in embroiling Europe in a general war, from which they would shortly seek to escape, retaining Sicily as a British possession. The czar, it was said, was most unwilling for the keys of Sicily to be given to Britain.⁴⁴ These Russian suspicions were not justified, but it does seem from what Harrowby, the then-foreign secretary, wrote to Elliot on 5 November 1804 that the cabinet was very interested in developing Sicily's military potential as a source of manpower for future operations conducted in the Mediterranean.¹ Harrowby envisaged that if the king was forced to take refuge in Sicily, a considerable proportion of his army could then be enlisted in British pay. This force, commanded by British officers, could become a very efficient army, and though initially at the service of the king, it could later be made available to serve elsewhere in the Mediterranean.⁴⁵

By the spring of 1805, however, the difficulties with Russia had been overcome, even if Russia's suspicions remained in the minds of her diplomats if not of her soldiers. On 11 April 1805 an Anglo-Russian treaty was signed

providing for the protection of Naples and for the expulsion of the French from Italy. Meanwhile a force of 5,000 men under General Craig was sent out from England, destined initially for Malta, but ultimately for Italy. Craig had orders to place himself at the disposal of the Russian commander, and British transports were to convey Russian troops from Corfu to Naples. But the principal object of Craig's expedition, as was made clear in his secret instructions, was the safeguarding of the island of Sicily. On no account, his orders ran, were the French to be allowed on the island, and if they did succeed in landing, they must be expelled without delay. If French action should compel the king once more to seek asylum in Sicily, or if under extreme French pressure, he were to close his ports to the British, then Craig must at once take hold of Sicily. Over this decision he was accorded complete freedom to act on his own, although he was told that if circumstances permitted, he should work with Nelson, Elliot, and Ball.⁴⁶

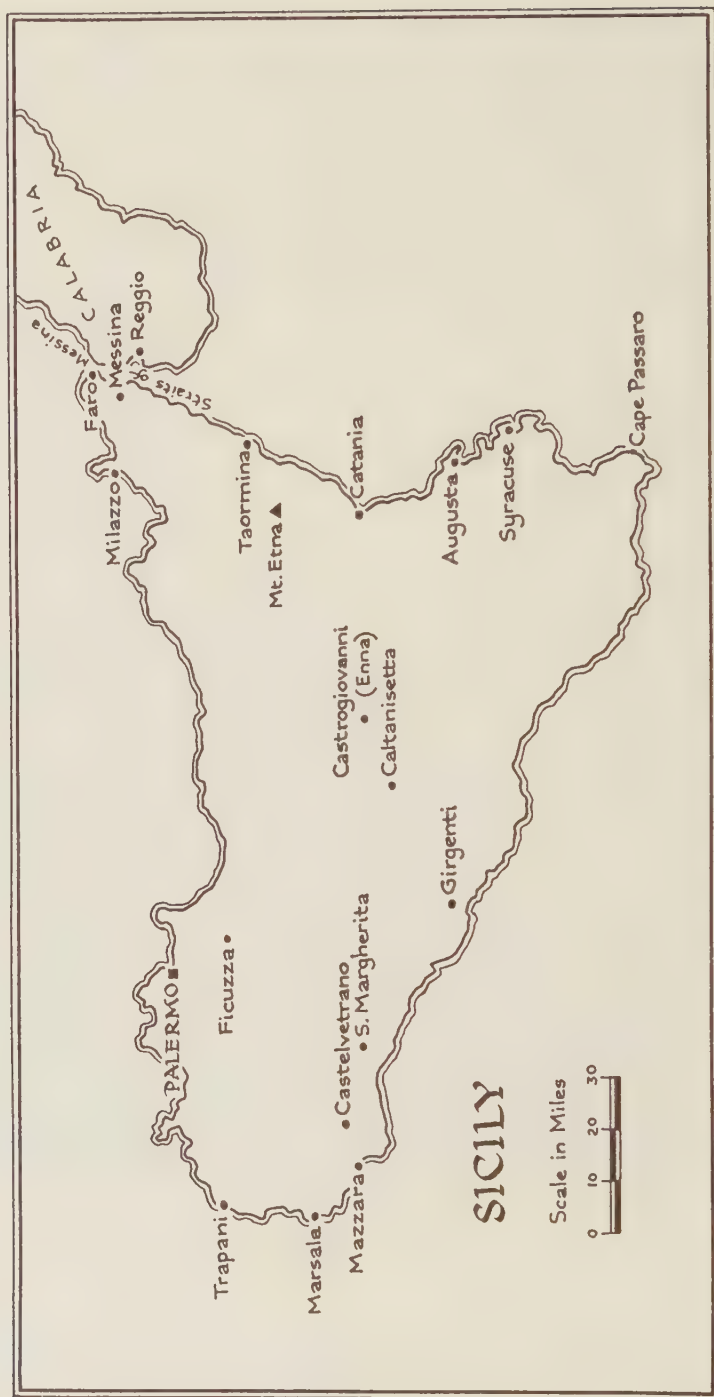
At the same time a British officer, Lt. Colonel Smith, was dispatched to Sicily to report to Malta and then to London on the current state of Sicilian defenses; and to help him prepare his eventual report, he was sent copies of the recommendations made by Charles Stuart six years earlier. The conclusions to which Smith finally arrived were not very different from those of Stuart. The Sicilians, he found, were discontented and heartily disliked the French, but even so they might not resist if a force of 10,000 Frenchmen landed. The regular Neapolitan troops, dispersed throughout the island, were unreliable, especially the officers, while the principal military commanders were either useless or objects of ridicule. General Bourcard, a Swiss officer, had been two years in command in Sicily, yet he had never once stirred out of Palermo and knew nothing of the island's resources. Guillichini, in command at Messina, was an ex-naval captain from Tuscany, ignorant of military matters and obviously a person quite unsuited to command the island's principal fortress.

All the fortresses, apart from Messina, were wholly lacking in artillery, were generally of inferior construction, and were in a very poor state of repair. Palermo itself was indefensible. Syracuse suffered from a lack of guns and also lacked an adequate water supply. Messina alone was in good condition and with a garrison of 3,000 British soldiers could hold out, Smith thought, indefinitely. As for the island generally, he agreed with the verdict of General Stuart that it could only be defended by the local inhabitants. All this Smith reported to the court before returning home to England, and he thought the king and queen welcomed the idea of Sicily having a British garrison.⁴⁷

The landing of an Anglo-Russian force consisting of 13,000 Russian and 7,000 British troops under the command of General Maurice de Lacy, an aged but Anglophile Russian officer, in the bay of Naples in September 1805 and its hasty withdrawal a few months later, without ever having fired a shot,



General Sir James Henry Craig, attributed to Berczy. (*Courtesy of McCord Museum, McGill University, Montreal.*)



do not need recounting once again. It would never have landed in the first place had Napoleon not ordered General St. Cyr's withdrawal to meet the imminent Austrian threat, and he fully intended that St. Cyr should return once Austria had been defeated. Napoleon's victories at Ulm and Austerlitz made the presence of the Anglo-Russian force in the kingdom of Naples anachronistic. Even with the help of Neapolitan forces, most of whom were completely untrained, it was quite inadequate to defend Naples against the forces the French could muster. General de Lacy received an order to withdraw his army at once to Corfu, while Craig had already made the decision that to carry out his original instructions he must reembark and retire to Sicily. Yet while there remained the slightest hope in the minds of the queen and her advisers of negotiating with Napoleon, the court remained extremely anxious to prevent the British from landing in Sicily. Serious differences arose between Elliot and Craig over this question, Elliot supporting the court in its efforts over forty days to treat with Napoleon. Offers were made on behalf of the queen involving Ferdinand abdicating in favor of his eldest son and (though this was not known to Elliot) closing the ports to British ships. It was believed that Spain and Russia would lend the negotiations support, and Tatischeff, the Russian envoy in Naples, who was certainly no friend of the British, hinted to Neapolitan ministers that Britain intended to take over Sicily.⁴⁸ Initially the queen had desired the British force to remain near Naples to back her diplomacy by a show of force, but when Craig made clear he was leaving anyway, she had wanted the British to go to Malta. Writing to Damas, she fulminated at what she regarded as British cowardice: "The smell of gunpowder sickens the feeble organs of General Craig. . . . I am entirely disanglomanised."⁴⁹

Craig in fact went to Messina not Malta, although he took care not to land his force until invited by the king to do so. Elliot, who remained ingenuously satisfied that the queen's negotiations had some chance of success, told Craig that an uninvited landing would be treated by the court as a hostile act. Craig understandably showed irritation, sure that Elliot was being deceived. As Nelson had noted two years earlier, the court at Naples had not found it difficult to hoodwink this British minister.⁵⁰

Writing to Castlereagh on 11 February, Craig told him his original intention had been to make for the port of Augusta, much more capacious than that of Messina, but had decided the risk of leaving the latter open to the French was one it was too great to take. They might slip across 5,000 troops before the British were aware they had done so, and since Collingwood and the British fleet had had to leave the Mediterranean, there was no squadron at hand to deter them. Now that the French were established in Venice and in Venice's ports in the Adriatic, Sicily appeared to be all the more vital to British interests in the Mediterranean. The court and Elliot had seemed to

think he intended to land without permission, but in the existing circumstances he saw no necessity to do so.⁵¹

In early February the disagreement between Craig and Elliot was brought to an end by the steady advance of the French army, and the "existing circumstances" mentioned by Craig were a reference to the king's decision to leave Naples and take refuge in Sicily. Napoleon had never had the least intention of yielding to the requests of the queen. "The dynasty of Naples has ceased to reign," he had publicly pronounced at Pressburg, and his brother Joseph was to seize the kingdom. On 9 February the king sailed for Palermo, followed shortly by the queen and her entourage, and once in Sicily, on Acton's prompting, he visited Messina and allowed Craig to land.⁵² In the third week in February British troops took over Messina. They were not to leave it for another nine years.

Julian Corbett describes these events as "the last stroke of the Trafalgar campaign," by which the British were able to avert the full consequences of Ulm and Austerlitz.⁵³ And there is no doubt that if the British had not been able to command the straits from their firm base in Messina citadel, having first removed all boats from the mainland as well as the coastal artillery, the French, pursuing the routed elements of the Neapolitan army of Damas, could have crossed with ease into Sicily and so gone on to threaten Malta and the whole command of the Mediterranean.

Sicily as the British Found It in 1806

Sicily was different from mainland Italy. This difference arose partly because the island lay so close to the coast of north Africa, and after its conquest by the Arabs retained a very strong African connection that lasted into the sixteenth century; and partly because it became and remained, for a period of over four hundred years, a kingdom annexed to the throne of Spain and was administered separately from other Spanish possessions in Italy. When Ferdinand IV of Naples became King Ferdinand III of Sicily, succeeding his father Charles III, there were few ties of affinity between the Neapolitans and the Sicilians. The African and the Spanish connections had bred in the people of Sicily a complacent sense of isolation from what went on in the rest of Europe.²

The period of the African connection had been one of great prosperity and vigor, intellectual as well as material, and the Arab influence on Sicily's culture persisted throughout the reign of the Normans and of the Suabian, Frederick II. The exotic flavor of the court at Palermo, where Arab and Byzantine influence intermingled, made it entirely different from any other court to be found in Europe.³

The Aragonese and then the Spanish connections (once the thrones of Aragon and Castile were united), which began at the end of the thirteenth century (when Peter of Aragon was called in to replace the detested Angevin), resulted in Sicily becoming still more distinct from neighboring Italy. Sicily welcomed Spanish rule, and in spite of periodic revolts, was for long considered a loyal province; most Sicilians looked on themselves as closer to Spaniards than to Italians.⁴ But this meant that Sicily was also cut off from that flowering of Italian culture that began in the age of Giotto and Dante and blossomed into the Italian Renaissance. Its isolation was further increased by the introduction there of the Spanish Inquisition.⁵ This last was responsible, needless to say, for effectively strangling free enquiry, so that all the rebirth of learning and science that illuminated so much of Europe in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries had little effect on the island of Sicily.

There were other respects in which Sicily's distinctness from Italian life was made manifest. The island boasted of having a parliament that dated back to the early Middle Ages and that at the end of the eighteenth century was still possessed of its liberties. That this fossilized relic of past history, surrounded

as it was by both myth and romance, was now merely a bastion of privilege and had been largely responsible for keeping Sicily poor and backward does not alter the fact that it was extraordinary and indeed very nearly unique. In the whole of Europe—outside of Sicily, only England and Corsica could boast of parliaments that had remained intact.⁶ Also in contrast to other countries, at the end of the eighteenth century when the European aristocracies had lost much of their power (and were trying desperately to regain it) and most if not all of their feudal privileges, the nobles in Sicily had hung on to theirs. Henry Swinburne—an English traveller to the island—remarked in 1785 how the Sicilian baronage were more independent of royal authority than were the barons in the kingdom of Naples, and exercised more control of their vassals. In Sicily, the lord of the manor seemed to operate without restraint:

He appoints to every place of jurisdiction and trust; civil and criminal law are both distributed by his creatures . . . in general the barons have disposal of everything within their manor.⁷

While a Frenchman visiting Sicily in 1778 could write:

The Sicilians, remote from their king, whom they know only by his representative, are accustomed to consider him as a pensioner whom they defraud of his due; while they pride themselves in granting free gifts, and from time to time make experiments of disobedience, with the sole view of performing an act that may assist their freedom.

The Sicilians have had so many sovereigns that they are accustomed to like none of them, and to give the preference only to him, with whom they can make the best conditions.⁸

He also commented on what he described as their “insular and republican character.” Even the Catholic Church in Sicily was remote and cut off from the continent. Subjection to Rome was minimal in matters ecclesiastical and all holders of senior church appointments were nominated to their posts by the crown. The king of Sicily in his own person was apostolic delegate, and the court of *monarchia*, which enjoyed supreme jurisdiction in church affairs, was presided over by a judge who was a royal appointee.⁹

Sicily in 1806 was, as it had remained for centuries, “a traditionalist and static society” (to use the words of Professor Mack Smith), and all attempts by its foreign rulers during the eighteenth century to change it to conform with modern ideas in keeping with the Enlightenment had in every case encountered failure. What the British found, when they came to the island, was a country that for historical reasons was so backward it was a century behind the most advanced of the western states. Nelson in the summer of 1803 described Sicily’s condition as “almost as bad as a civilised country’s can

be," with a population so discontented it would welcome even the hated French, if that meant any change for the better.¹⁰ He was merely echoing Sir Arthur Paget, who had told Grenville in 1800 that the state of the island was so wretched and corrupt that "nothing useful can be effective but by the introduction and direct influence of foreigners." There were several others who shared this opinion. Colonel Bunbury, on General Craig's staff, remarked on the welcome the British received when they first landed in 1806; he noted that if a few of the merchants had appeared at first to favor the French, this was out of no love for the latter but because "they longed for better laws" and some "relief from capricious tyranny." And the French they reckoned were more likely to stay, while the British would only be "birds of passage."¹¹

The Abbate Balsamo, who was Nelson's contemporary and an expert agronomist among other things, saw the difference between the Sicilian laborer and his counterparts in Western Europe as similar to that between the Sicilians and the savage tribes of Africa or America.¹² The plight of the peasant was hard indeed. He lived in a state of extreme poverty, seeing the profits from agriculture passing into the hands of a tiny minority—the income of the richest prince (Butera) equalled one-tenth of the national revenue, or so it was reckoned in 1810. He was often forced to live in the open, no matter how inclement the weather, or to return to his village late at night, since his place of work was so far from his home. The peasant was ill-clothed, ill-housed, very close to starvation, burdened by all sorts of dues and taxes, ignorant of modern methods of farming, short of capital and clinging desperately and obstinately to outdated customs. The Scots landowner Gould Francis Leckie, who at the end of the eighteenth century had farmed land round Syracuse, had endeavored to introduce new farming methods, but according to the traveller John Galt, who visited Sicily in 1810, few had followed his example.¹³

Though once the granary of the Roman Empire, Sicily by the start of the nineteenth century could scarcely produce enough to feed itself. Only a third of the land was cultivated and this so badly that it produced no more than a third of what it might have. The main reasons for the shortage of corn lay in the increased population, which by 1800 was half as much again what it had been in 1700, and in a shift in the population from the country areas to the towns.¹⁴ But the inefficiency of the system by which the corn was marketed, as well as the unwillingness of cultivators and landlords to undertake agricultural improvements that would have ensured increased production and have maintained an export trade, was also a major contributory factor. The growing of greater quantities of cereal was not encouraged by government taxes on the export of corn and the consumption of flour. And the strict control of export licences benefited only the merchants of corn who "played the market" and manipulated prices. Peter Brydone, in his tour through

Sicily made in 1770, remarked how the duties on the export of wheat that he described as "exorbitant" had served to make corn a drug on the market and had been responsible for the ruin of farmers.¹⁵ Of the sum total of Sicily's harvest, a third was bought by the government at a price it fixed for its own convenience, and the rest was sold to monopolist corporations. The latter, not the market, controlled the price, and price controls led inevitably to a black market and to the bribery of officials.¹⁶

There were other reasons for the decline of the grain trade and for a falling off in production. The kind of hard grain that was grown in Sicily could not compete with the cheaper-priced soft grain that was able to be grown in milder climates. The discontinuance of granting long leases led to the removal of any incentive to improve the land or to use modern methods. Land was overcropped and exhausted, while the profits accruing to the landlords were not invested in agriculture but frittered away in conspicuous consumption by absentee landlords who lived in Palermo. Lack of roads and the high cost of transport also discouraged would-be improvers of the backward state of Sicilian farming, while the onset of the French revolutionary wars had dislocated all maritime trade.¹⁷

The plight of Sicilian agriculture had been made worse in recent times by a drought that had lasted for the past six years, and at the time that the British arrived, the appalling prospect of famine was looming. It seemed to the English ironical that in neighboring and barren Malta the markets were well supplied with corn, due to good management by the Governor Ball, while in Sicily there was starvation: "a glaring proof (Hugh Elliot wrote) of the . . . incapacity of this government,"¹⁸ though the reasons were more complex than Elliot realized.

There was very little manufacturing, although linen was made at Caltanissetta and silk was woven in Messina and Catania; and there was very little internal trade, not only because of the mountainous country, but also because roads and bridges were lacking and because there were so many local tolls. Even in the middle of the nineteenth century it cost more to carry goods to Palermo from the interior of the island than it did to transport them from Sicily to places as far off as Paris or London. The external trade of Sicily was closely linked to the mainland of Italy and to central and northern Europe. The war therefore was initially to have a harmful effect on this trade, and the loss of markets in France and Switzerland had serious results for silk production in the provinces of Messina and Catania.¹⁹

Another feature of Sicily's backwardness was its wholly corrupt judicial system, with a complexity of different laws seemingly designed to produce the maximum confusion. Because of delays in the dispensing of justice, people no longer looked to the courts but preferred the protection of a powerful noble. Judges were ignorant or subject to court pressure, torture

was used to extract confessions, and orders could be obtained from the king for proscriptions, confiscations, and arbitrary arrests (much in the manner of *lettres de cachet* during the ancien régime in France) to satisfy some private vendetta or enrich the magistrate involved.²⁰

The vast majority of Sicilians in a population of a million and a half were either peasants or poor townspeople; Palermo's population numbered 200,000 and absorbed most of the wealth of the country. There was much jealousy of the capital on the part of towns like Catania and Messina, and Palermo's claims to jurisdictions were challenged by its principal rival, Messina. There was practically no middle class, but numerous clergy and a few thousand nobles. In what was still in many ways a feudal society, the Sicilian nobility controlled the island, some of its members being extremely rich. In fact, as a class, the nobility were far more wealthy than was the crown, holding in towns and lands in the island three times as much as the king. Even so, the greater part of the noble families was heavily in debt. It was said that it was almost as difficult to find a nobleman out of debt as it was to find one who was well-informed, and though the revenues of a few families were nominally very great, these were the families that were most in debt. This explains why the nobles as a class were eager, when a new constitution was drafted, as it was in 1812, to be rid of their feudal obligations to the crown, while insisting on being paid compensation for the extinction of their feudal rights over the peasants. They possessed the means to oppress the poor through the exaction of these feudal rights and enjoyed all sorts of privileges and jurisdictions in both town and country. Under the reforming viceroy Caracciolo, toward the end of the eighteenth century, enlightened reforms had been set in train to restrict the nobles' privileges, put an end to monopolies, and help the peasants to get credit more easily. But the peasants were unwilling to change their ways, and the abolition of villeinage merely created landless laborers.²¹ In any case, the French Revolution brought all enlightened reforms to a halt. Drummond, the British minister at Palermo, writing in the spring of 1807, compared the state of Sicily to that of England under the Plantagenets, even if the nobles did not keep private armies.²² In the view of the Scotsman Francis Leckie, the nobles as a class were "ignorant beyond belief" and were very largely responsible for the "abject wretchedness of the people."²³

The Sicilian parliament, which was summoned to meet only once in four years, consisted of three *bracci* or estates of the realm: *militare* or noble, *ecclesiastico* or clerical, and *demaniale* or communes of the royal domain. Its powers were limited to granting *donativi* (the name implying gifts not taxes) to supplement the ordinary income of the crown, present petitions for redress of grievances, and elect a body of royal nominees whose task was to collect the taxes and administer the laws between sessions of parliament. In the

braccio of peers, a nobleman had as many votes as he had feudal estates, and Prince Butera with his nine towns, over which he exercised jurisdiction, was therefore entitled to no less than nine votes in the Sicilian parliament.

The fiscal system was quite inequitable, with its burdens falling not on luxuries but on articles of daily consumption. There was no register of land and taxes on property were based on self-assessments, while the nobles resisted strenuously any attempts to survey their lands.²⁴ The king had been forced by his need for money to sell annuities secured on the customs to monopolistic corporations, yet his court, while in Sicily, made no attempt to live in any way economically. Neapolitan and French émigrés either occupied the posts at court or drew state pensions at Sicilian expense—they were a host of parasites, some far from reputable, and a cause of much bitterness among native Sicilians.²⁵ The king foolishly, though perhaps understandably, in order to uphold his independence tried to maintain an army and navy as well as diplomatic representation at all the principal courts of Europe, something that the slender royal revenues, even when bolstered by British subsidies, found it extremely hard to finance.

King Ferdinand, in whose person was united sovereignty over the two kingdoms of Naples and of Sicily, spent very little of his time at court, preferring the retired life of a country gentleman with sporting tastes. He had a passion for shooting and fishing, and showed little interest in the business of government, which he was glad to leave to the queen. Although lacking in formal education, he was neither a dolt nor a simpleton, possessing a certain native shrewdness that he used in his dealings with the British. He was moody, extremely obstinate, and had fixed ideas about his royal prerogatives that were similar to those of the queen. His common touch and earthy *bonhomie* commended him to the Naples *lazzaroni* who had nicknamed him “Nasone” for obvious reasons, but underneath he remained a despot, and a vindictive one at that.²⁶ One Frenchman has described him as being *populacier plutôt que populaire* (common rather than popular), though when he first arrived in Palermo the people welcomed him very warmly. Only when they came to realize that he looked on Sicily merely as a place for furnishing him with the means by which he could pay his court and recover Naples did their attitude toward him change. For on one subject he was singleminded—the recovery of his Neapolitan throne. As he was to write in 1814: “I will never renounce what God has given me and my father left me and which in justice belongs to me and also to my successors, nor ever agree to accept compensation.”²⁷ Even then it was the queen and ministers rather than the king himself who attracted unpopularity.

The queen of Naples, Maria-Carolina, has been portrayed so often in print that her character must be familiar to most people. A strange, contradictory, and pathetic person, she was a compound of restless energy, passion, charm, and utter ruthlessness, swayed by every momentary occurrence or the most

casual and idle rumor. Robert Fagan, British consul general in Palermo and a man to whom she unburdened herself, described her as "either exhilarated to excess or engulfed in a chaos of imaginary and gigantic evils."²⁸

She had all the pride of her Hapsburg mother, the formidable Empress Maria-Theresa, and the political amorality of her wretched sister, the French Queen Marie-Antoinette. General Moore, first deputy and then commander of the British force in Sicily in 1807, decided in the end that she was not really wicked, but only badly guided by those about her. It was her misfortune, in his opinion, to feel that she must meddle in public affairs for which she had no capacity.²⁹ Admiral Collingwood, who commanded the fleet in the Mediterranean from 1805 to 1810 and had some dealings with the queen, shared Moore's views to a large extent. "She would be thought a deep politician, yet all her schemes miscarry. She broods over what is impracticable with her little means, and frets herself continually that others are not as dim-sighted as herself."³⁰ She chose to be surrounded by a network of spies and employed agents all over Italy, as well as maintaining in her pay chiefs of the partisans or *masse* (often no more than brigand bands) in the mountains of Calabria and the Abruzzi. It was estimated that she spent a million and a half ducats in maintaining this system of spies and informers, many of whom proved double agents in the pay of Saliceti, the chief of police in Naples. But all her intrigues in Naples, Rome, Tuscany, and Genoa, London, St. Petersburg, and Vienna in the end had very little effect. She did exercise some influence, though not as much as was once thought, in Sicily, over the king and her sons. By 1806 she had really become in many ways a tragic figure, worn out by personal misfortune, childbearing, and miscarriages, which had driven her to take opium daily. She loathed Sicily and its inhabitants, talked sometimes of selling the island, and longed only to return to Naples, the recovery of which was her main preoccupation. In the winter of 1798 she had described Palermo as being "poverty-stricken, and peopled by rogues, where the price of everything is exorbitant and the climate depressing," and she never altered this initial opinion. Of the Sicilians themselves she wrote, "the priests are completely corrupted, the people savage, the nobles of doubtful loyalty. . . . I ought not to govern Sicilians I hate them and, if they were as honest as I am, the King and the Hereditary Prince would say the same, for they think the same." She in turn was detested in Sicily and was so unpopular that, when her son the hereditary prince was seriously ill (possibly from food poisoning), it was widely rumored that the queen had poisoned him in order to recover her influence.³¹ She, who had been devoted to the British in the days of Nelson and Emma Hamilton, was now convinced that they were only concerned to keep Sicily for themselves and had no real interest in recovering Naples. The only Englishmen she liked were those who were ready to flatter her and forward her schemes for campaigns on the mainland for the recovery of the kingdom of Naples—Admirals Nelson and Sidney Smith and, for a

time, General John Stuart; she liked the British ministers at Palermo, Sir William Hamilton, William Drummond and, for a few years, Hugh Elliot, and the consul general, Robert Fagan. She hated Hamilton's successor Paget, the two generals, Fox and Moore, and particularly Lord William Bentinck, who was to be responsible for her enforced exile from Sicily, so that she was later led to declare that when she saw an Englishman she felt the guillotine on her neck. Even though she intensely disliked the French, seeing them always as the murderers of her sister and oppressors of all monarchies, she was quite prepared to intrigue with them, if only to get rid of the British. She loathed the ideas of the French Revolution and had no love for the Bonapartes, though the personality of Napoleon had an awful fascination for her. She told her confidant the Marquis de Gallo that she considered Napoleon "the greatest man of the century" and that for him, as a person, she had "a really deep respect." She said she hoped his schemes would fail, but wished him personal glory and good fortune, so long as they were not "at our expense."³² She was quite unscrupulous in her methods, and Joseph Bonaparte believed not only that had she placed a price on his head, but that she had tried to have a plague-ridden ship driven onto the coast of Naples. In the end she became the scapegoat for everything that went wrong in Sicily, although it is not difficult to understand the desire of the British to see the last of her.

Her remaining children (only six remained of the seventeen to whom she had given birth) were married into Europe's royal families—her daughters to the Hapsburg Emperor Francis, the Spanish Prince of Asturias, the brother of the king of Sardinia (in 1807), and the duke of Orleans (in 1809), while her eldest son, the hereditary prince, found a second wife in the Spanish Infanta. The hereditary prince and her youngest son Leopold (who was completely dominated by his mother) and her two then-unmarried daughters (Maria-Amelia and Maria-Christine) all accompanied the court to Sicily. (Both the empress of Austria and the princess of Asturias were dead before the end of 1807.)

Francis, the hereditary prince, was at the age of thirty-five still largely under parental influence. Interested like his father almost solely in country pursuits, he found himself after 1810 compelled to play a political role. Though he seemed to go along with the British when appointed by his father as vicar general, he had little real sympathy with their views on Sicily and remained a Neapolitan at heart.

As to ministers and court officials, the man who wielded the greatest influence when the British first became concerned with Sicily was the Anglo-philic Sir John Acton, a former favorite of the queen, although he had lost her favor completely. His eventual retirement was due, however, as much to old age and growing incapacity as to the jealousy of the queen. For many years he had been the real directing hand in Naples. He was not, in the opinion of William Drummond who briefly succeeded Paget as envoy, a very profound

politician, and one who was happy to wait on events, but nevertheless the only man who in Drummond's words could hold the helm "of a crazy vessel, in very stormy times."³³ Forced in May 1804 to withdraw to Palermo by pressure from Napoleon, he continued to advise the king from Sicily and be sent diplomatic correspondence. When the royal family were once again forced to leave Naples and flee to Palermo, Acton regained for a short time his former dominant position, since his rival at court, the Count Damas, was blamed for the rout of the army of Naples. His sudden return to power, however, lasted a matter of less than four months, and he finally retired in June 1806, having become a sort of Polonius.³⁴

The man chosen to take his place, the Marquis Circello, was not a strong character. The British first thought that he was on their side, but they soon realized he was no match for the queen and was incapable of influencing royal policy. The court adopted measures without his knowledge, and his sense of loyalty toward the crown forced him to accept them without any protest. William Drummond thought little of his abilities—"no minister of foreign affairs was more foreign to those affairs than he"; while Lord William Bentinck, a few years later, contrived to have him removed from office for having "entirely despotic" principles.³⁵

The queen surrounded herself at Palermo with a group of advisers who were wholly non-Sicilian: Tatischeff, the Russian minister until 1808, Kaunitz, the Austrian minister until 1810, Roger Count de Damas, the French émigré (though he left Sicily in 1806), Corsicans who were anti-Bonapartist, and Neapolitans like Circello, and Medici, the minister of finance, perhaps her most able and loyal servant (despite his dubious prior career as a suspected Jacobin), Prince Moliterno (of whom more later), and the young and romantic Prince Canosa, the so-called "Don Quixote of reaction," whom she dispatched to the island of Ponza to try and raise a rebellion in Naples.

She was also surrounded by humbler men, some of them near-criminals, the most notorious among whom were Colonel Carbone and Marquis Castrone.³⁶ The only others who counted for something in a court dominated by Neapolitans and French were the Duke of Ascoli, an agent of the king, and the Marquis Saint Clair, the queen's secretary and (so gossip had it) her secret lover.

Ascoli was the king's private secretary and had considerable influence with him, partly because he was a good sportsman and shared the king's mania for shooting and fishing. Ascoli did not like Sicilians any more than he liked the British. He was in turn disliked by the queen, who was jealous of anyone who challenged her influence. Ascoli had been head of the police in Naples, where he gained an unsavory reputation for brutality and the abuse of power. In Sicily he supported the king in his role as unchallenged sovereign and urged him in 1811–12 to resist the demands being made on him by the British for constitutional and administrative reform, to the extent even of

abdicating and seeking refuge at some foreign court. He favored taking extreme measures, even if this meant civil war or playing the game Napoleon wanted, rather than yielding to British pressure, though the king did not accept his advice. The British eventually forced him to leave and go into exile in Sardinia, but for a time he was virtual viceroy.³⁷

Castrone was another undesirable character, the protégé and confidant of the queen. He was the chief of police in Palermo and controlled the network of spies and agents with whom the queen surrounded herself, maintaining her contacts with mainland Italy and particularly with the kingdom of Naples. Together with the queen he ran a lucrative business in privateering and piracy, the profits from which went to maintain this whole system of informers and agents.³⁸ While Castrone operated from Palermo, Carbone based himself on Messina, was instrumental in organizing flying columns of the Calabrian *masse* from 1806 to 1809, and collaborated with the English commanders. But he acted also as a spy on the English and reported all he heard back to the court, even though his truthfulness was profoundly suspect. He was appointed by the British to be head of their military secret service and was so well regarded by senior officers that in 1815 he was awarded a pension for life by the British government, on the recommendation of Lord William Bentinck.³⁹

The Marquis Saint Clair, an ex-French guards officer, possessed good looks but no real talent. Alquier, the French minister in Naples, had described him as less than a mediocrity. Though he was hated by the British as the representative of the pro-French faction, he hardly deserved the execration. Appointed tutor to Prince Leopold, he was merely the lap dog of the queen, and the senior posts he filled in the army gave him status but no effective power. He was honest and loyal to his mistress, and accompanied her when she went into exile.⁴⁰

Another favorite of the queen was the colorful condottiere Prince Moliterno, a dashing type of professional soldier, adventurous, physically brave, but lacking any political sense. The queen, who was herself a romantic, fell in easily with his wild schemes for the reconquest of the kingdom of Naples, and at one time of the whole of Italy. Even when the king was forced to concede the overall command of all forces in Sicily to a British officer, Lord William Bentinck, the court still attempted, unsuccessfully, to appoint Moliterno to a similar post. His military activities, as well as those he carried out as a double agent in correspondence with the French, made him yet another of those at court who aroused in the British the deepest suspicions of treachery or at least bad faith.⁴¹

Relations between the British in Sicily and the court at Palermo grew increasingly strained during the first five years of occupation, and eventually ended in the British government agreeing to active interference—something that most British cabinet ministers had studied studiously to avoid.

Problems of Defense in the Early Years of Occupation

Throughout 1806 and 1807 the prospect of the invasion of Sicily by a French army was a very real one. Napoleon did not cease to impress on his brother, now seated on the throne of Naples, the importance of taking Sicily. He could not tolerate that on Italy's doorstep there should remain (and in English hands) a smugglers' base, a refuge for deserters, a standing threat to the stability of his empire in Naples and elsewhere in Italy, and what he described as "an impassable barrier" to communications with the Levant. Only after the Treaty of Tilsit, signed in July 1807, which secured him Corfu and the Adriatic, did Napoleon lose interest in capturing the island. Sicily in theory remained desirable, if only to safeguard his base in Corfu, but from this point on he regarded it as of only secondary importance. Once he became committed to his plan for absorbing Spain and Portugal, Sicily was seen by him merely as a trap where British forces could be kept immobile that might otherwise oppose him in the peninsula.

But in 1806 he could not wait to have news of the capture of Sicily. "I would rather," he told Joseph, "a ten years war than leave your kingdom incomplete and Sicily an unsettled question."¹ Both he and Joseph had counted on making a quick dash across the straits of Messina in the wake of the routed army of Damas, and they had only been frustrated in this by Craig, who had taken away all the boats available as well as the guns from the coastal batteries. Joseph then insisted that he needed an army of no less than 25,000 men if ever a crossing was to succeed, a figure Napoleon considered ridiculous. According to the latter, a force of 10,000 or at the most 15,000 was all that could reasonably be required. Joseph had, so Napoleon told him, 15,000 more troops than he needed, and if he still could not take Sicily, not to mention the fortress of Gaeta whose garrison under the Prince of Hesse still held out against the French, then he would never be able to do so, even if given 100,000 men.²

Bonapartist plans for Sicily suffered a setback in July, when General Stuart's army landed in Calabria and won an impressive victory at Maida. But with Stuart's withdrawal shortly after and the fall of Gaeta in the autumn, preparations for the capture of the island were resumed. Nothing could be

done immediately, for the *masse* insurrection had to be crushed and the country cleared of brigand bands, but this was achieved by the spring of 1807. Even then, there still remained the British-held fortresses of Scilla and Reggio. These places the British had garrisoned at the time of their withdrawal following Maida, and their capture remained a precondition for any successful invasion of Sicily. Napoleon continued to pester Joseph throughout the summer and autumn of 1807 for their immediate reduction, finally issuing him a personal order to take them. By March 1808 they had both fallen and Sicily was once again faced with the prospect of invasion.³

When General Craig had arrived in Sicily in February 1806 he had found the island largely defenseless. On its long coastline, with its multiplicity of roadsteads, small bays, and open beaches, an enemy force could land very easily; and its main harbors, save for Messina, were lacking in the necessary means to defend them—artillery, stores, and also men. Colonel Smith had made this apparent in his report of the previous October when he stated that the island as a whole could only be defended by its inhabitants. The regular forces at the king's disposal were supposed to number 9,000 or thereabouts, but their effective strength, it transpired, was not much more than a third of this figure, and they were for the most part in very poor shape. As to the militia, it proved nonexistent for all practical purposes, a force without either clothes or pay or any sort of organization. Meanwhile Sicily remained dependent on Malta for guns and ammunition.⁴ Apart from the northeastern strip of the island occupied by the forces of Craig, its safety, as Elliot impressed on Collingwood, was wholly in the hands of the British navy, and the extent of the latter's protection would sway the loyalty of the Sicilians.⁵ Collingwood did in fact provide a substantial squadron to guard Sicily and keep watch on the enemy-held ports in the Tyrrhenian and Adriatic—four ships-of-the-line, eight frigates, and three sloops—while a sizeable flotilla of gunboats and galleys, including Neapolitan gunboats, was based on Messina to cover the straits. The formation of the Sicilian flotilla was a most important contribution to the effective defense of Sicily, since it was small craft that were needed in the narrow waters that separated Sicily from Calabria. It was manned by Sicilian volunteers who were only too willing to serve in vessels that flew the British flag, not the Neapolitan one.⁶ What remained of the Neapolitan navy was of very little immediate assistance, apart from the gunboats already mentioned—one ship-of-the-line and some frigates and sloops, but so neglected through lack of money they were little better than useless hulks. Later, though not until 1809, these ships were repaired at British expense in the naval dockyards at Gibraltar and Malta.

Lack of money in the next few years, despite a large subsidy paid by the British, continued to keep the king's regular army in a wretched state of inefficiency. It was badly trained and, in General Moore's view, did not possess a serviceable musket. Recruitment was a difficult problem because of

the inadequate rewards that were offered. The queen tried to enlist the *masse* and form them into regular units, but these people resented discipline. Criminals and Italian deserters from the French army were accepted as recruits, and the king ordered all means short of force, though he dared not use conscription, to encourage enlistment. General Fox found the Neapolitan troops totally undependable and despised by the *masse* and the people of Sicily. He regretted that the more reliable Sicilians were not kept apart from the Neapolitans, but the court "by the fatality that attends almost all their measures" made no attempt to separate them, and they lost all pride and esprit de corps.⁷

After the disaster at Mileto at the end of May 1807, when 6,000 men under the Prince of Hesse met with humiliating defeat, a rather more serious attempt was made to organize the royal army. The king and queen, with some reluctance, allowed its inspection by British generals, who were not impressed by what they found. Not only was the discipline poor—the officers discontented, the soldiers unpaid, pawning or selling their arms or deserting—but the higher command was unimpressive. Even Count Damas, favorite of the queen and certainly no lover of the British, was more damning in his verdict on the latter than any British general: "Hesse is a loyal and brave man, but very far from intelligent. Bourcard does not want to leave his beloved Sicily; baron Acton [brother of Sir John] is merely another edition of Hesse, while Cattolica is a fool. That is all I can say. In fact we have nobody."⁸

In 1806 attempts were made to raise a genuine force of militia, the court issuing an edict in May to enroll a force of 24,000. Yet a year later Colonel Bunbury, quartermaster general and chief of staff, reckoned that there was not a single militiaman in the whole of the district the British occupied. In 1808 Cattolica brought forward a plan to enlist 40,000 Sicilians, raised and commanded by local landowners, but this was opposed by the queen and the Neapolitans. The British command had no faith in the scheme and disapproved of it anyway as discouraging regular enlistment. There was already jealousy between the regulars and the volunteers over the question of rank and command, and there was no provision for unified control, let alone overall command by the British. In June 1809 there were reckoned to be a maximum of 1,500 militiamen in the whole of the island, outside Palermo, who were trained and equipped for general service. And the corps at Palermo the British considered to be fit for little save ceremonial occasions. The court did agree to the British embodying two battalions of Sicilian militia, but nothing ever came of this. At Augusta not a man turned up, and at Milazzo the 380 who did appear were of such poor quality (having been crimped or dragooned into joining) that they had to be instantly discharged.⁹

All this meant that Sicily's defenses continued to rest on the British alone, apart from any help from the peasants whom the court out of fear refused to

arm. Initially Craig had had to strip Malta in order to raise the strength of his force, but on his return soon after to England (giving up his command on grounds of ill-health) he persuaded the British ministers to reinforce the Sicily garrison. Guns and gun-carriages arrived, as well as two battalions of infantry, and General John Stuart, who succeeded Craig, was able to recruit 500 Sicilians, paid and clothed by the British government and officered largely not by Sicilians (to Colonel Bunbury's relief) but by members of the Corsican corps or by foreign regiments. By the early summer of 1806 Stuart had a force of 7,500 holding a defense line in northeast Sicily, which stretched from Milazzo in the north through Faro and Messina as far south as Taormina. The king then allowed him to extend his command further south to Cape Passaro to include the ports of Augusta and Syracuse, which, on the insistence of Collingwood, were to be garrisoned by British troops.¹⁰ Even so, the island enjoyed a security that was only relative. Moore, writing in 1807, took a typically pessimistic view of the prospects of defending it successfully. He thought it required 12,000 more troops, to include cavalry and artillery, in addition to the existing garrison, which then amounted to 14,000. More brigs, cutters, and small craft were needed, while the fortresses that were far too numerous but because they existed had to be manned were (save for ammunition) completely lacking in the means to resist an attack for long.¹¹

The glaring defect in these Sicilian defenses did not however prevent the island from being used for offensive purposes during the summer of 1806. The driving force behind the offensive was the British Admiral Sidney Smith, recently appointed commander of the fleet in the central Mediterranean. Pushing, vain, and irresponsible, the admiral arrived with a great reputation. Everyone had heard of his exploits, for he had a great gift for self-publicization: his daring raids on the French coast, his dramatic escape from the Temple prison, his triumphant relief of St. Jean d'Acre. A spoilt child of fortune, brave, dashing, seductive, he was (in the words of Jacques Rambaud) "only too ready to lend an ear to the flattery of an Italian court and become the champion of a distraught queen."¹² The latter, delighted to discover what she fondly imagined was another Nelson, played on Smith's obvious vanity, and decided, as she said, "to work on his feelings."¹³ On pleas from her, he took stores and ammunition to the garrison of besieged Gaeta, though without consulting anyone else. This infuriated Elliot, who prided himself that he alone could approach Acton and so the court.¹⁴

Smith raided the Calabrian coast, capturing guns and inciting revolt. He took Capri, got Stuart to garrison it, and then persuaded him to cooperate in a scheme to conquer the whole of Calabria. In fact the object of the expedition, which Stuart led with 5,000 troops who were landed in the Gulf of St. Euphemia, was to force the French from the toe of Italy, destroy their supply dumps, guns, and magazines, and so pre-empt an invasion of Sicily. In this



Admiral Sir William Sidney Smith, engraved by W. Say. (*Courtesy of the British Museum, London.*)



Major-General Sir John Stuart, engraved by A. Cardon. (*Courtesy of the British Museum, London.*)

Stuart was entirely successful, though his victory at Maida in July owed more to the action of his subordinates than to brilliance of leadership on his part. The French lost nearly 4,000 men and at Crotone, to which the British sent two regiments round by sea, they lost all their guns and warlike stores, accumulated for use against Sicily, as well as their army's sick and wounded that General Régnier had left behind.

Wisely refusing to pursue the French army with the limited force at his command and wisely refusing to commit a force of 1,000 men to reinforce Gaeta (a fortress that was on the point of falling), Stuart contented himself with capturing the strongpoints of Reggio and Scilla, the two places the French must hold before embarking on an invasion of Sicily. It should be remembered that in doing all this he had acted entirely without instructions, his only orders from London being to safeguard Sicily against attack.¹⁵

During the course of these operations, Sidney Smith had obtained from Ferdinand a commission to act as the viceroy of Calabria, with command of all the king's forces there, and this not unnaturally had annoyed Stuart. The latter through Elliot and Acton made strong representations to the court and as a result Smith had to step down and accept Stuart as commander-in-chief.¹⁶ But he did succeed in involving Stuart in schemes, which were really those of the queen, for raising the Calabrian *masse*. Stuart was unwisely persuaded to issue an inflammatory proclamation inciting the Calabrians to rise, an action that the ministry in London found a source of some embarrassment. Stuart, though acclaimed for his victory and rewarded by being made a Knight Commander of the Bath, was all the same rebuked (although mildly) for the indiscretion of his proclamation. The government, he was told, could not guarantee indefinite protection for the people of Calabria, and in taking his action he should first have obtained the approval of the British Minister Elliot.¹⁷ Stuart shortly afterward resigned out of pique at being passed over for command and was replaced by General Henry Fox, the younger brother of the statesman, while General John Moore was sent out to act as Fox's deputy and second-in-command. Henry Fox was a sick man and known by the ministers to be such, so his reliance on John Moore, where decisions or actions were required, was something that was accepted in London.

Meanwhile Sidney Smith, in the words of Bunbury, "always panting for distinction . . . restlessly active"¹⁸ and bursting with enthusiasm, spread his ships and small craft along the coast as far north as the bay of Naples, scattering his proclamations to revolt. Moore blamed him, perhaps unfairly, for concentrating on these activities rather than trying to relieve Gaeta, and for taking credit for capturing towns that had either already been abandoned or must have fallen to the British army as it fell back on Scilla and Reggio. Smith kept pressing Elliot and Fox for more money and more men, urging that these were all that were needed to drive the French out from the kingdom of Naples. Moore, who was the real driving force behind the less



decisive and ailing Fox, had to point out that it was not the intention of the British command to tie up its forces in Calabria, more so since the French had been reinforced. The Calabrians anyway were hopelessly divided, with property owners siding with the French and the *masse* intent on rapine and murder. The main object of the British forces must remain the defense of Sicily, and the navy's small craft ought to be used not in conducting futile raids but in intercepting the coastal traffic.

Moore was sent by Fox to investigate what Sidney Smith was really doing, and, having landed at various points, he came to the conclusion Smith's ideas were absurd. Moore found the people frightened and disheartened, ready to hoist, as danger dictated, either the Bourbon or republican flag and occupied only in plundering or satisfying some private vengeance. He thought it not only an act of cruelty but one unbecoming to the British name to encourage this kind of hopeless insurrection unless the British intended to stay. On behalf of Fox he therefore told Smith to abstain from any further promises of British assistance to chiefs of the *masse*; Fox alone must now be responsible for help afforded to the Calabrians.¹⁹ Smith however remained firm in his conviction of the rightness of his strategy and that Sicily "could not be defended militarily or maintained politically without Calabria as a *tête du pont* and as a magazine and mart."²⁰

Elliot, who was sensitive on questions affecting protocol and his position as minister, wrote home privately to complain of Sidney Smith's irregular behavior: his direct communications with the queen, his importunate requests for funds, and his misapplication of those funds, granted for the purpose of obtaining intelligence.²¹ Smith eventually received from the Admiralty a mild reproof (though he described it as "most mortifying"),²² but he nevertheless remained the queen's ally in her plans for the reconquest of Naples until his posting away the following January. There is no doubt that Sidney Smith had found in Stuart a ready collaborator, and the latter's departure meant that the army was no longer prepared to indulge Smith's schemes. Henry Fox wrote home to his brother that Calabria had become for Stuart "in a degree his hobby horse" and that he had "in the vagabond *massi* [sic]" a confidence he thought no one else had. Stuart was, in Fox's opinion, not without his share of vanity and he had more confidence in the court than Fox had, because Stuart had been misled by its flattery and failed to realize how much it was despised.²³

After defeating the Prussians at Jena in October 1806, Napoleon had advanced into Poland but had then been checked and had retired onto Warsaw. Russian ministers in foreign courts gave out that the French had been defeated, and the court at Palermo, and the queen especially, were only too ready to believe this story. In consequence the queen, through Circello, pressed hard for another expedition to be dispatched to mainland Italy, suggesting that this was desirable, if only for political reasons. If a general



Calabrian brigand. Early nineteenth-century print. (*Courtesy of Mrs. Joan Streatfield.*)



Lieutenant-General Henry Edward Fox, engraved by C. Turner. (Courtesy of the British Museum, London.)

peace were concluded, she argued, it might well be on the basis of *uti possidetis*, and of course if the French defeated the Prussians, the British could always withdraw to Sicily.²⁴ But quite apart from the fact that Britain had never guaranteed the recovery of Naples, Circello's proposal was unacceptable. As General Fox explained to his brother, such an expedition was bound to call down a superior army of the French, who had ample reserves in the north of Italy. Moreover there were few on the mainland who genuinely supported the Bourbon cause, and most Calabrians gave their support only to the party that appeared the strongest and that promised them the maximum personal gain. To send a force to Italy now would divide the army in Sicily, weaken the defenses of that island, and prevent a decisive blow being struck when the opportunity eventually offered. He regarded the plan to send

Hesse to Naples with an army of 8,000 royal troops to cooperate with a British army (even supposing a force of that size could be raised at that time in Sicily) as both "chimerical and absurd." Masséna, he reckoned, was far too experienced to make the mistake of Régnier at Maida, and anyway he was so strongly positioned, he could choose freely which force to attack.²⁵

Two months earlier, Admiral Collingwood had already voiced very similar views. Writing to Elliot in July, he had expressed considerable skepticism about the wisdom of capturing Capri, an island without either a port or a roadstead, which could hardly be reckoned to be of much use in preventing the passage of coastal traffic. As for an expedition to Naples, he regarded it as "the vainest dream that ever entered the imagination of a woman":

When they [the Bourbons] possessed it, with all the resources of the country at their command, with the (professed at least) loyalty of an armed people, and the army of the allies at their head, it was abandoned as untenable; and now that the country is disarmed . . . and the enemy possessing every place of strength, on what foundation can the hope of success be built?²⁶

Even the fall of Gaeta fortress Collingwood considered no bad thing, all attempts to support its resistance having taken ships from more useful tasks, exhausted Sicily of war stores, and reduced British strength in guns and men.

Drummond, who had returned to Sicily in February 1807 to take up once again the post he had relinquished in 1803—Fox, since Elliot's departure, having filled in both as minister at Palermo and military commander—was also convinced, at least initially, that the time was not ripe for invading Italy, and took offense at Circello's attitude.²⁷ But the queen was not to be put off so easily, even if it meant an expedition consisting only of Neapolitans, and Fox discovered that without any notice the royal troops in the British area had been withdrawn from his command.²⁸



Admiral Lord Cuthbert Collingwood, by H. Howard. (*Courtesy of the National Portrait Gallery, London.*)

The Court, William Drummond, and the British Generals

A deep distrust obtaining between the court at Palermo and the British government, further exacerbated as it was to be by the strained relations that soon developed between Drummond and the British generals, became apparent in 1806. Negotiations for peace with Napoleon had been conducted by Charles James Fox, foreign secretary in the Ministry of All the Talents, during the months of June and July, and fears were expressed by Acton and Circello that the British saw Sicily as expendable; they wanted to force the king to exchange it for territory in, perhaps, the Balearics.¹ It was true that the Russian plenipotentiary had agreed to accept such terms from the French, but the czar had refused to ratify them, and Britain never agreed to them. Drummond was instructed to refute vigorously allegations made in Palermo that Britain had neglected Ferdinand's interests, and to emphasize instead that it was her perseverance in standing up for the king's right to choose that had been one of the principal reasons for the failure of peace negotiations. Whitbread, while speaking in the House of Commons in January 1807, made clear that Fox could only have proceeded on the basis of *uti possidetis*, and had made the retention of Sicily the *sine qua non* of any peace settlement. Howick, speaking in the same debate, referred to the impossibility of Britain ever surrendering Sicily without first obtaining Ferdinand's consent, adding with a patriotic flourish that "it would have broken the hearts of those brave men who fought for it in the plains of Maida, if it could have been given up on any other conditions." In any case the death of Charles Fox, which occurred in September 1806, had ended the peace negotiations; but as even he had allowed the garrison to be increased to 13,000 by the end of July 1806, there was really no question of Britain deciding to leave Sicily in any hurry. Sicily (in the words of Professor Holland Rose) "was the chief cause of the prolongation of the war, as Malta had been of its inception."²

Instead, the ministry decided to bind the court more closely to her British ally by offering it a treaty of alliance. This treaty provided for Sicily's ports to be kept open to British ships, and for Sicily to supply provisions for British crews and British troops as well as for the island of Malta. In return, Britain agreed to protect the ports of Messina and Augusta, to maintain at least

10,000 troops stationed on the island at her own expense, and to pay a subsidy of £300,000 annually, backdated to September 1805. Further provisions were suggested to the court, but these were most unfavorably received. They involved the British guaranteeing to keep 5,000 troops in Sicily in peacetime, giving Syracuse, Milazzo, and Augusta the same free-port status Messina enjoyed, and granting to British merchants in Sicily the position of most-favored nationals.³ The court was understandably afraid that the British had ideas about annexing Sicily, while Messina was bitterly opposed to sharing her privileges with other ports. The hostile manner in which the draft treaty embodying these last clauses was rejected by the court caused a temporary rift with the British government. Drummond decided to suspend the subsidy and wrote back to London for instructions. These instructions, drafted in March 1807, were never in fact dispatched to him because of the fall of the ministry and its replacement by one led by Portland. They would have entailed Britain playing a significant role in governing Sicily, the sort of role that she was eventually compelled to adopt in 1811. They would have entailed the continued suspension of the subsidy Britain paid to the court and ultimately the use of force, were the court not to accept measures designed to render it less unpopular, and were aimed at removing what seemed a real danger of a discontented people or a disloyal court betraying Sicily to the enemy. Strangers obnoxious to Sicilians were to be removed from the royal council, Sicilian noblemen were henceforth to be admitted to positions of trust, there was to be a unified command under the senior British officer, and no post of military importance was to be given to a non-Sicilian, or indeed to anybody not approved by the British commander. It was also proposed that the British minister should have the power to remove from their posts any foreigners suspected of treachery.⁴

When Canning took over the Foreign Office, he decided these instructions should not be sent and that all that could reasonably be required of the king was his confidence and cooperation. But by this time, Drummond, having been persuaded that the court's attitude had radically changed, had already renewed the payment of the subsidy. The treaty, without the offending clauses, was signed on 23 March 1807, though because of changes in the international scene brought about by the Treaty of Tilsit in July, its ratification by the British sovereign was postponed for another fourteen months. Drummond had convinced himself that because the queen had agreed to withdraw from the royal council and Saint Clair had been removed from his post, the policy of the court had changed, and that he (Drummond), Circello, and the king would henceforth control the conduct of affairs.⁵ In believing this he was certainly naive, and the generals made it clear that they thought so.

Meanwhile the British government had decided during the winter of 1806 to send a naval force to Constantinople to support Russia and to frighten the

Porte, who, it was thought, was about to yield to French pressure and side with Napoleon. Though Britain now possessed in Sicily an army of 20,000 men, it was felt that because of the court's dubious loyalty, no substantial force could be spared from the island to lend support to the naval squadron—a deprivation that had fatal consequences since it resulted in the total failure of Duckworth's expedition to the Dardanelles. Instead it was decided to send from Messina a force to seize Alexandria, in order to forestall a possible move by Napoleon to recover Egypt.⁶

Accordingly 6,000 men, commanded by Brigadier General Fraser, were dispatched to capture Alexandria from the Mamelukes, which they did on 20 March 1807. Fraser was not an experienced commander, and Fox would have preferred to send Moore, but decided he could not spare him from Sicily. Fraser, in trying to extend his position to include control of the Nile delta, suffered two serious military reverses involving the loss of a third of his force, and Fox had to send from Sicily 2,000 reinforcements to make good this loss. When the ministry in London was told by Fox that it would require 16,000 troops, including cavalry, to defend Egypt, it decided Sicily took priority. The possession of Alexandria, wrote Windham, had always been subordinate to the security of Sicily, and to "the more important object" of acting against the French in Italy.⁷ The British troops in Egypt were withdrawn, though not until September 1807.

Meanwhile General Fox had been under strong pressure both from Drummond, now a spokesman for the court, and from the Russian ambassador Tatischeff, to send another army to Italy to relieve the pressure on Britain's allies. Such an expedition would, it was argued, cause a diversion in favor of the Russians, who felt threatened in Dalmatia by French forces in Friuli, and would meet with little opposition in Naples, which kingdom the French had denuded of troops. Now that the army of Napoleon had received a serious setback in Poland, the time was ripe, so it was argued, for an assault on Italy.⁸ General Fox rejected these arguments. He had already made clear to Drummond his objections to such an enterprise, drawing attention to the large proportion of his army that was now committed to Egypt, to the possibility of having to send another force to the Dardanelles, and to the lack of dependability of the Neapolitan troops of the king. He doubted the accuracy of the information about the strength of French troops in Naples, and the French in any case could always draw on a large strategic reserve in the north. Anyway of what use was a plan whose secret was bound to be betrayed by the queen and her entourage, he asked?⁹ Rebuffed, the court acted on its own, and dispatched Hesse's army to defeat at Mileto.

The reactions of Fox and Moore to the latter were, predictably, "I told you so." Moore wrote privately to Fox: "Thus has ended Circello's and the Queen's expedition in the only manner it could reasonably be expected to end." He was sorry that a brave man like Hesse had been employed on what

he called "so bad a corvée," but "Fools, I believe, never learn—so that we cannot hope that those who direct the Sicilian government will profit by this check." And Fox could not resist telling Drummond that the Neapolitan cavalry had behaved even worse than their infantry. As for the *masse*, perhaps even the queen would now acknowledge their uselessness—they had not fired a shot in the whole campaign, and their vengeance had as usual been directed against their defenseless countrymen.¹⁰

Two months later, Fox received from Castlereagh instructions drafted on 21 May ordering him to prepare to land in Calabria or some other part of Italy. This might, in Castlereagh's opinion, lead on to the conquest of Naples and even its permanent occupation, but at worst it would furnish a useful diversion and perhaps destroy a French corps as well.¹¹ It was clear that Castlereagh, who had been prompted by Drummond, did not realize the size of Ferdinand's army, fondly imagining that it and half the British force (the proportion he instructed Fox to hold in readiness) amounted to 20,000 men. Fox had to point out his error to him, at the same time emphasizing the poor fighting quality of the Neapolitans, as revealed so recently at Mileto. If he did, he wrote, take an army to Italy, he would have to leave behind 2,000 men to secure the fortresses of Messina and Syracuse, and that would give him a strength of 8,000 (half the army being still in Egypt) to confront a French army of 20,000. He remained without any cavalry and, even if joined by the king's forces, he would still be outnumbered by the French.¹²

Over plans for yet another expedition (Mileto took place at the end of May) and over attitudes toward the court, the disagreement between Drummond and the generals came to a head in July 1807 when Fox went home and the outspoken Moore took over the post of British commander. Ever since he had changed his mind over the attitude of the court, Drummond had tried to persuade the generals that the French party no longer controlled it, and that since the king's power was limited by noble and corporate privileges, many abuses existing in Sicily were outside the power of the king to remedy. He was sure the queen's influence was now minimal, and protested that he (Drummond) had been unfairly stigmatized for "weakness, imbecility and lack of steadiness."¹³ Fox in his turn had represented to Drummond that the recent appointment of the king's eldest son to be inspector general of the royal army and of Saint Clair to be one of his aides certainly did not correspond with any loss of power by the queen. As to the barons, Fox was unsure whether giving them more power would not be preferable to what he characteristically described as "the miserable weak government of the reigning family."¹⁴

Drummond continued to believe that the way to better Sicily's lot was by a reform of the constitution, initiated by the king, and that he (Drummond) could use his influence to bring such a reform about. He certainly did not want such a change effected by a military coup, a course the generals were



Lieutenant-General Sir John Moore, by Sir T. Lawrence. (*Courtesy of the National Portrait Gallery, London.*)

known to favor. "I would desire for many reasons that the seat of legislature should rather be a Sicilian parliament than a British camp."¹⁵ The generals favored stopping the subsidies until British demands were met for radical reform of Sicilian institutions, but such a recourse, in Drummond's view, would never produce the results desired. He thought the king and queen far too proud to yield to menaces of that sort, and meanwhile the royal army would fall to pieces through lack of pay.¹⁶

In March Drummond had visited Messina to try to present his case in person, but the generals had given him a chilly reception. Moore had talked a little wildly about dispatching the queen to Trieste, and Drummond had come to the conclusion that he understood little of Sicilian affairs.¹⁷ Moore for his part despised Drummond, whom he thought "the weakest and silliest of men," a "false, unprincipled, mean fellow . . . who at first bred all the mischief with the queen and who still, as far as he is able, will endeavour to foment it." Moore was certainly not renowned for his tolerance of civilians and politicians, and his strictures concerning Drummond recall curious echoes of his condemnation twelve years earlier of Sir Gilbert Elliot's conduct in Corsica. Sir Arthur Paget, the diplomat and former minister at Palermo, who passed through Sicily in July and who listened to both sides in the dispute, concluded that they were irreconcilable.¹⁸

The navy also was drawn in to the quarrel. Captain Thornborough commanding the squadron, entrusted with the defense of Sicily, was approached by the court to convoy to Italy a royal expeditionary force. In private talks he had had with Drummond, the latter had appeared to agree with him that such an action would only divide his squadron and subject it to unacceptable risk. Yet when Thornborough met the queen in the presence of Drummond, the latter totally unexpectedly turned round and spoke in support of her case. "This sudden change . . . has astonished me," wrote Thornborough, "at present I know not how to act with such a man. . . . [I] am convinced he would wish to throw all the blame on the Army and Navy."¹⁹ Drummond was certainly devious, and his lack of frankness in dealing with Canning over the question of the Spanish regency and Ferdinand's claim to it for one of his sons was a year later to lead to his recall.

The person, attitude, and influence of the queen remained at the center of the dispute. She herself put her views to Paget during his stay in Sicily. She complained that it almost seemed that the British looked on Sicily as a conquered country. The generals complained that the court did not recruit, yet how, she asked, could it hope to do so, when the British offered higher rates of pay. The court had 6,000 regular troops ready to embark at an instant, yet the generals treated her plans with contempt and refused to expend British blood in removing a tyrant from the throne of Naples. Those who accused the court of betrayal were, she said, nothing but a crowd of malcontents who had taken refuge at Messina and got the generals to listen to



Admiral Sir Edward Thornborough, by S. Lane. (*Courtesy of the National Maritime Museum, London.*)

them.²⁰ It was difficult to argue rationally with her. She had in the winter of 1807/8 been involved in one of her many intrigues, this time with the Russian ambassador, with the idea of a Russian garrison being sent to Sicily to replace the British. Tatischeff, anxious to discredit Britain, had according to Drummond been spreading rumors that he was able to mediate between the court and Napoleon, to the end that the king should recover Naples, provided the British got out of Sicily. At Drummond's peremptory request, which earned him a rebuke from Canning, Tatischeff was ordered to leave Palermo, but the incident did little to better relations between the Sicilian court and the British.²¹

Russia, of course, since the Treaty of Tilsit, when Czar Alexander joined hands with Napoleon, had become an enemy of Britain. It was therefore, in British eyes, disgraceful that the queen should be seeking the help of the Russians. There had already been an incident in January, when Circello had been under pressure from Drummond to order the seizure of a Russian frigate that had earlier arrived in Palermo harbor, before war was declared between Britain and Russia. Thornborough, acting on Admiralty instructions, had wanted to attack the frigate, but the Sicilian government had at first demurred. It was finally induced by Drummond to declare a state of war with Russia, and the frigate's captain agreed to surrender to the Sicilians, though not to the British, thus defusing an awkward situation that had touched the quick of Sicilian pride.²²

The Sicilian court was particularly sensitive about attacks on its loyalty to Britain and on its general competence, including those made in the British press. Castalcicala, the minister in London, was so incensed at an article published in February 1808 in the pages of the Whig *Morning Chronicle* that he persuaded the British government to start proceedings against Perry, the proprietor. The matter was eventually settled, though not until after more than a year, by Perry making an abject apology. The paper, he said, was merely anxious to draw the British public's attention to the danger to which British troops were exposed in the current Sicilian situation, and he had no wish to interfere in the way an independent state was governed, much less to try to sow dissension between the Sicilian king and his subjects.²³ But six months later there was more trouble, when Leckie's "Historical Survey" was published and brought to Castalcicala's attention. In it Leckie did not mince his words. He described the Sicilian government as exhibiting "all the weakness and degeneracy" associated with the Byzantine Empire "in its last stages of degradation," and he urged the ministers to undertake the much-needed reforms in Sicily, since by propping up an unpopular regime the British themselves incurred popular hatred. He attacked the attitude of the queen who clearly had no love for the British, the duplicity of the Palermo court, and the pro-French sympathies of at least one minister, and demanded that Britain interfere in Sicily's internal affairs for "pressing motives of self-

defence." Castalcicala wrote to Canning, describing the survey as grossly insulting—an appalling libel on the king, the queen, and the whole Sicilian government, and again asked for the author to be prosecuted and punished with the full vigor of the law.²⁴ And matters had been made no easier, in trying to establish relations of trust between the British and Sicilian governments, by an episode concerning Spain, which involved the Sicilian royal family.

As soon as the news had reached Palermo that Ferdinand VII of Spain, nephew of Ferdinand III of Sicily, had been forced by Napoleon to abdicate, that the Spanish royal family were now prisoners in France, and that a revolt had broken out by the Spanish people against French occupation, great excitement prevailed at Palermo. By the will of Charles III, the father of the Sicilian king and of the unpopular Charles IV of Spain (who had recently yielded his throne to his son), if the male line of Charles IV should fail, Ferdinand the Sicilian king would become heir to the throne of Spain.

Drummond took up the cause of the king (Ferdinand III of Sicily), sponsored his claim to the Spanish regency, and managed to persuade the queen that it had the support of the British government. (Needless to say, King Ferdinand of Sicily was not himself greatly interested, and Drummond felt he had cause to complain that the king did not go to Spain in person.)²⁵ Yet Drummond was acting on his own initiative, not only without authority but directly against Canning's stated wishes. This was to have unfortunate consequences, not just for Anglo-Sicilian relations but also for Drummond personally.

Writing on 31 May 1808 and a week later on 7 June, Drummond told Canning he was sure that if the Spanish monarch, as well as his sons, were excluded from the throne of Spain, then Britain must wish to see on that throne someone who was her friend and ally. He thought the prospects for old Spain were gloomy, but that Prince Leopold could be sent to England and helped to a throne in Spanish America. At this stage, he assured Canning, he had breathed no word to the king or his court that he was thinking along these lines, but wanted to learn what the ministry thought.²⁶ Yet, without waiting for a reply, Drummond committed himself at once (and by implication the British government) to sponsoring a Sicilian regency in Spain. Having toyed first with the idea of sending the hereditary prince to Spain, while Leopold went via England to America to claim the regency on behalf of his father, he got the court to agree that Leopold, in the company of various advisers, would be sent to Gibraltar to sound out the Spanish. To this end Drummond had already advanced £10,000 of British money toward the expenses of the voyage and the cost of Leopold's stay in Gibraltar.²⁷

Drummond's letter of 31 May and his second one of 7 June crossed with a dispatch to him from Canning. This warned him not to encourage the court to make any claim to the Spanish regency—a claim for which the backing of

Britain had already been canvassed by Castelvicala.²⁸ And when Canning learnt of Drummond's views and his assurance that he had not yet communicated them to the court, he instructed Drummond on no account to lend support to any such claim. The question of choosing a regent for Spain must be a matter for the Spanish *Cortes*, and any attempt by the court of Sicily to claim the regency without being invited was bound to arouse a hostile response. The last thing the British government wanted was to offend the Spanish patriots.²⁹

But things had now gone too far for Drummond to see how he could retract his support, and Circello had been given his written assurances that what he was doing was backed by his government. The queen had agreed that Leopold should leave for Spain as soon as possible in the company of her favorite Saint Clair, the Duke of Orleans, Prince Cassaro, the Duke of Ascoli and Tommasi, a legal adviser of the government. The whole party was to be conveyed by the British warship *Thunderer*, which Ball in Malta had agreed to supply, without having been shown the passenger list. The *Thunderer* duly sailed in September and arrived at Gibraltar, only to find that the party was not permitted to land. Prince Leopold was kept three days on board until he agreed to return to Palermo and abandon any attempt to make contact with the Spanish Junta and the patriot party.³⁰

Canning had naturally been outraged when he discovered what Drummond had done, disregarding his clear instructions. The British government had been placed in a quite invidious position. It must either approve Drummond's actions and so appear to be interfering in Spain's strictly internal concerns, or disown the whole Sicilian *démarche* and thus risk causing offense at Palermo. It decided to take the latter course, and Drummond was told that he was recalled.³¹

Drummond comes somewhat discredibly out of the whole wretched, botched affair. He tried to excuse himself to Canning by making out, quite untruthfully, that Circello had been the moving force in having Leopold sent to Spain, and that he, Drummond, had merely connived, and then only in his private capacity. His excuse for the failure to tell Captain Ball that the *Thunderer* was to carry a royal prince was a thoroughly unconvincing one; over the sending of the Marquis Saint Clair, he attempted to shift all the blame on the queen—"another proof of her dirty cunning which fools have mistaken for sense and acuteness"—though he certainly knew that Saint Clair was going.³²

The situation was not improved by a protest, lodged soon after by Castelvicala at the action the British took at Gibraltar. When he tried to argue that Leopold's party should have received the same hospitality that British forces had received in Sicily, Canning became extremely angry. "It can hardly be necessary to you to point out the inaptitude of this illustration." British troops, he added, had been invited to Sicily, and then in order to safeguard

the island, while Leopold's presence at Gibraltar was scarcely required for defense of that fortress. Nor had his reason for coming there been to look for safety and British protection. It was all very well to take a "high tone" about the right of the king of Sicily to the regency of Spain being "clear and incontrovertible" and to assert that such a claim was the only way to avoid civil war, but the evidence for this was not forthcoming, nor was there any for the claim by the king to devolve the regency onto his son. If the united voice of Spain had called for Ferdinand III or Leopold, that indeed would alter the case, but the facts proclaimed that this was not so. The court at Palermo, Canning went on, must have been aware that Drummond had acted without any precise instructions, and had he not connived personally at the action taken by the Sicilian court, the British government would be entitled to take grave offense at what had been done. The arrival of a prince of Sicily aboard a British vessel before a British fortress was liable to the gravest misconstruction, and the king was advised to stand very clear of any suspicion that he had condoned it.³³

What Canning was saying in so many words was that it had all been the fault of the queen. And this was underlined in a secret letter he sent the same day to Castelcicala in which he protested in the strongest terms about the inclusion of the Marquis Saint Clair in the party that had accompanied Leopold. Saint Clair he described, without actually naming him, as someone whom the British government had been trying over the past two or three years to have removed from positions of trust and had only refrained from pressing its case out of a sense of delicacy. Hence the government had been amazed to discover that this man had been sent to visit a British fortress in company with Prince Leopold—"a Frenchman and one whose near connections are notoriously established at the throne of Bonaparte." He must, wrote Canning, be sent home at once, and on no account would he be allowed to pass through Gibraltar into Spain.³⁴

The upshot of the whole affair had been to further injure Sicilian pride, or at least the pride of the royal family, and to make the British yet more suspicious of the loyalty of the court at Palermo.

Moore, once he had assumed command, obtained two interviews with the queen, at one of which the king was present, in which Moore did his best to persuade her that he had the court's best interests at heart and wanted sincerely to do all in his power to regain for it the kingdom of Naples. If it had not been possible to agree on the feasibility of plans, this was for very good military reasons. As he told Paget, the king and queen thought that because the French had recently sent some troops to Corfu from Naples, the whole of that kingdom now lay open, and that it only needed a force to land for the country to fall like a ripe fruit. It would, he commented, be time enough to land at Naples when the French had gone—"the kingdom will not run away." The largest force that could be raised in Sicily, 8,000 British and

7,000 Neapolitans—the latter ill-paid, ill-led and disaffected—would not be under a unified command, could certainly never beat the French, and would not impress the local people. As for it acting as a diversion, it would do nothing to distract Napoleon, who “knows that the fate of Italy will be decided on the Vistula.”³⁵

Moore, with good reason, was very doubtful if he had succeeded in convincing the queen. He felt that she so detested the British, he seriously wondered if her real aim was not to get the British out of Sicily and to see their army destroyed on the mainland. The king, it is true, did eventually permit him to inspect the royal armed forces, whose condition he found indifferent—about equal to that of the London Volunteers but with “far less discipline and without their zeal and personal bravery”; but he was not granted a unified command, the king insisting that the time for this would be when a joint force had landed in Italy.³⁶

Moore was convinced there was no remedy for an unsatisfactory situation until the role of British diplomat in Sicily was merged with that of military commander, as it had once been very briefly when General Fox had filled both parts; for, as things were, the British army had no influence whatever at court. The queen, he was sure, was guilty of treachery, and surrounded herself with foreign émigrés who were certainly no friends to Britain. The only way to maintain Sicily was to take over its government, for if it were left to the king and queen “they will lose themselves, the island and us.” If the French were to land, the island would be gone, the royal troops probably would desert and the local inhabitants, losing confidence, would offer the enemy no resistance. All the British army could hope to do would be to shut itself up in its fortresses and await relief from the British navy. It would clearly therefore be prudent to retain enough transports to take away the army.³⁷ Moore had decided to make Castrogiovanni (today and in ancient times called Enna), set on a well-nigh impregnable hill in the center of the island, his pivot of resistance, leaving only enough men to garrison the principal ports.

This very pessimistic analysis, and Moore’s call for 12,000 more troops, decided the cabinet to recall him. The Treaty of Tilsit had left Britain on her own again and had put paid to any hopes of using Sicily as a base for offense, so Moore and 8,000 of his best troops were ordered back to protect the home shores and to act as a mobile strategic reserve outside the Mediterranean. The cabinet had been put in a position in which it must either accept Moore’s views or recall him and replace him by someone else. It chose the latter, for reasons that Castlereagh made clear in a letter he wrote to Hawkesbury:

Unless we are prepared to act up to his principles of setting the government aside, which I certainly am not . . . I should not despair of his obedience, if of his conversion, to any system we might lay down for him,

but unfortunately the Sicilian government know the extent of his opinions, which deprive him of all influence, and make him a less effective instrument for enforcing any measures of authority short of the extreme one of subversion.³⁸

Bunbury found it incredible that at the moment when Sicily seemed to be threatened with the greatest danger, Moore and so many excellent troops should be removed to another theater, leaving behind to guard the island a force of only 9,000 men. Russia was now an ally of France, and Marmont had in the Adriatic area a disposable force of 40,000 that could be transported by French ships at Venice and by Russian warships at Corfu and Trieste. And at Toulon and at Genoa there were French troops as well as the ships to carry them, while their fleet could easily be joined by a Spanish one from Cartagena. Ministers in London had taken a risk, one that was nearly to lose them Sicily, and as soon as Castlereagh realized that the French had taken over Corfu and that the threat to Sicily was real, he decided to reinforce the latter.³⁹

Moore's replacement in Sicily was the same John Stuart who had been there before, prior to the arrival of Henry Fox, the victor of Maida and friend of the court. Perhaps to ingratiate himself with the ministers, he had told them that he considered that Sicily could be held with a garrison of only 10,000, given sufficient naval support. Fox and Moore, on the other hand, insisted it needed 26,000. Castlereagh decided to compromise, increased the garrison to 16,000 by the early months of 1808 and, ignoring the possibility of it having to be evacuated, ordered home the available transports.⁴⁰

Threats of Invasion and Counterinvasion

The fear of a French invasion of Sicily continued to preoccupy Stuart throughout the course of 1808. During the winter of 1807/8 the threat of a French assault was a real one, for Napoleon, seeing Sicily denuded, albeit temporarily, by Moore's departure together with 8,000 of the best British troops, ordered the capture of Reggio and Scilla and preparations for full-scale invasion.¹

French success in capturing these two strongpoints was due to the British navy's inability to keep station in the winter storms and intercept convoys of small craft carrying munitions from Naples to Pizzo. British reverses were also the result of the French success in capturing (perhaps through treachery) in the straits of Messina four gunboats, armed with twenty-four-pounders—guns that the French found extremely useful in reducing Scilla's fortifications. Sherbrooke, the general in temporary command of the British forces at Messina, ordered the withdrawal of the Scilla garrison after a siege of seven weeks, not having sufficient forces to make a diversion to relieve the fortress.² Scilla fell on 23 February 1808, but by then Napoleon had changed his plans. Originally, he had ordered Ganteaume, commanding the Rochefort and Toulon squadrons, to sail to Naples, embark 9,000 men there, and then land them around Messina at the same time that Régnier was to put across a further 9,000 from Reggio and Scilla. But he now felt that Russia's threat to the Turkish Empire in the Mediterranean had become of far-more-pressing importance than the need to deprive the British of Sicily. He decided therefore to reinforce Corfu with the object of staking out a claim to the Turkish provinces in Albania and Greece. He instructed Joseph, who at that moment was busy preparing to enter Sicily, to regard Corfu as of greater importance: "Sicily's fate is known and sealed, Corfu's is quite unknown and hangs in the balance . . . in the present state of Europe the greatest misfortune that could befall me would be the loss of Corfu."³ And Ganteaume was not to call at Naples, but instead to make directly for Corfu. When part of his fleet under Admiral Cosmao became detached in the course of a storm and put into the port of Taranto, Cosmao sent to Joseph for instructions; but Joseph, though longing to invade Sicily, did not dare disobey his brother, and Cosmao was therefore dispatched at once to rejoin Ganteaume's fleet at Corfu. Napoleon, now having learnt that the British had been reinforced in

Sicily and that a powerful British fleet had arrived in the Mediterranean, and having no wish for Ganteaume's ships to become engaged with a superior force, ordered them to return to Toulon. It is true that Joseph still had a force ready amounting to nearly 8,000 men, though of these 3,000 made up the garrison holding down Lower Calabria; but without the munitions and transports promised that would have arrived with Ganteaume's fleet, he felt that he could take on the British with any reasonable chance of success. When Napoleon's interest soon after shifted to the theaters of Spain and Portugal, Joseph was recalled in July to take over the Spanish throne.⁴

During the summer of 1808 Stuart continued to act offensively against the Neapolitan coast and kept up pressure on the enemy ports, although he decided to terminate the raids by Calabrian refugees that were organized by the Marquis Carbone. These raids, he had been assured by General Sherbrooke, were merely pillaging expeditions that could only result in bringing discredit on the British army in Sicily.

In September he was able to report a most successful combined operation against the small harbor of Diamante. A detachment of British troops had been landed and with the help of two British sloops had captured thirty-eight enemy vessels, including two large Neapolitan gunboats.⁶ During the remainder of that month he continued to make hostile demonstrations with troop transports, as if planning a landing, but eventually he had to call these off for lack of an adequate naval escort.⁷ But in any case he was now confronted with a far more resourceful and daring opponent than Joseph Bonaparte had ever been, and he himself was forced onto the defensive.

For Joseph's successor in the kingdom of Naples, the daring, ambitious Joachim Murat, was quite determined to undertake the conquest of Sicily as soon as he could. As a preliminary, he captured Capri during October 1808, describing this success to Napoleon as a good augury for the seizure of Sicily.⁸ Although the British had not intended to surrender the island so easily—in fact the relief force arrived too late (having been driven back by a storm) and the many desertions from the Corsican regiment, once the deed of surrender had been signed, had proved, to say the least, somewhat disconcerting—they did not regard its loss as serious. The cost of defending it had been excessive and it had served very little purpose except as a base for the queen's spies and agents.⁹ The loss did however alarm the court, who, through Drummond, complained to Collingwood about the lack of naval protection. Collingwood was impatient with such complaints. He told Mulgrave that no important point on the coast of Sicily would be left undefended and his ships were constantly on station to watch the approaches to the island. The court, he thought, seemed to imagine that when those ships were out of sight, the defense of Sicily had been abandoned, and yet when they were seen in port, the enemy had been left to do as he pleased. "It would," he commented feelingly, "require a squadron in every port to

remove all their apprehensions.” However, to calm the fears of the court, and particularly those of the queen, who still apprehended a British betrayal, he detailed Admiral Martin with three ships-of-the-line to base himself on Palermo harbor.¹⁰

Throughout October and November Murat continued to prepare for invasion, assuring Napoleon that all he required was 6,000 troops and naval support; and he argued that the time was now ripe, since the strength of the British army in Sicily had been reduced to a mere 4,000 [*sic*]. Clearly, Murat had swallowed whole the disinformation put out by Napoleon to alarm the government in London and deflect its attention from Portugal to Sicily. He had ordered false reports to be placed in various Dutch newspapers about the strength of the British in Sicily, a landing by 30,000 French, and the exodus of the king from the island. But by March it must have dawned even on Murat that Sicily’s invasion had been postponed indefinitely, orders having reached him to send troops northward to meet the threat presented by Austria.¹¹

Meanwhile there had been various pressures on the British to use their forces in Sicily to support a national Italian uprising of the kind that had just been witnessed in Spain. A Neapolitan called Biancamano had recently got in touch with Drummond, making out that he was the spokesman for the chiefs of all the parties in Naples. He alleged that these chiefs were in league with others throughout the whole length of Italy, and that they looked to the British in Sicily to give them material support.¹² The government in London, being apprised of this, instructed Stuart to use his discretion. But any help that he might give must be used not for some attempt at the temporary recovery of Naples but for a purpose “likely to lead to important and extensive combinations,” or in other words to a major effort to liberate Italy from the French.¹³ A month later he received instructions that were a little more positive. He was urged to explore the possibilities of giving assistance to the Italians, and for this purpose he was allowed to retain the transports he had been told to send home. He was warned however that any help given must be dependent on the success achieved by the patriot armies of Spain.¹⁴

Through Lowe, when commanding the Capri garrison, Stuart had made various inquiries as to how far the local inhabitants would support the arrival of an army of 10,000. He contemplated the possibility of a landing at some point along the coast between Terracina and the Gulf of Spezia, since any landing in the kingdom of Naples would have little appeal to other Italians. Colonel Bunbury, corresponding with Lowe, pressed for a landing where the French were weak, and that meant the Roman states or Tuscany. They had 32,000 men, it was true, but scattered over so extensive an area, sickly, and locked up in garrisons, they would not be able to concentrate them to meet a threat posed far from Naples. But he did admit to serious doubts about the

whole subject of Italian resistance. "I fear there are no leaders," he wrote, "nor any one common or durable bond, which could ensure to us the united and continued aid of the Tuscans, Romans, Neapolitans and Piedmontese."¹⁵ Collingwood was also very skeptical about there existing a spirit of patriotism on which to build a war of resistance. "There is no stuff to work on there—the people are licentious, the nobles are unprincipled. It is a superior army alone that can effect a change or maintain it." The Italian people, in his view, did not possess "the Spanish spirit."¹⁶

Stuart by now had become distrustful of Biancamano and his claims, especially since he seemed to be linked with slippery characters like Prince Moliterno, the condottiere who kept in with both sides. He told Castlereagh that he did not doubt that many in Italy were discontented, but he had yet to hear of a cohesive party, a concerted plan of operations, or any measures generally agreed upon. Much depended on the future actions of the Spaniards and the Austrians, for his force of 9,000 (all he could spare) would never free Italy on its own. In the kingdom of Naples the upper classes would be slow to desert their French masters by whom they had been courted and rewarded, and the people as a whole still had bitter memories of the royal vengeance in 1799. An amnesty guaranteed by Britain would be "an indispensable prelude" to any attempt to recover Naples. And he tried to convince the king and queen that he could not undertake any move to the continent until he received unequivocal proof that the Italian peoples were organized for war.¹⁷

Murat, through his agents, was well aware of the British involvement with potential rebels and he kept Napoleon informed accordingly, as also did Eugene, the viceroy of Italy. He knew of the British correspondence with patriot leaders in Bologna and Venice in regard to placing Italy under one constitutional sovereign, and of 12,000 who had pledged themselves to take up arms in the Roman states, but he sensibly and realistically attached little importance to all this and assured Napoleon that a general uprising throughout Italy was an impossibility.¹⁸

Castlereagh, as soon as he realized that Italy was no duplicate of Spain, decided that troops in Sicily could be better employed in Catalonia. In October, therefore, he instructed Stuart to prepare to dispatch a force to Spain, without realizing the damaging effect that this would have on morale at the court. The latter was already sufficiently alarmed by the recent loss of Capri to Murat, the movement of troops into Lower Calabria, and the seeming absence of naval support, to which reference has already been made. Stuart delayed acting on Castlereagh's instructions, if only because it seemed useless to send a force of less than 7,000 to Spain, and that would leave in Sicily fewer than the minimum of 10,000 troops guaranteed by the treaty of alliance. The king made it clear he would never agree to such a reduction in British strength, since he thought it was bound to appear to Murat an open

invitation for him to invade.¹⁹ Stuart's arguments persuaded Castlereagh, who received his dispatches in May 1809. By that time Austria had reentered the war, and Castlereagh, in writing to Stuart to approve his not sending forces to Spain, expressed the hope he would now begin to make himself useful in Italy.²⁰

The vague wording of Castlereagh's dispatch exemplified the cabinet's lack of a plan for cooperation with the Austrian armies. The Austrians themselves had since the spring been trying through the offices of Count Sallier de la Tour to coordinate plans with the British command and with the courts at Palermo and Cagliari for joint operations in northern Italy. La Tour, who was a Piedmontese subject serving as an officer in the Austrian army, had arrived in Palermo on 31 March. He had instructions from the Austrian government to obtain the support of the king and the British—the latter providing, it was hoped, if not troops, then transports and naval escort. The Archduke John, who was to command the Austrian army in the north of Italy, impressed on La Tour the need for speed—his own campaign against the French was due to start on 9 April—and what he wanted was for forces from Sicily, and if possible from Sardinia also, to join his own army in the Lombard plain or in the valley of the Po.²¹

The queen, as might have been expected, was a great enthusiast for the plan, and she even got the king to agree to Stuart being given the supreme command. Stuart agreed, in principle only, to taking some action in Italy, but would not commit himself to details until he knew more of the Austrian movements and until he had received instructions from London. The relevant instructions (if such they can be called) did not reach him until July. In any case he felt incapable of doing more than causing a diversion with the limited number of troops he had, even if the French had withdrawn their main army and the mass of Italians were "ripe for revolt."²² Collingwood, on the other hand, was a firm supporter of the Austrian case. He sent three frigates to reinforce Martin and urged Stuart to take advantage of the dearth of French forces along the coasts. If Austria were to fail now, and the fate of Italy depended on her, he would not wish Britain to be responsible, and he could not see how the allied cause could be helped by the temporary possession of Naples or of some island in its bay.²³

Stuart finally agreed with the court to make a double landing in the south of Italy, 15,000 troops going to Calabria, and another 2,000 to Naples itself, in the hope of achieving a *coup de main* there. But when he learned of the Austrian defeats that had taken place in Bavaria, he suspended all preparations for sailing—this despite violent protests by the queen, who refused to believe that Vienna had fallen. The troops had been embarked on 26 May, but Stuart told La Tour that they could not leave until the situation in the north was clarified. The queen meanwhile bombarded La Tour with messages urging immediate action and with plans for 3,000 Sardinians to join with the

British in the seizure of Genoa.²⁴ Stuart's hesitancy is understandable, given the memories of his government's displeasure at his raising of the *masse* in 1806, his instructions not to intervene in Italy unless there was a plan for a general liberation, and the fact that he had not yet received permission to withhold his troops from Spain. He was also in fear of a mutiny among the officers of his army, many of whom were highly critical of his competence to lead them in action and therefore thoroughly disapproved of the whole idea of the expedition.²⁵

At last, feeling he must do something with an army of 16,000 lying idle, and convincing himself that the Austrian reverses were not as severe as French reports made out, he decided to capture the island of Ischia and to use it as a base for further operations. This was a course that the court approved, though Collingwood considered it a waste of effort.²⁶ The expedition on board included a large contingent of the court entourage, including Prince Leopold, Circello, Tommasi, Saint Clair, Ascoli, and General Nunziante, and they insisted on making landfalls at Policastro and Sapri en route in anticipation of picking up numerous recruits for the expedition. These landings proved a complete farce and showed only too clearly that the local people were not at all ready to welcome the Bourbons. By the time the convoy arrived off Ischia, Stuart had lost all confidence in the successful outcome of his enterprise and would probably have returned to Sicily at once had the Ischia garrison not surrendered so easily.²⁷

Landing at Ischia on 25 June, Stuart was soon in control of the island and of its neighbor Procida, but instead of assaulting Naples forthwith, he wasted time in prolonged discussions about the nature of the new administration, the court having sent along Prince Leopold, who suddenly proclaimed himself viceroy. Murat had taken immediate steps to strengthen the defenses of his capital, and Stuart realized too late that the moment for attacking it had passed.²⁸

In the south, a force of 3,000 men under General Mackenzie had tried and failed to capture the little fortress of Scilla, having been incorrectly informed that the French had withdrawn from Lower Calabria. When they did withdraw, shortly after, they blew up the fort and all the brass cannon assembled there for the assault on Sicily, something that drew down on the general responsible the wrath of both Murat and Napoleon, the possession of Scilla being considered by the latter as indispensable for an invasion of Sicily.²⁹

Stuart, under pressure from Bunbury and Collingwood to land troops in the Roman states, was on the point of dispatching 4,000 to capture the port of Civit  Vecchia when two new factors changed his mind. One was the news in the *Moniteur* that the Austrians had been defeated at Wagram, the other a warning from Collingwood about the state of the French fleet in Toulon. France had now got in the Mediterranean the largest fleet she had ever mustered since the signing of the peace of Amiens, and this fleet was now

lying in Toulon's outer harbor as if awaiting orders to sail. Collingwood warned that he was unable to guarantee the protection of Ischia, or indeed of Palermo itself, for if the French fleet got out from Toulon, it might well be in the Bay of Naples before he knew that it had sailed, were the weather to favor the enemy. In view of all this, Stuart decided he must, if ignominiously, retire forthwith to Sicily, abandoning the captured islands that Collingwood had never considered worth taking.³⁰

Back in Sicily, the Count La Tour continued to press for a joint expedition to land on the northwest coast of Italy, and in this he received the support of the court (disgusted at Stuart's withdrawal from Ischia) and the British ministers in Palermo and Cagliari. But, wisely, Stuart remained hesitant. It may be, as La Tour suggested, that Stuart possessed only physical courage and was frightened of making any decision for which he could be held personally responsible; but given the decisive defeat of the Austrians, a landing in the north would have courted disaster and exposed Sicily to immediate invasion.³¹

La Tour then propounded a new plan. It involved 6,000 Austrian troops being sent to Sicily to join the king, as a bait to tempt him back into Italy. The idea had great appeal to the queen, since it seemed a way of ridding the court of its utter dependence on the British, and with 4,000 troops the Sardinians were offering, there could soon be a force of 10,000 in Sicily completely under the control of the court. The whole thing was a fantasy, based on Vienna's erroneous conception that the allied forces in Sicily were made up of 5,000 British auxiliaries under the direct command of the king, and a royal army of 15,000. In any case the La Tour mission and schemes for sending armies to Italy were brought to a very speedy conclusion when the Austrians signed the Peace of Vienna.³²

What Stuart was persuaded to do, at the thrice-repeated request of Collingwood, was to send a small force of 1,700 to capture the southern Ionian islands. Now that the French looked on the point of moving into Illyria, Collingwood was persuaded it was important to prevent them from getting a hold on Greece and threatening the existence of the Turkish Empire. Possession of the islands, he hoped, would act as an effective check to the French and would simultaneously afford Sicily correspondingly greater security. During the first week in October British forces from Sicily captured the islands of Zante, Æthaca, Cephalonia, and Cerigo, and shortly after, Santa Maura. Stuart was then pressed by his subordinates to authorize an assault on Corfu, but because of his instructions from London he had no choice but to resist this pressure.³³ Wellesley, the secretary of state, positively forbade an attack on Corfu since far too many troops would be needed not only to capture the fortress but to hold it. The policy of the British government was to act defensively in the Mediterranean while the struggle being waged in Spain and Portugal was employing so much of the British army. The gar-

risons in the Ionian islands were to be reduced to 1,300, the balance being brought back to Sicily. And if Sicily were ever threatened, still more of the garrisons were to be recalled. The security of Sicily and Malta, as Liverpool emphasized to Stuart, was the primary object in that theater, and the five southern Ionian islands were considered to be of only secondary importance.³⁴

Thus at the start of 1810, a year during which Sicily was again under threat of French invasion, Stuart was left in command of a force of 16,000 with which to defend it, and was under increasing pressure from London to send to Spain as much as a third of it.

Growing Impatience with the Court at Palermo

At the root of the differences between the court and the British representatives in Sicily, either military or civil (for Amherst, who in March 1809 had replaced Drummond as minister, shared the views of the generals about the court), lay three apparently unanswerable questions: how to obtain stricter control of the way in which Britain's subsidy was spent, how to get a unified command of all troops on the island, both royal and British, and how to procure the court's support in the effort to mobilize the island's defenses. On each of these three important matters, and of course the three were interlinked, all attempts to secure agreement or to establish any measure of confidence continued to meet with total failure, and in consequence bred increasing frustration.

The growing financial difficulties of the court led the British government to offer it an increase of £100,000 in the amount of the annual subsidy, in return for which it was suggested that certain important concessions be made. The first of these was the introduction of a unified command on the island. If this were done the problem of accounting could be solved simply and painlessly. British senior officers at Messina had long been pressing for the right of supervising the way in which the subsidy was spent—ostensibly on military objects, but in reality on pensions for émigrés and for financing the queen's network of spies.¹

What Canning wished to make clear to the court was that his government had no desire to interfere in Sicily's internal affairs, though neither could it commit itself to the restoration of the kingdom of Naples.² The court, while welcoming the first assurance, remained completely adamant over the question of a unified command. This was awkward for the ministry in London. It had earlier secured from Castalcicala, Sicilian minister to the Court of St. James, a pledge that if Sicily were invaded, all forces there would come under British command. This pledge had been used by ministers to satisfy a querulous House of Commons who were doubtful about the value obtained from the annual subsidy paid to Sicily. Now the court made out that Castalcicala had acted without authority, that the king had become the commander-in-chief (an expedient to be rid of a difficult question, since his health would prevent him from taking the field) and that to surrender command of his forces would be a blow to his royal dignity. The queen saw it



Admiral Sir George Martin, by Sir T. Lawrence. (*Courtesy of the National Maritime Museum, London.*)



William Pitt, Lord Amherst, engraved by C. Turner. (*Courtesy of the British Museum, London.*)

as an absolute necessity for the king and his sons to be seen to command if they were not to lose "face" in Sicily and indeed throughout the whole of Europe.³ The queen got her way and the treaty was signed and duly ratified in 1810 without the government in London mentioning the court's continued intransigence. "We are still," Amherst wrote to Stuart, "in the same uncertainty . . . left to ourselves to remedy as best we can the want of unity of plan and employment of the military resources of Sicily."⁴

Stuart by now had become disillusioned with a court whose darling he had once been. The operations he had undertaken in the Bay of Naples in June and July had opened his eyes to the court's duplicity. He complained to Castlereagh of the way he had been deceived over the role of Prince Leopold, who had accompanied him to Ischia in what was nominally a military role. Yet once Ischia had been taken, the prince had revealed himself unexpectedly as the king's representative on the island, a step that Stuart considered to be both "premature and injudicious," in view of the suspicions of many Neapolitans in regard to the king and his future intentions. Stuart also complained bitterly of the actions of the Marquis di Schiara, appointed by the king as civil governor in Reggio and the surrounding area. Despite the king's solemn amnesty, backed by assurances from the British commanders, Schiara had behaved in such a way as to alienate all the local people, and although Circello tried to make out that Schiara had acted without authority, Stuart was convinced he had been the recipient of secret instructions from the queen. While the latter was considered the source of authority by ministers and all those in government, "Revenge, Passion and Asperity" would rule, and there seemed to Stuart to be little advantage in any military agreement with the court.⁵

It was only the strongest opposition on his part and on that of Rear Admiral Martin, now in command of the naval force that was protecting Sicily, that prevented the court in February 1810 from once more trying to raise the *masse* by sending a force under Prince Moliterno into Calabria with 3,000 muskets. The fact that this madcap scheme of the queen had been planned without consulting the British, though it entailed the employment and escort of British transports for 4,000 men, caused the British commanders no small irritation, and it also caused Amherst to lodge a protest against such "separate and secret undertakings."⁶ Stuart by now had become convinced that only intervention by Britain could save Sicily from disaster, ironically the same conclusion that Moore had reached three years before. He informed Bunbury there were no alternatives but to take over Sicily or to abandon it altogether, and he told Amherst that Britain must dictate to the court "its measures as well as its policy."⁷

Amherst had come to agree with him. Writing to Wellesley, the foreign secretary, he called on the ministry at home to intervene in Sicilian affairs. Outlining his reasons for doing so, he drew attention to the preparations

being made by the French to invade Sicily, the inadequacy of Sicilian defenses, the deplorable state of the royal army, and the fact there was no unified command. He also drew attention to the civil unrest, the widespread contempt for the court and its government, and the acceptance by most Sicilians of the absolute need for foreign intervention, no matter from what quarter it came. Britain, by supporting the court, was reproached for perpetuating current abuses, and Sicilians queried the value of an alliance with a country pledged to such nonintervention. Intervention now by Britain would be welcomed by everyone on the island, save only the queen and her entourage, a group whose hostile attitudes endangered the lives of the British garrison.

In practical terms what he was suggesting was the introduction of Sicilians to the cabinet⁸ (at present made up of four Neapolitans), the summoning of a parliament, the exclusion of the queen from public affairs, and the granting to Britain of a unified command; that, or at least the right to control all expenditures on the royal forces, whose condition was such they might well desert the moment the French set foot on the island. Force, he thought, should be used if necessary to ensure these measures were carried through—measures imperative in the face of invasion, but also to prevent the island from remaining merely a “backward and lukewarm ally.”⁹

The discontent of the British commanders (greater even than that of Amherst) at the court's lack of cooperation in making preparations against an invasion is apparent in letters written by Campbell, the adjutant general, to his fellow officers. “The court makes no effort, sends no succour, takes no notice. Ferdinando the fourth goes a'tunny fishing, and his wife continues her usual pranks . . . convicted in my mind of acting in concert with Murat for our expulsion. . . . We must soon hear of some decision by the government to abandon Sicily or strongly reinforce and effectively maintain [it].” For as things were, the court presented nothing but “a tissue of folly and inconsistency.”¹⁰

The invasion crisis of the summer came on the heels of a political one, resulting from the court's financial difficulties and the parliament's refusal to grant it any money. The last time the king had asked for a donative had been back in 1802, and since that date he and his court had had to seek refuge on the island. The way in which they had used Sicily for their own, not Sicilian, purposes, the gross extravagances of the queen, the awarding of senior posts to foreigners, and the maintenance of a substantial army merely in order to recover Naples, caused steadily mounting dissatisfaction. A body of discontented nobles whose motivations were various and who were led by the vain and ambitious Prince Belmonte together with his uncle, the idealistic Prince of Castelnuovo, sponsored a plan for a more rational tax system, designed by Balsamo, an enlightened economist. This plan envisaged abolishing donatives and substituting a tax on land and a moderate tax on general con-

sumption. The plan was approved by parliament but rejected out of hand by the court, who, under the pretense of negotiating a scheme for amending the Sicilian constitution, succeeded in dividing the barons and winning over a part of them, headed by the loyal and upright Cassaro. The recalcitrant barons led by Belmonte then decided to turn to the British and made an appeal for help to Amherst, who, though sympathetic, had no instructions.¹¹ Amherst, knowing he was quite shortly retiring from his post in Palermo, recommended that his successor be empowered to intervene in the government (in ways he had already sketched out in his dispatch of a month before). The barons, he wrote home, want a constitution modelled to some extent on the British, and they believe that the king's opposition to it can be overcome only by Britain's interference. Sicily, he stressed once again, was a country that was ripe for resistance, and the prospect of becoming a province of England was not unwelcome to most of its people. Tactful support by the British government of the kind of constitution the barons envisaged could have the effect of influencing the court. But in any case some change was needed. There must not be a repetition of what had recently occurred when the court, confronted by a French invasion, had clearly appeared to side with the enemy.¹²

For several months there had been no doubt that the enemy was seriously preparing an assault. Murat, who to the end of his career remained a victim of self-deception, had persuaded himself from intelligence reports that the bulk of the Sicilians were on his side. The British army and the court at Palermo were both, he was told, detested heartily and in any case were at odds with each other. He told Napoleon that he was sure he could count on the support of Prince Moliterno, who, together with his fellow officers, was awaiting his arrival with some impatience.¹³ By the end of July Murat had concentrated 500 boats in the little ports immediately facing Sicily, dismantled his forts to arm these boats, and erected batteries at points where transports could be assembled and troops embarked. Finally he arrived in person in the neighbourhood of Reggio, publicly pledging that in twenty-five days he would be dating his letters from Palermo. Yet in the face of all this the court had maintained an attitude of indifference, conduct that Amherst had stigmatized as "tardy, temporising and even suspicious." After much delay, it did finally order the enrollment of 8,000 men, though not until the end of July. But in any case there was no real prospect of the order being carried out, since everyone knew the court had not the means to pay even the troops it already had. The court also ordered sixteen gunboats in Palermo harbor to join the British, but then reduced the pay of their crews, thus offering them, it seemed, an incentive to desert; and the crews were only prevented from doing so by the British agreeing to make good their pay.¹⁴ There is also evidence that agents of the queen issued secret instructions to the gunboats

not to resist an attack by the French and that the latter received from her assurances that their own vessels would not be fired on.¹⁵

Meanwhile attempts to persuade the court to agree to a unified command continued to meet with a negative response.¹⁶ There was a suggestion that the Duke of Orleans, the Anglophile son-in-law of the king, should visit Messina to consult with Stuart, but the latter made it clear that he considered this pointless until the question of command was resolved. Finally Stuart did accept that Bourcard should be allowed to come and help coordinate the movements and positioning of the British and the Sicilian forces; yet almost on the eve of Murat's invasion, the plans agreed upon were cancelled by the court.¹⁷ Efforts had been made to get the king to issue a public proclamation, denying that the interests of Sicily were in any way different from those of Britain, and to encourage the Sicilian people to join in resisting the invader, but no action had been forthcoming. Only in July could the king be induced to order his troops and his general in Messina to cooperate with the British forces, and to deny Murat's claim that the people of Sicily looked to him (Murat) as their deliverer and savior. Even then the order in question did not carry the king's signature nor those of any of his ministers, nor was it ever officially proclaimed or given widespread circulation. Mellish, the chargé d'affaires in Palermo, had had to use the strongest language to get the order issued at all and to persuade the king to send to Milazzo a regiment of royal cavalry.¹⁸

As the court had done nothing on its own to counter the stream of propaganda put out by the government in Naples, Stuart had organized his own with the newspaper *Gazzetta Britannica*, written and published in Messina and edited by a Sicilian priest. From March onward it described the horrors the people might expect once the French landed, and it led its readers to anticipate a Sicilian Vespers in reverse. Stuart relied on local support (as things turned out, with justification), and issued his own proclamation to the people, as the court had so signally failed to appeal to them.¹⁹

To resist the invasion, Admiral Martin disposed of a force of three sail-of-the-line, five frigates, nine brigs and nearly 120 gunboats, which harassed Murat's invasion preparations and captured and destroyed a great many of his vessels. In one action alone on 21 July this force successfully intercepted a convoy carrying important stores, and out of a total of fifty boats captured thirty-seven and sank the rest. Even so Martin remained very conscious of the limitations within which he operated, and he emphasized to his superior, Cotton, the impossibility of interdicting the enemy's coastal communications.²⁰

Stuart himself had under command a force of 16,000 troops, almost half of whom were foreign, which included a disposable reserve of between 8,000 and 9,000 men. Since April he had resisted the orders that were sent to him

by Castlereagh to send away four battalions to Spain, exercising, understandably, the ultimate discretion he had been given.²¹ He had much improved the coastal defenses in the area most exposed to attack, built a military road from Messina to Faro, and constructed batteries along the coast, suitably protected by fascines and sandbags. The local peasants had given their labor voluntarily to dig entrenchments, and the well-to-do had offered their horses, till forbidden to do so by the governor of Messina.²² Whether this would have been sufficient to withstand an assault by 25,000 well-led, well-equipped and experienced troops (15,000 of whom were French), it is impossible to guess. Everything really hinged on the question of whether Murat would be able for long enough to maintain his line of communications in face of the threat from the British squadron, for his own tiny naval squadron had been largely destroyed on 3 May by a British frigate. And of course his ability to do so depended entirely on the weather.

When the invasion eventually took place on the night of 17/18 September, it very soon developed into a fiasco. Thirty-five hundred Neapolitan troops under Brigadier General Cavaignac landed on the coast south of Messina, but, when attacked by a British force, retired swiftly and took to their boats, leaving behind 1,200 men (or according to French sources, just under 800), together with their brigade commander. In this encounter the British suffered the loss of only three or four men. The local peasants, most of whom had firearms, had also joined in the defense and surprised Stuart agreeably by their hostile attitude to the invaders. The major attack planned on the Faro mainly by French troops never took place—Murat giving as his excuse a sudden drop in the favorable wind. Whether their commander, General Grenier, who was in communication with Paris and directly responsible to the minister of war there, had been given an order not to embark cannot be proved by the documents. What is certain is he had been told by Napoleon to take no risks and to be sure of success.

Jacques Rambaud, in an interesting article about this abortive enterprise, has shown that it was not only Napoleon and Grenier who were hesitant, but also the other French generals commanding the divisions of Murat's assault force, especially Partonneaux, who knew the area, and Lamarque, who had earlier proved his enterprise in his bold assault on the cliffs of Anacapri. It was Murat's awareness of his generals' reservations that had almost certainly prompted him to launch Cavaignac across the straits, in order to convince the others that the operation was feasible.²³

Napoleon, we know, was primarily interested in making the British believe in the invasion in order to distract their attention from Portugal, Spain, and the Ionian islands. He was therefore furious with Murat when the latter, realizing his project had failed, withdrew most of his forces from Calabria, including all his gunboats and transports, Murat was unable to afford the expense of keeping his troops mobilized for invasion. He also feared running

the risk of sickness in an area known to be plagued by malaria during the months of July and August. But to save face, he announced publicly that the point of the exercise had been achieved. Napoleon told him he ought to have kept his army concentrated, to deceive the British, and that he was immediately to resume a threatening posture in regard to Sicily.²⁴ When Stuart reacted as Napoleon desired and for fear of weakening Sicily's defenses refused to send more troops to Spain, he was overruled by Liverpool and resigned his appointment in disgust.²⁵ The court meanwhile declined to order any public celebration of the island's deliverance.²⁶

Sicily continued to remain vulnerable. The foreign troops under British command were of a very mixed quality, and two regiments were singled out as being especially unsatisfactory. The British forces covered only the area from Milazzo to Faro and then south to Cape Passaro and, apart from Trapani where they had a small garrison, the rest of the island was very exposed, guarded by an army of 9,000 virtually useless royal troops. As for protection by the British navy, this was entirely dependent on the weather. The ships could not operate off Calabria in the teeth of a strong northeasterly wind and might always be inhibited by currents or periodic calms (as Nelson had stressed earlier). On 18 September 1810 the fleet had not been able to prevent the bulk of Cavaignac's invading force from returning safely to Reggio, nor to stop Murat's fleet of 600 ships from making its retreat to the north, unscathed, save by volleys from coastal batteries. It is true that a fortnight afterward a flotilla of 110 of these boats was successfully intercepted off the coast of Calabria and that thirty-six of them were destroyed, but the bulk of Murat's invasion armada contrived to return to Naples intact.²⁷

Nevertheless the ministry in London was not inclined to be pessimistic, no doubt influenced in their views by the conclusions of a military report submitted early in 1811. This report considered that the British garrison, amounting to 15,000 troops, could repel any attack from the east. And if the French were to land in the west, conveyed by a strong naval force from Toulon that might always evade the British fleet, it would still be months before they could drag their heavy siege guns across the mountains to reduce the fortresses of Messina and Milazzo. By which time, it was safely reckoned, the navy would have come to evacuate the army.²⁸ In refusing to strengthen Sicily further at the expense of Spain and Portugal, the ministers took a calculated risk, but one that proved in the end to be justified.

Lord William Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage One

As the constitutional crisis worsened in the early months of 1811, so did relations between the court and British officials, civil and military. The refusal of the Sicilian parliament to grant the king the money he had asked for led him to try to raise taxes by decree—a patent violation of the constitution. The royal edicts of 14 February imposed a tax of 1 percent on all sales, including those made by British merchants, and confiscated properties belonging to the church and to various charitable communities, which were then ordered to be sold by public lottery.

When the British merchants protested strongly that the sales tax was contrary to the treaty signed with Britain by Spain in 1667 and renewed by the Palermo court as recently as 1809, they received the cursory reply they should either comply or leave the island. The court was irritated not only by this protest but by the appeal being made to London by Prince Belmonte and other barons, calling for the repeal of the royal decrees and the summoning of a parliament. Protests on behalf of British subjects arrested and detained in Sicily and on behalf of the captain and owners of a ship flying the British flag, captured by three of Castrone's privateers, were all rejected out of hand, and the British Consul General, Robert Fagan, when he tried to remonstrate with Circello, was accorded a less than polite reception. He was then suspended from all his functions on the grounds that he was interfering with the normal judicial processes.¹ Meanwhile five leaders of the dissident barons, including Belmonte and Castelnuevo, were arrested and deported to the smaller islands.

All the tension this generated was made worse by the growing suspicion that the queen was involved in treachery. As early as March 1810, Amherst had drawn London's attention to the queen's change of attitude toward Napoleon, after she had learned of the latter's intended marriage to her granddaughter, Princess Marie-Louise. There was evidence that the queen was corresponding with the government in Paris through Vienna, with the French consulate in Tunis, and with Lucien Bonaparte, a prisoner in Malta. In February 1811, reports reached Amherst that the queen had made a secret agreement by which the king was to get back Naples, while an Austrian

prince was to rule in Sicily with the support of German troops. Though Circello, on behalf of the court, made a solemn denial of these rumors and assured Amherst that the king still remained staunchly loyal to the British alliance, Amherst professed himself dissatisfied, until the king conceded a unified command.²

Meanwhile the government in London had at last followed Moore's advice, given to it by him four years earlier, namely to combine the offices in Sicily of diplomat and military commander as they had once been under General Fox. On 25 February 1811 Lord William Bentinck was appointed to this post—envoy extraordinary, minister plenipotentiary, and commander-in-chief of the British forces.³ Bentinck was a man of wide experience in both the military and administrative fields, having seen active service in Spain, Italy, and the Netherlands, and from 1803 to 1807 he had governed the province of Madras. Described by his most recent biographer as possessing something of the energy and forthrightness of a great Victorian public servant, cool in action and very determined, a Whig idealist but not doctrinaire, he was to fill for the next four years the unenviable and exacting role of a British proconsul in Sicily,⁴ which is what the ministry had decided that it wanted. His plain speaking as a straightforward soldier, as well as his somewhat charmless manner disguising what was a strong natural reserve, did not endear him to the court, and the queen who resented particularly his dictatorial attitude and actions described him as being a wild beast, a boorish sergeant, someone who having been sent to Sicily merely “in order to bow and scrape” had the temerity to give laws to the country.⁵ While the king, completely unaccustomed to hear such blunt language used to a sovereign, thought of Bentinck as an instrument of God, sent to punish him for all his sins.⁶

The British government had long been under pressure to intervene more in Sicilian affairs—pressures exerted by members of Parliament, a section of the popular press, the publications of Francis Leckie (the Scotsman who had farmed near Syracuse), British merchants who did business in Sicily, and also by a very influential book by the army captain Charles W. Pasley. Indeed the ministers had had some difficulty in persuading the irate Castelvicala that they were anxious to give such protection “to the honour and dignity of an ally” as the law allowed against offensive publications. A letter published in the *Morning Post* on 14 August 1810, which suggested that Sicily could only be saved by Britain annexing it and pensioning the king, caused the institution of legal proceedings, though a month later these were dropped. And a report in the *Morning Chronicle* on 2 May 1811 reporting the speech of a member of Parliament, in which he had said of Sicily that “a more profligate government or a more oppressed people did not exist or had not existed,” called forth further protests from Castelvicala and renewed demands that the editor of the newspaper be prosecuted.⁷ Captain Pasley's “Military Policy and Institutions



Lord William Cavendish Bentinck, painted by Sir T. Lawrence and engraved by R. J. Lane. (*Courtesy of the British Museum, London.*)

of the British Empire" was published in November 1810 and ran through four editions in two years. It was read and admired by many army officers, including Generals Wellington and Beresford, and it was favorably commented on in the *Quarterly Review* of May 1811.⁸

Pasley's thesis was that Sicily had not fulfilled the terms of the treaty under which it received a substantial subsidy, and instead of providing an efficient army, it absorbed 15,000 of the best British troops. "As long as we hold Sicily . . . without applying its revenues and resources to our own purposes, in return for the protection we afford it, it can only be compared to a millstone round our necks." He argued that Sicily was potentially an incomparable asset to Great Britain, and militarily of far more value than all the West Indies put together, yet the British government seemed to regard it as nothing more than an appendage of Malta. Britain should have conquered it in 1805, instead of earning unpopularity by propping up an incompetent monarchy. Pasley therefore proposed that a Britain general should be put in command of all troops in Sicily, and that commissariat and postal services should be placed forthwith under British direction.⁹

This may have made uncomfortable reading for the Perceval ministry in London, but in the end it was the resignations of both Amherst and Stuart coming together, that forced the government to rethink its policy.¹⁰

Bentinck was commissioned by Wellesley to produce a memorandum of his views, based on a reading of the relevant dispatches, before being given his instructions. His conclusions, which did not please all the cabinet, were that if Britain were to keep Sicily, she could not delay her intervention. Britain, he submitted, must control the subsidy, take command of all troops in the island, appoint Sicilians to the government, and ensure the reform of outstanding abuses. These measures would appeal to the people and might have a great effect on Italy. If the Sicilian court refused to accept them, then the minister should withdraw to Messina. The great and pressing evil in Sicily demanded a "speedy and decisive remedy," and unless he was given extraordinary powers he felt he could not perform the task or cope with all the "deceit, low cunning and intrigues of that miserable court."¹¹

The Prime Minister, Perceval, was not impressed by this reasoning. He pointed out that for the past five years every military authority had said the same thing, namely that the security of Sicily depended on effecting these reforms. Yet Sicily was still defended. The revolution envisaged by Bentinck would overthrow the royal prerogative and also noble and corporate privileges, and he was not convinced that the changes proposed would necessarily result in the promised gains. He did not believe in the queen's treachery and thought her jealousy of Britain understandable, and he did not feel that the use of violence was justified in the circumstances. Bentinck must be urged to accept the post, provided the views he submitted to the court were the British government's and not his own.¹²

It was for this reason that Bentinck's instructions specified that he must reassure the court. Britain, he must tell it, had no intention of interfering in its internal affairs or of trying to effect a revolution in the Sicilian constitution. Nevertheless the king and queen must be informed that Britain, being as anxious as they were to see them restored to the kingdom of Naples and equally anxious to use Sicily's resources in order to achieve this end, felt that the people must first be appeased. This could be done only by granting a share in the government to Sicilians, by paying heed to Sicily's parliament, and by redressing popular grievances. If the court was not willing to do these things and so was faced by a revolution, it could not expect from its British ally any military or other assistance.¹³

Bentinck's arrival in Sicily was awaited with both anxiety and hope, according to Douglas, the secretary of legation, who told Wellesley that most Sicilians would now "be satisfied with nothing less than the British flag flying all over Sicily," and a "total eradication of the abominable system."¹⁴ When he did arrive on 18 July, only two days had elapsed after the arrest of the five barons—something he thought not coincidental, for having learnt of his reputation the court was afraid he might enlist the support of these noble dissidents. He stayed in Sicily five weeks only, at the end of which he returned to England to report and to ask for wider powers. He had, during his very brief stay, encountered a completely negative attitude on the part of the king and queen and their ministers, who denied there was any sort of crisis and therefore the need for any measures to meet one. He was told that the levy of 1 percent had been entirely constitutional, the barons' protest had been illegal and disapproved of by parliament, the stories of popular discontent were entirely without foundation, and the barons who had lodged the protest were in no way representative. Although he considered it unlikely there would be a serious revolt with the opposition leaders removed, spies and informers everywhere, and the royal army disliking the people, Bentinck was convinced of the need for change—a change that could only be effected by controlling the British subsidy and by employing forcible language.¹⁵

Before he left Sicily for England, Bentinck had appointed General Frederick Maitland to act in his absence as his deputy, and Maitland soon convinced himself that the Sicilian government had joined hands with the enemy. Maitland wrote to Wellesley in some anxiety:

We are in such a state as our enemy would wish—we believe the Sicilian government to be plotting and combining for our ruin, and whether from consciousness of their intrigues with Bonaparte or from apprehension that we will bring about a change of government, from a despotic one, which it now is, to a mixed one—certain it is, they distrust and fear us as much as we do them.¹⁶

And when Bentinck returned to the island in the late autumn of 1811, Maitland had just unearthed a plot that seemed to involve the court in

treachery. It entailed the suborning of German troops (part of the garrison of Messina), the seizure of the Faro fort, and an invitation to the French in Calabria to cross over without opposition. Sixteen people in all were arrested, including the colonel of the Sicilian flotilla, the principal judge, and an army captain. And a soldier of the Calabrian corps (who was arrested by a British patrol) was tried summarily by court martial and executed without further ado. The bishop of Oppido was also arrested, although by royal command and at Maitland's request.

In regard to the earlier "conspiracies," revealed in the letters sent from Calabria that had been seized by the British authorities and had seemed to implicate the queen, the king had been anxious to demonstrate his continuing loyalty to the alliance. The incriminating letters, so Circello pointed out, were clearly intended by whomever sent them (the agents of Murat in Calabria) to fall into the hands of the British, and so were designed to sow suspicion between Britain and Sicily. In November therefore the king had ordered the printing of a special dispatch to be given the widest distribution in which he condemned all such attempts to stir up discord between the allies. And in order to discourage future messengers, armed with such letters and carrying false papers, he decreed that any such persons caught were to be hanged within twenty-four hours of their having been found guilty of the offence. The British commander, Sir Frederick Maitland, was asked to assist in smuggling copies of this dispatch to Calabria, which Maitland of course agreed to do.¹⁷

But then had come the revelations of a "real" conspiracy at Messina. The king took violent offense at what seemed to be the high handed manner in which Maitland had handled the business. He could not, so Circello protested, allow his subjects to be put on trial by the representative of another power, and he therefore ordered a special court, to include two British officers, to be set up to try the accused. He also took very great exception to a proclamation that Maitland had issued appealing for the support of Sicilians for the British forces protecting Sicily—a proclamation that had been made without the permission of the king, and one in which no mention was made of any alliance between Britain and Sicily. And the king took further grave exception to the promise, publicly made by Maitland, to pardon all those who might turn "king's evidence." Pardon was, it was pointed out, the prerogative of the king alone.¹⁸

By this time Bentinck had returned to Sicily and he had to apologize to the king for the tactlessness of his deputy. The need for speed in taking action in what seemed desperate circumstances had led Maitland, he feared, to forget due forms. But what Bentinck refused to accept was the kind of tribunal the king envisaged for trying the men accused of treason. The persons arrested had been detected in the very center of the British camp and at the headquarters of the commander-in-chief, and he therefore insisted that the court to try them must be appointed by him alone. It should be composed in equal parts

of British and Sicilian officers and he himself must appoint its president. He also asked for authority to arrest and punish summarily anyone found inside the British defenses who either aided the enemy or was in correspondence with him. To the latter request the king demurred on the grounds that the matter was no longer urgent, but he did accede to other demands about the appointment of a "council of war" and the way in which it was to be composed.¹⁹

The most important figure in the plot, Captain Rossaroll, an infantry officer and chief of the royal police in Messina, was tried by an Anglo-Sicilian court, sentenced to death and subsequently hanged.²⁰ Though Rossaroll did not reveal at his trial he had been acting on behalf of the queen, Bentinck had evidence enough to prove that her advisers were deeply involved. Another of her agents, Captain Cassetti, had earlier been arrested in Palermo and the letters he carried seemed to show on whose behalf he must have been acting in the contacts he had established with Murat.²¹ The threat to publish the relevant documents was one Bentinck used against the court, and the fact that the king refused to examine them showed he knew that they were not forgeries. But he told Orleans that although the queen had committed many indiscretions, he could not believe she would go so far as to correspond with the enemy.²²

These plots were only the culmination of intrigues that had been detected a year before, revealing the queen to be rather more of an inveterate schemer than a serious danger. Castlereagh told Castelficala that although he was convinced of her treachery, which meant that she could not stay in Sicily, he thought she had acted in a moment of passion and not with any premeditation. Bentinck himself never believed that the queen really meant to give the French Sicily, and he thought that only her love of intrigue, her love for Naples, and her Anglophobia had led her to compromise herself.²³

It seems that the initial reactions in both London and Messina to events in Sicily during 1811 had been overdone. One shrewd observer in Messina, the wife of a senior British officer and clearly a woman of some intelligence, wrote home of the alarmist reports then being circulated in England about the state of unrest in Sicily and the spy scare that for several months had caused a flurry in military circles:

Each party speaks boastfully and threatens much—but in each there is so little spirit and real energy and so little genuine patriotism or power of pursuing consistently for any length of time one steady undeviating course—that small indeed is the reliance to be placed in anything said or projected by either party—a Sicilian talks loud and long, sometimes even well—but he has rarely the resolution or courage necessary for action.²⁴

That was in August 1811. Five months later, she wrote on the same theme:

So far from the people of the island being in a state of insurrection, as has been asserted in many of your newspapers—the total apathy with which

they regard the changes now making in their government is astonishing even to us, who have had for so long an acquaintance with their want of sense and good feeling in any matters savouring of patriotism.²⁵

In regard to the trials in Messina to investigate allegations of treachery, she described how the mountain of the council of war, of which her husband had been a member, had labored long to produce its mouse. (It had sat for seven weeks and examined an enormous volume of written evidence.) The prisoners accused of selling the island had, the court found, merely offered to trade some trifling details to the French in Calabria about British strengths and dispositions, only in order to obtain facilities for promoting a trade in contraband.²⁶

Bentinck had returned from England armed with the power to withhold the subsidy if the court refused to accept his demands. These were: the immediate appointment of Sicilians to positions of influence, the conceding of a unified command, the recall of the five exiled barons, and the removal of anti-British advisers.²⁷ He proceeded at once to use this power, though it did not yield instantaneous results. His interviews with the king and queen and Marquis Circello all proved fruitless, so he sent for a regiment from Malta and ordered his troops at Milazzo and Trapani to embark on transports and sail for Palermo. As he wrote to General Oakes, the civil commissioner in Malta, "this uncertainty will never be determined until force, or the appearance of force, shall produce the necessity of a decision." It was a policy that Robert Fagan had urged on him the previous September ("every point will be obtained in four hours . . . Good God, what ridiculous and ill-judged delicacy has directed our conduct till the present").²⁸ And indeed there were many others, generals, admirals and diplomats, who had acquaintance with Sicily and the political position there, who had written him letters of encouragement, urging him to take a very firm line.

In a stormy interview with the queen, Bentinck found himself accused of trying to dethrone the king, whose only course, so the queen declared, was to lead his army into Italy and die in the breach, like Tippoo Sultan.²⁹ She ridiculed the whole idea of choosing Sicilians as ministers—people "who could neither read nor write"—yet there was little she could do.³⁰ She was however almost certainly responsible for encouraging an officer called Melito to try to stir up the mob in the capital, and Bentinck now decided to make that city the future headquarters of the British garrison.³¹

The king offered to abdicate (a course that Bentinck himself favored) and was only dissuaded by the queen. But in the face of the military threat, he did agree to appoint his eldest son, the hereditary prince, as vicar general (a course that the queen had also opposed), although he refused to delegate any control over foreign affairs. He also agreed to a unified command, with Bentinck henceforth as captain general, and to recalling the five barons without any conditions attached.³²

Yet despite his apparent victory, Bentinck discovered that little was hap-

pening, and he began to regret his precipitancy in resuming the payment of the British subsidy. The court was expert at procrastination, and the hereditary prince was no exception, being far more under the influence of his parents than Bentinck had either supposed or hoped. The prince tried to have the former ministers, including Circello, retained as councillors, a course to which Bentinck strongly objected, given their unprogressive views and general unpopularity. And the prince also took the view that to summon parliament at this time, when popular opinion was so inflamed, would merely be courting revolution, despite Bentinck's attempt to impress on him that nothing less than a parliament could solve the country's financial problems and introduce much-needed reforms. The king, who together with the queen really governed the hereditary prince, was convinced that Bentinck had exceeded his powers, and he therefore counted on Bentinck's recall before a parliament could be summoned and a new constitution introduced. For that reason he advised the prince to delay in effecting any change.³³

A new ministry was eventually formed of four members of the Sicilian nobility: Belmonte, Castelnovo, Cassaro, and Aci, though not until March 1812, and even then it failed to gain the hereditary prince's confidence. Parliament did not meet until May and no progress whatsoever was made toward adopting a new constitution. There were still too many anti-British advisers who surrounded the king and queen, even if the worst had been removed (Ascoli exiled to Sardinia,³⁴ Castrone shut up in Castellamare, and Medici allowed to go to England in order to plead the cause of the queen there). Bentinck was certain that the queen was the real cause of all the delay. She was responsible, according to Belmonte, for spreading rumors that the latter was trying to get rid of the hereditary prince and set up a regency under Orleans. Orleans was the intimate of Belmonte and also the trusted friend of Bentinck, whom, through his link with the royal family, he was able to keep very well informed of what was being thought and done at court. Orleans told the hereditary prince that he was wrong to suspect him of wanting his place; that if he wanted that he would not try so hard to reconcile him to the British command. But the rumor, once started, was hard to scotch, and Bentinck thought it was one of the reasons for the unpopularity of the British.³⁵

Bentinck tried without any success to persuade the queen to leave Sicily, letting her know he was well acquainted with her agents dealings with the enemy. She grew by turns angry and tearful at the harshness of Bentinck's inflexibility, his attempt to get rid of her "as if she were nothing but a common prostitute," and his refusal to pay her debts, and she resolutely declined to move.³⁶ The court had been banking on Bentinck's support for an expedition to Italy and had therefore professed to approve of the idea of Sicily having a new constitution, having been convinced by Moliterno of the magical importance of that word as the key that would unlock the kingdom

of Naples. Moliterno himself liked to pose as the leader of an Italian resistance movement, obtaining the queen's support by suggesting she herself might eventually become the ruler of all Italy. But Bentinck made clear he would not allow any Italian expedition until Sicily was given the free constitution he wished her to have. And when British troops in Sicily were ordered to Spain and not Italy, the court lost interest in the constitution.³⁷

Bentinck's frustration reached breaking point when he found himself obstructed in measures for reforming the royal army in Sicily, whose condition he considered such that "no officer could lead it to the field with any confidence of victory." The hereditary prince refused to allow him to issue orders except through the minister, on the grounds that he had no authority from the king and that Bentinck had already agreed to Sicily being governed by Sicilian ministers. The minister in question was Aci, a man who, Bentinck came to think, had "more vanity than patriotism," was certainly incompetent, and deeply resented having to share the credit for army reform with anyone. Bentinck therefore decided he had once again to step in and withhold the subsidy.³⁸ The Sicilian reaction was immediate. Parliament, though it had been elected in the spring, had not been summoned till 8 July, and since then it had done nothing at all. It now met on 20 July and passed all the fundamental articles (or *Bases*) of the constitution in one all-night sitting.³⁹

The constitution approved by the parliament provided for a bicameral legislature with the exclusive power of making laws, and one to which government ministers and public officials were now responsible. Parliament was to meet at least once a year, though the king had the right to prorogue and dissolve it, as well as the right to veto laws. The king was given a civil list, while the Commons controlled all public expenditure. The judiciary were independent; there was trial by jury and the right of *habeas corpus*, and relative freedom of the press. But only the literate had the right to vote and the right to sit in parliament (which meant about 15,000 men out of a population of a million-and-a-half). The guilds and all religious bodies were to lose all their privileges, while feudal rights and entail were abolished, with certain provisions made for compensation. Sicily was declared independent, the king was forbidden to leave the island without the consent of parliament, and a provision was made, if he went back to Naples, for his eldest son to remain as viceroy.⁴⁰

The modelling of the constitution on the English prototype was deliberate, because in Sicily (outside Catania) there was more sympathy for English ideas of the politically enlightened kind than for those of Rousseau and the French Revolution, and Balsamo, who drafted the constitution, was well versed in English common law as well as in the writings of Blackstone. It was not originally Bentinck's intention that the constitution should be so modelled, although he had been given complete discretion by Castlereagh to make recommendations. And he had at first opposed the idea of copying the

English constitution, since he rightly thought it unsuited to Sicily. He had told Belmonte that because the English constitution was such that no one understood it or was able even to define it, to adopt it as a model was inviting ridicule. Later however he changed his mind, but only because no alternative plan seemed to present fewer difficulties.⁴¹ The king believed that the English constitution safeguarded the royal prerogative; the queen, who derived her knowledge from Medici, concluded that it was largely nonexistent, while what did exist was largely negative.⁴² But if Bentinck did not beget the constitution, he was certainly an active midwife at its birth. The Italian historian Capograssi thinks that without Bentinck's enthusiasm it could never have seen the light of day. But clearly this enthusiasm got the better of his sober judgment and led him to imagine that Sicily, because it had for so many centuries boasted of having a constitution, must have had the necessary experience to assimilate a new one on the English model.⁴³

The king was at first most unwilling to sanction the resolutions of the parliament, and adopted his usual delaying tactics. When pressed by Bentinck, he became very angry, exclaiming "Never, never, never" would he assent to the constitution. An English constitution, yes, but this was neither English nor Sicilian. But the threat of withholding the subsidy proved in the end to be decisive, because it was obvious that without it the army would not be paid or fed. The king therefore signified his agreement to the prince, although he insisted that he approved only of those articles that conformed with the English constitution.⁴⁴ He even talked of sending it to England, to be scrutinized and reported on, but in his heart he could never bring himself to approve of any new constitution. He later told Bentinck that he was afraid that the changes it brought could only end in bloodshed, revolution, and anarchy. "We are living with cannibals," he said, and fearing for his life and property and for those of his family, he wanted a warship standing by to carry them off to some safe haven.⁴⁵

The hereditary prince was also, at heart, no enthusiast for the constitution, and he filled the role allotted to him out of fear rather than genuine conviction. He was fond of repeating the Latin tag *Nescit regnare qui nescit simulare* (He knows not how to reign who knows not how to feign), and Bentinck was amazed that such a "blockhead" should be so adept at dissimulation. In his private correspondence with Castelvicala, the prince complained of being bullied by Bentinck (of whom he was obviously afraid), as well as reviled by his father and mother, the queen calling him a villain and the king accusing him of ambition. Belmonte thought his character was "like that of a woman, subject very much to change," while Bentinck told the Duke of Orleans that it was only fear or force that would ever induce the prince to act. Bentinck thought he was terrified of being damned for disobliging his parents, "always seeing Hell on one side and the reproach of posterity on the other." Not possessing a strong character, the prince tried merely to keep afloat, refrain-

ing from compromising himself in the hope of preserving the dynasty. When he gave his approval to the constitution, he gave it in a qualified form, and he excepted from his approval articles relating to the civil list, the right of parliament to control expenditures, and compensation for the loss of civil rights.⁴⁶

Much (too much) of Bentinck's time was given up to getting rid of the queen, to whose presence in Sicily, it can now be seen, he attached an exaggerated importance. The king liked to shelter behind the queen, making out that it was she, not he, who was really the cause of any obstructions. The king, in his attitude to the queen's removal, was, according to Belmonte, a cunning "old Fox," pretending he could not get his wife to leave in order to make the British use force and thereby enhance his own prestige.⁴⁷ In October 1812 Bentinck at last after considerable difficulty persuaded the king to induce the queen to go away to Santa Margherita (a town in the southwest of the island and far enough from the king and Prince), the king meanwhile living at La Ficuzza, a shooting lodge thirty miles from Palermo. The queen arranged that the following spring she would leave the island altogether, having been promised by the Habsburg emperor that she would be welcome to come to Vienna (although in fact the emperor did not want her there but found it impossible to refuse her). Yet two months later she was pleading her debts and her poverty as reasons for staying.⁴⁸ Castlereagh supported Bentinck in his efforts to exclude the queen from government and engineer her departure from Sicily, having been considerably impressed by the documents that Bentinck had sent him. He made clear to Castelficala that Britain could no longer tolerate someone who stood in the way of change, misled foreign powers like Austria and Russia about Britain's future intentions for Sicily, and engaged in treasonable correspondences. He did however in writing to Bentinck stress his desire to save the queen's face by avoiding the use of any force, and to make her leaving Sicily appear to have been done by arrangement only.⁴⁹ But when in April 1813 this dispatch arrived in Sicily, events had overtaken it and induced Bentinck to use forcible methods.

Bentinck was angry when he found that the queen, in breach of the previous agreement, had returned to Ficuzza to be once more with the king; and still more angry when the king denied he had made any promise in regard to the queen, asserting that the written undertaking, signed on his behalf by Cassaro and Circelló, had merely been an expression of his wishes.⁵⁰ Bentinck was already most dissatisfied with the influence that the duke of Ascoli (though in exile) continued to have on the king through his aide-de-camp Colonel Frilli, who acted as the king's secretary, and through Lonzelot, comptroller of the royal household. And to compound matters, the king (he found) was consulting Cassaro and other barons who, disliking the idea of abolishing entail, had split the ministry and turned to the crown. Although parliament had since November completed its work on the constitution, the



Royal shooting lodge, La Ficuzza. (*Photo by M. Woolley.*)

king had, to Bentinck's annoyance, so far made no move to give it his sanction.⁵¹

Bentinck was also increasingly frustrated at what he regarded as the weakness of the ministry—the lack of mutual confidence shown between ministers and the hereditary prince, disunion among ministers themselves, and the lack of cabinet government as that was understood in England. Bentinck said that all he could give was support to the administration—it was for ministers to lead the House. Belmonte in whom hitherto Bentinck had reposed such confidence now seemed “blinded by his own vanity,” could not apply himself to business, and was quite hopeless as a prime minister. Without assuming the government himself, Bentinck found it difficult to take a firmer line, as Orleans was urging him to do. “We appeared to have everything our own way and to have all the power . . . while in fact we have nothing. . . .”⁵²

Bentinck through Belmonte now approached the king, requesting that he sanction the constitution, call a new parliament as soon as possible, and order the queen away from Ficuzza. Although the queen was induced to go to Castelvetro in the south of the island, the king on 9 March 1813 arrived unexpectedly in Palermo and announced that he was resuming power, without informing either Bentinck or the prince. Acclaimed vociferously in the streets, he seemed to be returning in triumph, an event that was celebrated

shortly after by a solemn *Te Deum* being sung in the cathedral. But two days later he had to endure a stormy interview with Bentinck during which the latter told him plainly that he would not permit him to destroy the constitution. The king was furious at what he regarded as Bentinck's arrogant and threatening tone. He kept repeating the word "permit" with ever increasing irritation, arguing that Britain had no right to meddle in Sicily's internal affairs.⁵³

For the next fortnight Bentinck endeavored to treat with the king through intermediaries (as the king refused to see him personally)—the king's confessor, Prince Belmonte, the hereditary prince, and the duke of Orleans. Relations became increasingly strained, with Belmonte and all the ministers resigning, the king still adamant in his refusal to let Bentinck treat him (in his own words) as if Bentinck was his schoolmaster, and Bentinck widely reported as saying he would have the king and queen taken to London while he set up a regency in the island.⁵⁴ Both the king and queen still clung to the hope that Bentinck was unsupported in London. Castelficala had recently assured them that the ministers in Britain left their officials overseas without any definite instructions—if they succeeded, the ministers took the credit, while if they failed, they broke their neck.⁵⁵ Since the mail between England and Sicily could take from two to three months to arrive, it was easy enough to insinuate that Britain's representative had exceeded his instructions. It was a ploy that Paoli had used eighteen years earlier in Corsica when he had successfully undermined the morale of the British viceroy. But Bentinck was made of sterner stuff than the strangely self-doubting Gilbert Elliot, and Castlereagh was more punctual in answering dispatches than the ever-dilatory Duke of Portland.

After a week Bentinck's patience was exhausted and he finally decided on the use of force. When he heard that the king was about to attend another thanksgiving service in the capital, and fearing a popular disturbance would follow, he ordered his troops and guns onto the streets, and threatened the king with the end of the alliance. At one stage he even contemplated forcing the king to abdicate in favor of the hereditary prince and then making the king his prisoner, but he realized his instructions did not allow for this.⁵⁶ There was of course no attempt at resistance. The king agreed to delegate *all* his powers to the hereditary prince and accepted that the queen must be ordered to leave. In return, his civil list was confirmed and the queen was assured financial solvency. Even then, in order to get the king to put this agreement in writing, Bentinck had to post fifty dragoons on the road out of the palace at Colli in case the king should try to escape and raise a civil war in the countryside. What the king now put his signature to was a promise not only to restore the Vicariate but also not to resume his powers until permitted by Bentinck to do so.⁵⁷ Before finally signing the agreement, the king had made yet one final effort to slip out of the political noose by offering to make

Bentinck his prime minister or "Grand Chancellor." Not unnaturally this offer was refused, Bentinck replying that he could not see how any foreigner could hold such a post.⁵⁸

The king thus put firmly on one side, it only remained to deal with the queen and those advisers of the court who were known to be unfriendly to the constitution. The hereditary prince, at Bentinck's request, relieved of their posts the king's recent supporters, the barons Cassaro, Cutò, and Aci, agreed to deprive of all influence Tommasi, Hesse, and Circello, and ordered out of Sicily foreigners like Frilli and Moliterno.⁵⁹ To the queen, who was still at Castelvetro, Bentinck sent Macfarlane, a tactful general, with orders to ensure she left Sicily and to make arrangements for her departure. To make certain that the queen complied and did not attempt to raise the people, Bentinck dispatched three battalions of infantry, together with a squadron of cavalry. There was no physical resistance, but a great many protests and delays (some of them caused by the queen's ill-health) until she finally departed from Mazzara on 14 June 1813. She sailed aboard a British warship, escorted by two more, travelled to Vienna via Constantinople, and died there in September 1814 shortly after her arrival. Financially she had been generously treated, the British government paying her debts, redeeming her personal jewels from pawn, and granting her a respectable allowance. Whether she had really been worth so much trouble and all this expense is perhaps debatable. What is certain is that her removal was not a solution to the island's problems or to those of the British in Sicily.⁶⁰

Bentinck now appeared to have triumphed, though he regretted that the relevant dispatches had arrived too late to make his coup needless. For what the dispatches did was make clear what the queen had been trying to cast a doubt on (thus bringing on a political crisis), namely that Bentinck had the support of the British ministers in London. But now he felt certain that the matter was resolved, the queen's influence was finally extinguished ("the cause of all our past embarrassments"), the king was neutralized, the prince had full powers, and the ministry enjoyed his confidence. It was one in whose work he now played a full part, attending the council regularly and meeting ministers at his house or theirs to discuss tactics and policies, and the shaping of the new constitution. So involved had Bentinck become in bestowing a constitution on Sicily that he gave the matter priority over all other considerations, including the question urged by the British ministers of his taking over the command in Spain. It seemed to the egregious Sir Robert Wilson (disliked by Bentinck for his interference in the politics of the court at Palermo), who was staying in Sicily at this time, that the British were "preparing for a crusade, with the British code of laws on the points of our bayonets."⁶¹

Bentinck felt that he could now boast that the old system against which the British had been contending for the past six years had at last been "com-

pletely demolished.”⁶² But there is a certain irony about this boast. Only eight months before he had told Bunbury, “We are now masters and kings if you please,”⁶³ while seven months later he was to find himself forced to assume the role of dictator.

Castlereagh was not entirely pleased when he learnt from Bentinck what had happened in March. “We must,” he wrote back, “so try to arrange as to obviate the necessity of frequent acts of undisguised power.” Withholding the subsidy, he thought, should be a sufficient curb on the king, and stronger measures ought not to be necessary.⁶⁴ It was certainly true that financial embarrassment continued to force the king and the prince to lean heavily on the British. The king complained of being burdened by debt, which he would not allow parliament to shoulder, fearing that the latter might at some time call him publicly to account. Bentinck, who the previous November had intervened to prevent parliament voting as much as a fifth of its revenue to meet the needs of the royal family, now had to lend the king and the prince enough money to tide them over.⁶⁵ But he thought that the situation in Sicily was sufficiently stable for him to leave it to take command in eastern Spain, where his army had in the past few months suffered from unsatisfactory leadership. Accordingly he sailed from the island on 27 May 1813, delegating to Lord Montgomerie his plenary powers as minister. Neither Belmonte nor Orleans had wanted Bentinck to go away, but the latter felt it his only chance for what he termed “recovering his troops,” by which he meant, presumably, being able to retain a lien on them for a future Italian expedition.⁶⁶ Even so, he took the precaution of taking with him a private letter in which Belmonte had given him warning of democratic perils ahead, so that he could, if the occasion demanded, justify a sudden return to Sicily.⁶⁷

Lord William Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage Two

During the absence of Bentinck in Spain, things went badly wrong in Sicily, indeed so wrong that government, through lack of funds, was brought completely to a standstill, and parliament refused to grant money until its radical demands were met. Why things went wrong is a matter for debate. The Abbate Balsamo took the view that the troubles were really entirely due to the absence of Bentinck's guiding hand in a political scene that was highly volatile.¹ Bentinck's biographer, Dr. Rosselli, does not go as far as this, but he does consider that Bentinck's presence would have prevented much of the friction—friction between Sicilians and British and between the various political factions.² Another historian, Dr. Lackland, thinks that much of the trouble stemmed from the recent departure of the queen, fear and dislike for whom had for so long bound together the parliamentarians. But she does concede that with Bentinck there things would not have reached the pitch they did, even though he could not have prevented a radical movement from emerging.³

There is one factor that stands out in the turbulent scene of the summer months and that is the degree to which popular feeling was now directed against the British, something that struck Bentinck forcibly when he eventually returned to the island.⁴ It was they who had backed the constitution, and its enemies were not slow to associate all current troubles with the British presence. The British were really an obvious scapegoat for every fresh ill that affected the island, whether it was the threat of plague, the high prices of food in the towns, or the use of troops and martial law to restore order in the capital. A very serious outbreak of plague that affected Malta in 1813 had resulted in the Sicilian government imposing strict quarantine regulations and interpreting them in such a way that trade with the outside world was stopped. The British merchants were furious that licenses were being refused them to allow the landing of goods and passengers even from plague-free England and Spain, while attempts to get a relaxation of the total prohibition against ships from Malta calling at any Sicilian port gave rise to public accusations of officials' disregarding public safety. The British army too was incensed at the government's lack of cooperation in even the simplest

matters of routine, its refusal to allow troops to land and even to permit the landing of some cavalry horses dispatched from Egypt. The question of the horses became so sensitive that it gave rise to a debate in parliament. The horses were landed in defiance of the rules, on express orders from General Macfarlane, but eventually they were sent off to Spain, after Lord Montgomerie intervened. Marching the horses across the island would, he realized, have meant using force.⁵

Force did have to be used in Palermo when on 18 and 19 July 1813 riots and disorders occurred in the capital. Provoked initially by the shortages of food and the profiteering accompanying them, they were naturally exploited by all those people who were eager to discredit the ministry. Indeed the food crisis had been induced by the removal of price controls—a policy adopted by Castelnovo, minister of finance and a disciple of free trade—and Bentinck was forced a few months later to reintroduce a “law of the maximum.” British troops and artillery had to be used to restore order and the ringleaders of the revolt were executed.⁶

But all this was merely the background to a major constitutional crisis. A split had occurred in the ranks of the ministry and its supporters in parliament, brought about by differences over abolishing feudal rights and entail. It was an ideological argument that divided Belmonte from his uncle Castelnovo, though strong personal and material considerations also entered into it, causing Belmonte to turn his coat in order to side with the democrats.⁷ There had emerged in the parliament a radical democratic party led by men influenced by France and the ideas of the French Revolution. Chief among these was a lawyer Rossi (the so-called “Mirabeau of Sicily”) and an ex-shopkeeper called Gaspare Vaccaro, president of the Board of Health (a body the British found highly obstructive). The latter was so plausible that he made quite an impression on Bentinck, who later described him favorably as being both “able and educated.”⁸ Both Vaccaro and Rossi, had spent some time living in revolutionary France, and Rossi had no love for the English, having once been imprisoned by Nelson. These two and their followers (men from the Sicily outside Palermo who were jealous of the capital and all that it represented) stood for the destruction of noble privileges and for a fairer distribution of wealth—cheaper food, agrarian reform, the breaking up of great estates, more church property to be sold, and an equitable system of taxation. They were certainly not the red revolutionaries of the extreme Jacobin kind, though their radicalism so alarmed the British that Macfarlane did not consider it safe to dispatch any reinforcements to Spain. Their tactic in the parliament was the classic one of steadily refusing to vote any taxes, and referring everything to committees on which they were always well represented, until their first demand was met—the amalgamation of the houses of parliament.⁹

At the end of July 1813 the ministry resigned, demoralized by Belmonte’s

opportunism and frightened of a probable vote of censure for having introduced martial law. Montgomerie managed to get the prince to appoint a phantom ministry in order to maintain the semblance of government, and he toyed with the idea of a dissolution, which Orleans favored but the prince did not.¹⁰ Bentinck had written to dissuade Montgomerie not only from dissolving parliament, but also from using violence against men like Rossi. Neither the press nor parliament in Britain would tolerate arresting men merely on account of their opinions, and in any event he did not think a revolution in Sicily likely, the people in general being far too timid. If there was to be a revolution, it was better that it should come from the actions of the parliament than from any unconstitutional acts of the crown.¹¹

Montgomerie accepted Bentinck's advice. Nevertheless he persuaded the prince to veto two resolutions of parliament that he regarded as dangerous: an attempt to get control of the army by using it to enforce the quarantine, and sending a deputation to London to complain of the conduct of British generals. At one stage he went so far as to threaten the parliament with instant dissolution if it still refused to vote supplies, it now having adopted the ruse of voting enough for a few months only, with the aim (or so Montgomerie thought) of perpetuating its existence and becoming a kind of Sicilian Long Parliament. When in the face of Montgomerie's threat it did vote taxes for a year ahead, it still did not vote the ways and means by which those taxes could be raised, so Montgomerie got the prince to prorogue it until Bentinck returned at the start of October.¹²

Bentinck left Spain reluctantly and to Wellington's extreme displeasure, and only because of the urgent pleas of the hereditary prince, the duke of Orleans, Generals Montgomerie and Macfarlane, and a number of Sicilian constitutionalists.¹³ He was, it was clear, the only man who could resolve the crisis in Sicily. Montgomerie and his secretary Joseph Smith had been suffering from the effects of ill-health (they both died before the year was out), and neither had the experience to deal with the complex political situation that had developed since Bentinck left, Montgomerie being no diplomatist and Smith being new to Sicily.¹⁴

Bentinck landed once more in Sicily on 3 October 1813. At once he set about trying to find a solution through the parliament, addressing its members personally and lobbying them in a final endeavor to get the financial measures adopted. When this failed, he had to resort to getting the prince to dissolve the parliament having appointed a new ministry whose members Bentinck picked himself.¹⁵ But this ministry, for all its compliance, did not have the required courage to proclaim a state of emergency, which Bentinck now reckoned to be essential, if only because attacks on property had brought in a new and alarming element. So Bentinck himself proclaimed the emergency, assuming full responsibility for maintaining order in the island. He ordered his troops to march into the interior, where apparently they were

well received, and he threatened with trial by a military court anyone who disturbed the peace. He had become, like Oliver Cromwell, a military dictator *malgré lui*.¹⁶

This patent admission of failure to find a political solution of a liberal kind, toward which his principles propelled him, underlined his now deep disillusion with Sicilians as political animals. The hereditary prince he now regarded as weaker than the weakest of his subjects; Belmonte as more dangerous as a friend than an enemy; the nobles as lacking in education, courage, and the knowledge of public affairs; and the people as wanting the advantages of liberty without being prepared to serve or to pay for them.¹⁷ Bentinck seemed at last to have been converted to the views of the consul general Fagan. The latter for months had been counselling him to use the methods of a dictator with this people who failed to show any respect for familiarity or kindly treatment—"too long accustomed to the rod of iron not to get wild when you give them a certain liberty."¹⁸ Yet really Bentinck had known it all along. Writing in his journal in June 1812 he had referred to the Sicilians as "bullies, only to be managed by fear; they take advantage of the least concessions and always construe conciliation into weakness."¹⁹ "Vanity was the great defect of the country" he had again confided to his journal, and he "doubted whether [they] were made for freedom." It was a pity, he came to think, that the court had not paid attention to him when he first arrived in Sicily, for it would have been easier for the British to act through one single authority (the king) than through a Sicilian parliament.²⁰

The nobles who at the beginning led the movement for the constitution were now for the most part content to destroy it, frightened of the prospect of universal suffrage and of the nationalization of private land. They had imagined they were going to return to their positions in the Middle Ages, free of the kind of royal restrictions imposed at the end of the eighteenth century by the king's reforming viceroys. When they realized that what they had opened was in fact a Pandora's box of change, they saw the time had come to backtrack. As Joseph Smith succinctly expressed it, "Rather than yield to the people they would yield to the crown again."²¹ In these circumstances Bentinck had felt he had no alternative but to intervene. "Sicily can only be saved from political convulsions by our interference . . . if we don't direct, the enemy will."²²

As Luisa Giardina has pointed out in her article on Bentinck and his Sicilian journal, Bentinck had not initially been someone intent on the use of force or convinced that he must direct the Sicilians. Rather it had been Belmonte who had pressed him continually to be more ruthless and chided him for being too moderate and goodnatured. But Belmonte, as Bentinck came to realize, was largely interested in using the British to get rid of his enemies for him, and he had even tried in Bentinck's absence to induce Smith and Montgomerie to arrest 560 of his opponents. Little wonder that Ben-

tinck became so disillusioned with his Sicilians who reacted only, as he expressed it, to the strong man who was content to offer them "bonbons in the one hand and the stick in the other."²³

Yet blanket condemnations of a whole people seldom succeed in carrying conviction. Here they seem rather to be a reflection on Bentinck himself and on his attempt to impose a constitution on Sicily ("in part a creation of your own" as Castlereagh had written to him)²⁴ through a small section of the aristocracy, in which he had placed an unjustified faith. The people by whom he had been "let down" were not the mass of Sicilians nor the majority of the literate, for they had not even been consulted. It had been a mistake to allow the old parliament to act as a constituent assembly, because by its traditional composition it could represent only minority interests. As Enzo Sciacca has pointed out,²⁵ the radicals of the Demaniale and later those in the House of Commons were absent from the constitutional debates and the making of the constitution of 1812. He suggests (as Giovanni Aceto did earlier writing in 1827) that had the Sicilian radicals taken part in a proper constituent assembly, possibly much of the disequilibrium of the new order would have been avoided, and perhaps the constitutional experiment initiated by Bentinck might not have failed. This is certainly a large supposition. But when Bentinck got the prince to dissolve the parliament in October, the democrats in it whom he accused of endeavoring to usurp the functions of both executive and judiciary were not the extremists they have been painted by the constitutionalist historians. Not even the most extreme of them ever tried to force the hand of the prince over the selection of his ministers. Sciacca thinks it a pity that some were not chosen to hold ministerial posts (an idea Castelnuovo had earlier toyed with), for if they had been they could have done a good deal to calm the troubled waters.²⁶ Of course the radicals were anti-British, because they saw in British intervention the propping up of the dominant aristocracy and a captive monarchy, maintained through British subsidies. To them the continued British presence was the greatest obstacle existing to the kind of constitution they wished for Sicily.

Sicily as a Base for Offensive Operations, 1812–1814

Once the threat of French invasion seemed for the moment to have receded from Sicily, the ministry in London was naturally anxious to use its garrison for offensive operations. It was simply playing Napoleon's game to leave so large a force immobile while the war was being fought in Spain and Portugal. Liverpool expressed the hope to Bentinck, writing in June 1811, that it should be possible to reduce the garrison to the minimum figure of the 10,000 men stipulated in the treaty of alliance. Could not the Sicilians themselves contribute more to their own defense? For this purpose the British government were dispatching immediately to Sicily 14,000 stands of arms to help equip the Sicilian forces.¹

The deficiencies of the royal army have been referred to more than once. Bentinck told Circello in August 1811 that he had grave doubts about its effectiveness, consisting as it did of Neapolitans, anxious only to return to their homes, and foreigners and deserters from the French, many of whom were extremely disaffected. This army was not only ineffectual, a grave burden on the royal finances, but also a serious political danger. In the past year it had grown by as many as 5,000 men, augmented by a stream of French deserters and prisoners of war from Catalonia, until it now numbered 19,000. At the instigation of the queen, it might, Bentinck thought, ally itself with the French. The remedy he recommended and caused the hereditary prince to adopt was to cut its numbers by about 5,000. As he told the prince, a few thousand less would make no difference to recovering Naples. The whole of its non-Neapolitan element was accordingly discharged in May 1812, the Germans being recruited by the British army, the Italians formed into a corps of their own augmented by 2,000 prisoners of war that the British government shipped out from England. And later in the year the king agreed to reduce the number of his royal guards from 1,600 to 700 (half of whom were to be Sicilian).²

Yet, despite all these economies, Bentinck still had to lend the prince money in June 1812 and in the following January to keep the royal army in existence; otherwise it would have dissolved for lack of clothing, pay, and food. The appalling state of the royal army was brought home forcibly to

Bentinck when, prior to their embarkation for Spain, Sicilian regiments were marched into Palermo to be reviewed by him and Macfarlane. "Many were without shoes, none had great-coats, and the whole looked as if they had been half-starved."³ The cloth needed to provide them with uniforms Bentinck had to have sent out from England. It was this same financial exigency that had forced the British to assume the responsibility for the royal flotilla.

In return for thus propping up the monarchy and guaranteeing once again the sovereignty of Sicily to the royal family, Britain obtained an important asset in the shape of a sizeable Sicilian contingent, available for service outside Sicily, although within the bounds of the Mediterranean. By a treaty agreed to in September 1812, the signing of which the king was constrained to delegate to the hereditary prince, a division of 7,300 Sicilians was put at the service of the British commander. Its cost was deducted from the British subsidy and its recruitment, clothing, and equipment were to be Britain's responsibility.⁴ The troops that during the next eighteen months were to be sent to fight in Spain consisted in part of these Sicilians and the recently formed Italian Levy. This levy had had its origins in what had been called the "Calabrian Free Corps," formed by Stuart with the king's permission in the early months of 1809, when 1,500 Calabrians, fleeing from Masséna's extirpatory drive to eliminate the last traces of the *masse*, crossed over to Sicily. Rather than allow them to be recruited into the ranks of the royal army (seen now only as an instrument for forwarding the intrigues of the queen), Stuart took them into British pay, and appointed a British officer, Colonel Sir John Dalrymple, to inspect and train them. Its strength had soon risen to 500, divided into seven companies, and it was well reported on by Stuart. Initially bound only to serve within the territory of the kingdom of Naples, it was agreed in 1810 it could serve throughout the Mediterranean, and 300 of this corps were then dispatched as reinforcements to the island of Zante.⁵ But the aim of Bentinck was to form a force that would one day land on the mainland of Italy, the vanguard of a great national army to liberate that country from its foreign rulers.

The objects for which the Sicilian garrison could be used for offensive operations was the subject of discussion both in England and Spain. Since the outbreak of war in the latter country there had been Spanish and English voices urging an expedition from Sicily to help the Spanish in Catalonia, and this was a policy that found favor with Wellington, the British commander-in-chief in Spain, and also with Lord Liverpool, first when he was secretary for war and subsequently when he was prime minister. Italy was the other possible objective. Wellesley, the foreign secretary until he was replaced by Castlereagh in March 1812, had shown an interest in this theater, as did Bunbury, now under secretary for war and William Hamilton, foreign under secretary. But in holding these views, they were largely alone, and Bentinck, who was an enthusiast for the idea of Italian liberation, was very hesitant at

first about the timing of such an operation. Castlereagh, like most of his ministerial colleagues, shared the views enunciated in a memorandum edited by Huskisson in 1809, namely, not to excite any country to take up arms against the enemy, but to give it every possible help once it had been aroused to resistance. By April 1813 most ministers in London had lost faith in a rising in Italy.⁶

In a dispatch of June 1811 Liverpool had outlined the uses to which Bentinck might put his troops and mentioned certain desirable objectives, while leaving Bentinck the ultimate discretion over the choice he made of these. If the occasion presented itself, Corfu should be seized, though at limited cost; a force should be sent to protect Minorca, if it looked like being threatened from Toulon; troops could be sent to Catalonia, provided Sicily was not in danger. What Bentinck was instructed *not* to do was to waste his efforts recovering Naples. Its capture depended on French fortunes in theaters remote from southern Italy and, as Moore had written earlier, it was not likely to “run away.”⁷

Four months later Bentinck was told to coordinate his plans for forming an army in Italy with the Archduke Francis, a member of the house of Austria-Este with claims to the throne of Modena. But this was merely contingency planning, and Wellesley in writing to Bentinck emphasized that there was no intention of encouraging the Italians to revolt or of becoming involved in a project that might be risky or premature. The island of Sardinia, it was envisaged, might form the base for future operations, and the sum of £50,000 was made available to equip the Sardinians, while a further £50,000 was to be given to the Archduke Francis.⁸ This was the fruit of a project of Bentinck, suggested by him to Wellesley in June and put into his head by Metternich’s agent, Colonel Nugent, an Austrian officer (though in fact an Irishman by birth). Bentinck had thought the projected uprising was well worth backing at so little cost, and on his return from five weeks in Sicily had waxed even more enthusiastic. He had even proposed that he should send to Sardinia two or three British regiments from Sicily to serve for the immediate defense of that island and encourage that kingdom to raise and pay a new army for Italian operations. Failing the acceptance of this proposal, he suggested taking into British pay as many troops of the king of Sardinia as the sum of £10,000 would furnish. The king of Sardinia however demurred, fearing a loss of his independence and possibly also French reprisals.⁹

The lack of any reliable evidence of a national Italian resistance movement had forced Bentinck to agree reluctantly that the time was not ripe for intervention. The claims made by Prince Moliterno to be the leader of such a resistance struck him as being completely absurd. Looking however to plans for the future, Bentinck submitted that Corsica and Elba would form suitable bases for invading northern Italy, and only if these were ruled out as objectives would he think of sending his troops to Spain.¹⁰ The mention of

Corsica and Elba was harking back more than fifteen years to the days of the Anglo-Corsican kingdom, memories of which ill-fated episode were still fresh in the minds of ministers; and as Admiral Pellew pointed out, both islands would need a permanent garrison. So Bentinck was very firmly told that any attempt to take these two islands would be a total waste of resources, and as there was so little evidence of any popular movement in Italy, surplus troops could best be employed in support of the Spanish in Catalonia. They could always be recalled to Sicily and made available for Italy, if prospects there became more inviting.¹¹

A month before this dispatch was penned, Bentinck at the request of the navy, which had been pressing for it since the previous summer, had sent a small force of 600 men to occupy Lissa in the Adriatic, an island of greater strategic importance than any of the southern Ionian islands. It was to serve as a depot for trade, as a port for the Adriatic squadron, and as a means of maintaining links with both the Italian and Balkan shores.¹² But any attempt to seize Corfu, as mentioned by Liverpool in his earlier dispatch, was never seriously considered by Bentinck, its very powerful fortifications being defended by a garrison of 13,000. Britain did not possess in Sicily the resources for military operations, at least on any extended scale, in both eastern and western Mediterranean.

One way however in which some of Bentinck's forces, once part of the Sicilian garrison and now stationed in the Adriatic, could be thought to be more usefully employed than sitting in the Ionian islands was in helping a Montenegrin revolt. On information received from Lissa (information that later proved false) that there was a rising in Montenegro against the occupying French, Bentinck on 8 June 1812 authorized Admiral Fremantle, the naval commander in the Adriatic, to go to the help of these "freedom-fighters," taking whatever force he thought fit from the garrison on the Ionian islands. He told Fremantle that it was his policy (indeed it was that of the British cabinet) not to encourage any partial rising in Italy or the Adriatic, but to wait until "a general effort can be made by all nations engaged in the same cause." But nevertheless, since it now appeared that a revolt had in fact broken out and that war between France and Russia was certain—a war that might very well touch off a major rising in Italy—he thought it right to assist the Montenegrins.¹³

Fremantle collected at once 1,200 troops from the Zante garrison, embarked 400 on his own warships and took them to the island of Lissa, and left the remainder to follow on in troop transports as soon as they could. By the middle of July he was getting ready to escort his little force across to Montenegro, when he learnt that no rising had taken place. The French were, it seemed, in complete control. Naturally, when Bentinck learned of this, he cancelled his orders for the expedition and the troops were returned to their billets in Zante, and his political agents brought back to Palermo.¹⁴

Over the question of Catalonia, Bentinck forestalled Liverpool by sending his brother to Portugal to coordinate plans with Wellington, and it was agreed that Bentinck should find a force of 10,000 from Sicily to arrive in Spain by the end of June. Even so, the final decision to choose Spain and not Italy had been left to Bentinck's sole discretion, though the tone of Liverpool's dispatch made it clear that he hoped he would opt for Spain. In the event, Bentinck hesitated, thought he would go to Italy after all, and infuriated Wellington, who was counting on the force arriving from Sicily as part of his overall plan of campaign. Liverpool tried to blame Bentinck for disobeying "clear" instructions ("as positive as any which can be given to a commander so circumstanced").¹⁵ Bathurst however supported Bentinck. He told Wellington that Bentinck's instructions were in the last resort conditional, and that though he thought his decision wrong, there was no doubt that Bentinck had acted properly.¹⁶ By that time Bentinck had changed his plans, and his troops were sent to Spain after all, though not the 10,000 Wellington had been promised.¹⁷

What had led to all these changes during the month of June 1812 had been reports from Nugent and from allied agents in Italy that its people (especially in the Roman states) were on the point of rising up. This was clearly wishful thinking and depended, as Bentinck himself admitted, on whether the Russians entered the war. He justified his decision to switch from the Spanish to the Italian plan by arguing that the force he could spare for Spain was too small on its own to make any impact, while his 14–18,000 troops would outnumber any army the French could bring against him in Italy, now that so many of their men had been sent north for the Russian campaign. And any success achieved in Italy would benefit the cause of the allies in Spain. His force moreover would include 5,000 Neapolitan troops, thus removing a danger from Sicily while easing the path of royal acceptance of Sicily's recent constitution.¹⁸ But this was no sensible military reason for undertaking the operation. What appeared uppermost in his mind was the risk of losing an opportunity (perhaps one that might never recur) of leading a war of national liberation. Bentinck's arguments were not convincing, and Wellington, who had his own good reasons for wanting a force in eastern Spain, was certainly right when he wrote to Bathurst that the French would never allow an army of 15,000 Anglo-Neapolitans to remain for long on Italian soil.¹⁹

Within a matter of less than three weeks, Bentinck had changed his mind again. The news of a Franco-Austrian treaty and of a letter to the prince regent sent by the Habsburg emperor that urged him to send his army to Spain rather than into Italy (where Austrian troops at Napoleon's behest might well be called on to fight the British) had caused Bentinck to have second thoughts. Maitland with 7,000 men would go to eastern Spain after all, although Bentinck confessed he had little faith in their being able to achieve very much there.²⁰ As matters turned out, the late arrival of the force

from Sicily on 31 July and numbering 3,000 less than promised was not the setback it might have been for the fortunes of Wellington's campaign. Suchet, the general commanding the French in Valencia and Catalonia, had been so alarmed at the rumored arrival at any time in June or July of a great army from Sicily that he did exactly what Wellington wanted and sent no help to Soult or Joseph, with whose forces Wellington was engaged.²¹

The force from Sicily was never one that Wellington could depend on unreservedly, so its usefulness to him was limited. Bathurst made plain that the Sicilian situation must take priority over all others so far as Maitland's troops were concerned, and that Wellington must let them go if Sicily was ever threatened.²² This is precisely the situation that occurred in the spring of 1813 when Sicily's political situation forced Bentinck to act against the court. The 44th Regiment, destined for Spain, had to be diverted to Sicily from Malta, and General Murray, then the commander of the Sicilian forces in Spain, was required to send back 2,000 troops.²³ All this not unnaturally was unwelcome news to the ministers in London, who had recently been pressing Bentinck to send more of his men in the opposite direction. Spain in their view was the only theater in which Britain could afford to exert herself²⁴ (a point that had to be made clear to the Russians, who tried to involve Bentinck and his government in financing a force of 40,000 men to be sent from Moldavia to the Adriatic to cooperate in an Italian campaign).²⁵ If Sicily was not a liability it was scarcely the asset the cabinet hoped for. Nevertheless during 1813, as Bentinck was later at pains to point out in trying to justify constitutional change as the means by which Sicily had been made stable, there were dispatched from Sicily to Spain 13,500 troops, 2,500 of whom were Sicilian soldiers, the remainder British, Italian, and German.²⁶ Bentinck himself had left Sicily for Spain on 27 May 1813, only to be forced to return in October to restore the political situation. With the remainder of his army he now planned to invade Italy.

Already in January 1813 Bentinck was outlining to Bathurst his scheme to use the Italian Levy as the cadre for constructing an Italian army. He wrote in almost glowing terms of the military qualities of its two corps—something perhaps difficult to understand, considering the poor record for desertion one Italian regiment earned in Spain,²⁷ though doubtless it would have shown more spirit had it been fighting in Italy. Ponza, the island in the Bay of Naples his forces had captured in February, was to become, he hoped, the springboard and funnel for an Italian invasion. Twelve-hundred troops were earmarked for it, leaving behind in Sicily just sufficient men to garrison Palermo and the fortresses of Milazzo and Messina. The situation, he told Bathurst, was more favorable than it had been in 1812, and though he realized that Spain was important, Spain alone could not defeat Napoleon. To do this, the greater part of the peoples of Europe must be brought into the field and that meant involving Italy ("Italy is that instrument—Italy is

ripe for it"). There the British could act as principals, not as auxiliaries, as they were in Spain; and he painted himself a rosy picture of his army from Sicily taking Naples and then recruiting as it went along, heading for the north of Italy with its numbers swollen to 40,000.²⁸

Again he mentioned the political reasons for getting his army across to Italy. The Neapolitan troops in Sicily were a continuing source of anxiety, the Sicilian parliament was unwilling to pay them, and their officers were ready to desert. Had the passage to Naples been less difficult, many he was sure would long since have joined Murat. They were such a threat to security that while they remained in Sicily British troops would have to be left behind to ensure the safety of that island. It was for this reason that he had to tell Bathurst, writing in May 1813, he could not comply with the latter's request to send back two regiments to Spain.²⁹ To further influence the British cabinet in favor of his Italian strategy, Bentinck sent home his secretary, Lamb, to present his views in more detail to Castlereagh. In a long and persuasive memorandum Lamb presented at the end of May, designed for the eyes of Lord Castlereagh, it was argued that only by the opening up of a third front, this time in Italy, could Napoleon be decisively defeated. Napoleon had drained Italy of troops in order to support his campaigns elsewhere, and all the intelligence reports received showed that Italians would rise to a man before a French army could cross the Alps. To be forced to fight a campaign in Italy would put an enormous, perhaps an intolerable, strain on Napoleon's available resources. The British corps now at Alicante could never hope to achieve very much, because it was tied to its transports for supplies. "Every article, even the straw for the whole of the horses for the army during the entire winter has been sent from Sicily at a great expense and with a very considerable quantity of shipping." Italy, on the other hand, could supply all an army might require. And if revolts broke out in Italy as a result of allied successes and a British army was not then sent there to take advantage of the situation, Austria and Russia would benefit; yet it was important to the future of the continent and to England that Italian affairs should be taken out of the reach of these powers and placed firmly under English protection. Bentinck, so the memorandum went on, thought that the hereditary prince would not offer very much opposition to undertaking this enterprise, based as it was "upon liberal principles which appear to be necessary for its success."³⁰

It does not seem to have occurred to Bentinck that the introduction of political arguments (and ones that might not appeal to Castlereagh) into what was primarily a military proposition could do any thing other than to weaken his case.

When Bentinck wrote to Bathurst in February he sent Wellington a copy of his letter. Sensing the danger to his plans of any withdrawal of Bentinck's army, then deployed in eastern Spain, Wellington wrote forcefully to

Bathurst of the hopelessness of an undertaking involving sending the army to Italy. Unless the government were prepared to arm, clothe, and equip an Italian army on the scale it had done in Spain and Portugal, and in addition put into the field a force of 30–40,000, the whole scheme was foredoomed to failure. His anxiety was unnecessary since there was no chance of the ministry ever agreeing to such a scheme. As Bathurst wrote privately to Bentinck, “among our rulers . . . there is no belief of any character or energy among the Italians.”³¹ The bulk of the army of Sicily therefore continued to serve in Spain.

What Bentinck was now contemplating was a much more limited enterprise, to keep Murat’s army guessing, but also to rid Sicily of the disaffected Neapolitan troops. General Macfarlane, understandably, was not happy about the project of launching an immediate attack on Calabria, viewing the matter, as Bentinck did not, from a purely military standpoint. Landing troops in the kingdom of Naples, unless the operation succeeded, would do nothing to solve Sicilian problems and Macfarlane had little hope of success with only two British battalions available out of a total strength of 12,000. Bentinck was not deflected from his plan so easily. He argued that the loss of the Neapolitan troops would cause the Sicilians to make greater efforts in providing for their own defense and would also save them a lot of money. He had long deplored the attitude of the native Sicilians toward military service and their refusal to accept conscription, agreeing with what Belmonte had said to him about their desiring contradictions—no foreigners in their army, yet no Sicilian to be forced to serve in it; a large army to defend their island, yet no taxes to pay for it. It was quite sufficient to his mind that there was a chance of the plan succeeding.³² Fortunately for the reputation of both the British forces and Bentinck, the expedition did not take place, at least not for another eight months, and then it was sent to another part of Italy and in quite altered circumstances. The renewed fear of a French invasion (the combined threat from the Toulon fleet and 20,000 of Murat’s troops), followed by the political crisis that resulted in Bentinck’s return from Spain, meant that no expedition to Naples from Sicily would take place that year. As for the invasion threat, it proved to be nothing but a piece of bluff. When Bentinck cited it as a reason for his not returning two battalions to Spain, Wellington commented somewhat tartly that in his opinion the island of Sicily was “in no danger whatsoever,” an opinion that Admiral Pellew endorsed. Wellington and Pellew proved to be right, but it did not alter Bentinck’s decision.³³

What was attempted in December, however, on a very much less ambitious scale, was the dispatch of an Italian regiment to seize Leghorn by a *coup de main*. It was made on the initiative of Colonel Catinelli, the commander of the Third Italian Regiment, and Bentinck initially had misgivings about its chances of success, preferring it to go only to Ponza and there to make a more



Admiral Sir Edward Pellew, 1st Viscount Exmouth, by W. Owen. (*Courtesy of the National Maritime Museum, London.*)

detailed reconnaissance. However he soon convinced himself that he must not let slip any occasion for rallying the Italian people and giving them the opportunity "to assert their rights, liberty and independence." He hoped that another Catalonia would be created in Tuscany and that its population would hasten to join the standard of a national revolt. It all very quickly came to nothing. After capturing Viareggio and Lucca and beating off an attack from Pisa, the expedition failed in its aim of forcing the port of Leghorn to surrender. Bentinck blamed the lack of Congreve rockets, though bad weather also played a part in curtailing the operation.³⁴ In any case too much was expected of a force consisting of 1,000 men only. It is true that forty-seven years later Garibaldi with a more famous "Thousand" achieved spectacular success in Sicily, but the circumstances in Tuscany in 1813 were rather different. It seems that where his political principles and Italian liberation were concerned, Bentinck remained an incurable romantic.

Shortly after this minor fiasco, another expedition was planned—this time for a force of 5,000 men to take possession of Bastia, Bentinck having learnt from the navy of an Italian regiment there asking the British to take it away. Were this enterprise to succeed, Bastia, it was planned, was to act as a base for the invasion of the north of Italy and the rest of the army of Sicily was to be sent there as soon as possible.³⁵ The scheme was never carried out for, with the news of Murat's defection and his undertaking to join the allies, Bentinck was told to sign an armistice. This he did on 3 February 1813 on the basis of military cooperation to drive the French out of Italy.

The armistice was the culmination of negotiations going back nine months. Murat, once he had given up command of the Grand Army in Poland, had fallen from favor with Napoleon with whom his relations had long been strained. Murat was now anxious to secure his throne, to enlarge his kingdom at the Pope's expense, to aim perhaps for the throne of Italy and to displace Britain in the role of liberator. Once the British had captured Ponza, their contacts with Naples became quite easy, and these resulted in Bentinck calling there en route for Spain in June 1813 in an endeavor to persuade Murat to relinquish his claim to the throne of Naples. Murat had no intention of doing so, as became clear once Bentinck reached Ponza, though Bentinck hoped for a temporary accord by which both Murat and Ferdinand would recognize each others' claims and pledge themselves that they would not contest them until the question of compensation was settled. Though he did get the hereditary prince to accept "with considerable disinclination" the principle of compensation, Bentinck could not carry Murat with him. The latter continued to pin his hopes on the allies offering him the crown, and he was buoyed up by the recent news of Napoleon's victories at Lützen and Bautzen. Bentinck remained completely opposed to offering the crown to Murat, convinced (as was Castlereagh) that once he was sure of it, he would

cease to exert himself for the allies. Seeing that the cause of Napoleon was lost, it would not be very long (Bentinck thought) before Murat renewed the negotiations.³⁶

Six months later this proved to be the case. Approaches were made on Murat's behalf through General Manhès, commanding in Calabria, and the Neapolitan secretary of legation at the court of Vienna, the Chevalier Schinina; but Bentinck refused to make any concessions. Napoleon's decisive defeat at Leipzig made Murat's position uncomfortable, and he could not take his army northward without exposing his kingdom in Naples. Bentinck could therefore see no reason to prejudice the claims of Ferdinand, and he so informed the hereditary prince.³⁷ Meanwhile he was being pressed by Austria and by Lord Aberdeen, British envoy at Vienna, to sign an armistice with Murat in order to get the latter's help in driving the French from Italy. Bentinck tried his best to delay conforming with this desire for a ceasefire with Murat. He sent Colonel Graham, his aide-de-camp, to make contact with allied headquarters and to try to convince them that the army in Sicily remained a valuable bargaining counter in getting Murat to give up his throne.³⁸ His attempt failed, for the Austrians were to cut the ground from under his feet by the treaty of military alliance that they signed with Murat in January. Bentinck complained in vain to Castlereagh, condemning the treaty as "impolitic, inexpedient and unnecessary." It meant, he wrote, the abandonment of a great opportunity for Britain to champion the cause of Italian nationalism, and the showering of undeserved rewards on a man whose life had been one of crime. He tried to postpone the evil day by telling the Austrian representatives that he had no instructions on the matter,³⁹ but this would not answer for very long. On 18 January Bentinck received a dispatch sent to him from Lord Aberdeen and forwarded to him by Count Neipperg, the Austrian envoy at the court of Naples. This made clear that Aberdeen had agreed to Austria's approach to Murat and was anxious that Bentinck should also conclude a similar convention as soon as possible. While Castlereagh himself on 22 January sent clear instructions to Bentinck from Bâle that authorized him to conclude an armistice. Bentinck therefore left Palermo on 30 January 1814, and four days later he signed the armistice with the man he both despised and detested. Even so, he did not sign on behalf of the king in Sicily, who refused to acknowledge Murat's claims, and Bentinck himself also declined to acknowledge those claims in any way.⁴⁰

On 28 February 1814 Bentinck sailed with an army from Sicily made up of 6,000 British troops and the remainder Italian soldiers, leaving behind to guard the island only 4,500 men. A further contingent of 3,000 troops under the command of General Macfarlane (almost all of them Sicilian) joined him at Leghorn in early April.⁴¹ Bentinck disembarked at Leghorn on 7 March 1814 and a week later issued a proclamation in the name of the hereditary

prince calling on the people of Italy to rise and assert their rights and liberties. He was not alone in doing this, for Murat had already done so and Nugent and the Austrians were to do the same.⁴²

Bentinck had been ordered by Castlereagh to cooperate closely with the Neapolitans who were now in occupation of Rome, Emilia, and Tuscany, and he had been told that their "active assistance" was "indispensable" to allied success. But Bentinck could not tolerate Murat, nor was he willing to share with him the honor and glory of freeing Italy. He therefore demanded that Murat's army should forthwith evacuate Tuscany, which Bentinck made out he required as a base for his planned assault on Genoa. And when he found he could not get his way, he adopted a threatening attitude, talked of expelling the Neapolitans, marching on Naples, and then proclaiming Ferdinand IV as its rightful sovereign. Reprimanded by Castlereagh and told he was under Austrian orders and must in future work beside Murat, he accepted Austrian mediation and agreed to withdraw from Tuscany.⁴³

Genoa surrendered to Bentinck's army on 18 April 1814 and Bentinck, again disobeying orders, proclaimed the Republic of Genoa restored. But by this time Napoleon had already abdicated—his decision to do so having been caused not by allied successes in Italy but by other events to the north of the Alps. A few weeks later Bentinck again gave encouragement to the council of Milan in their endeavor to get accepted the concept of a free and united Italy. Again Castlereagh intervened, telling him that he must abstain from interference in Italian affairs, since the future of Italy (and of course Sicily) must be decided in another place.⁴⁴

It is somewhat ironical to reflect that when at last the occasion arrived for using the army of Sicily that Britain had paid and maintained so long for a major campaign in Italy, the effort proved to be largely wasted. Bentinck was far more interested in championing the cause of Italian nationalism than in working closely with his country's allies, one of whom was his *bête noire*, Murat. Reprimanded by Castlereagh for acting against the government's wishes ("It is not an insurrection we want in Italy . . . we want disciplined force under sovereigns we can trust"),⁴⁵ he was sent on leave and gradually replaced as British minister at Palermo, returning first briefly to the island, which he finally left on 16 July. The military command in the Mediterranean he kept until April of the following year.

Speculation on the Future of Sicily and Naples

As the end of the great war with Napoleon finally began to draw in sight, the whole question of Sicily's future and its possible annexation by Britain was raised again (somewhat unexpectedly) in the shape of what was called "Bentinck's Dream." This solution to Sicily's problems was put forward quite sincerely, in the interests of the island as much as of Britain, by the man who was now the dictator of Sicily. Its disclosure caused a temporary sensation both at the court and in Downing Street, and this reaction led Bentinck's enemies to hope it might lead to his immediate recall.

The whole question of Sicily's future and its relationship to Britain—the country that for the past eight years had protected it from the grasp of Napoleon—was certainly not a novel one when it was raised in December 1813. Howick and Grenville in 1806/7 had contemplated making Sicily a British protectorate in peacetime. Moore had certainly believed it necessary for the duration of the war to assume the government of Sicily, though there is no evidence that he ever thought it would be wise to retain it in peacetime.¹ And the persuasive propagandist Charles Pasley in his *Essay on Military Policy* had deplored the fact that Britain had failed to annex Sicily from the beginning. Leckie, another active propagandist, the writer of articles in the *Morning Chronicle* and a series of open letters and pamphlets published in 1806/7, as well as (almost certainly) the paper *Hints for the improvement of Sicily*, which was addressed to Lord Castlereagh, wrote in this last:

The master of Sicily regenerated holds Egypt under his foot; Tunis is his tributary; and the depot of the commerce of belligerents, the Barbary Powers, cease to have ships of war. He watches the fall of the Turkish empire, and stands with expanded wings to pounce upon Greece. He closes the Dardanèlles with Lemnos, and forbids the Russians to enter the archipelago.²

This visionary talk of British dominance in the Mediterranean, in war and peace, had been used earlier by apologists for making Corsica a British possession, and the same sort of arguments were to be used a year later by Richard Church and General Oswald to try to persuade British ministers to take over the Ionian islands. It says much for the hardheadedness and pragmatic approach of British statesmen, notably Pitt and Castlereagh, that

such arguments carried little weight. Pitt cared nothing for Corsica, save as a useful base for the fleet, and he later offered it to the Russians. Castlereagh saw in Sicily a military station and nothing more, serving a purely wartime purpose; and if he accepted an Ionian protectorate it was only to stop the allies from quarrelling and to help to safeguard the Turkish Empire. He was concerned as was William Pitt, and rightly so, with the winning of the war, and then with constructing a durable peace—a peace based on the hard, inescapable, and (to liberals) often most unpalatable facts of international politics, the need to retain reliable allies and the continued support of the other Great Powers.

Bentinck's dream of annexing Sicily with the willing compliance of the Sicilians sprang from a tour he had made of the island during November 1813, the purpose of which had been to find out what reforms in the administration of justice the mass of the people really wanted, but also to impress on local councillors the need to elect sensible men when the next parliament was summoned. During the tour he had experienced the typical warm welcome that southern peoples, many of whom were simple peasants, liked to extend to the man in power, from whom they hoped to obtain concessions—freedom from burdensome taxes and tolls, injustices righted, and corruption purged.³ It was just the sort of spontaneous reception that had warmed the heart of Sir Gilbert Elliot, when, as the newly appointed Viceroy, he had made his progress through Corsica. It put the idea into Bentinck's head (he had never before shown signs of favoring it) that the people of Sicily would surely welcome being annexed to the British Empire. The Constitution of 1812 provided for an independent Sicily. If the kingdom of Sicily was to be united once again with the kingdom of Naples, it would, he felt sure, mean the spilling of blood. Yet Sicily, it was painfully clear, could not exist independently, any more than Corsica could, and, as had been shown by recent events, it was quite unable to govern itself. Sicily in the hands of Naples would remain as it had been in the past a source of embarrassment to the latter. Under the benevolent rule of Britain it could become both content and prosperous, and pose no threat to its neighbor Naples. The king of course would be compensated, probably in the form of money, and Britain would provide 10,000 troops to guarantee his possession of Naples.⁴

All this was outlined in a letter from Bentinck, sent to the hereditary prince on 3 December 1813, though a few days later he wrote again to explain his proposal was not really serious, but a "dreamchild of his whimsical brain."⁵ It was not however seen as such by a worried and apprehensive prince, who had for years heard his mother declaiming against the sinister designs of the British. Having taken possession unilaterally of Malta and six Ionian islands, it now seemed that they wanted Sicily too. The suggestions that Bentinck had put forward seemed to his Neapolitan mind, accustomed to the indirect

approach, to be only a form of kite-flying, coming as they did from Britain's minister and the commander-in-chief of her army. He therefore replied in a guarded manner. Sicily, he wrote, was sacred property that the king his father was unable to renounce, and he could not think that Britain would wish to deprive her ally of the kind of refuge that Sicily had provided in times of adversity. In any case, the compensation Bentinck had mentioned seemed quite inadequate—thereby hinting that if more were offered, the scheme envisaged might yet be considered.⁶

Bentinck replied that the plan he had outlined was something that was entirely his own—the government in London knew nothing about it. But he did add that Sicily must always require some maritime protection, and Britain being likely for many years to remain the world's preponderant seapower, she was the obvious country to provide it.⁷

The prince consulted Medici, who in turn took counsel with Castalcicala, and the two in conjunction with the king (though apparently without the prince's knowledge) plotted to get rid of Bentinck by raising the matter with Downing Street. It seemed an excellent method by which, if Bentinck had acted without instructions, the minister could be disgraced and his immediate recall procured. But both Bathurst and Castlereagh, though not unnaturally surprised at learning of the relevant correspondence, were not prepared to be used in this manner. Castalcicala, despite being assured that the ministers had never heard of the scheme put forward in Bentinck's letter to the prince, a copy of which the ambassador had sent them, asked for Bentinck to be removed. It appeared, he wrote, that Bentinck's "dream" was no dream but rather an "avowed intention"—not to give Sicily liberty but to annex it to Great Britain. And furthermore, if Bentinck was not recalled, the case of his master the king of Sicily must be submitted to the king of Spain. If the king of Sicily was to be reduced to the status of a mere pensioner, he preferred that he should receive his pension from the court of his brother rather than from Britain. Castalcicala therefore asked for a passport to be issued to his messenger who was to take this request to Madrid.⁸

The reply he received was chilly in tone. The British government, Bathurst wrote, had already made clear it had been no party to an idea "thrown out" by Bentinck in what had been clearly a confidential letter. If Castalcicala had received authority to request the recall of Lord William Bentinck, he was asked to supply the date on which the hereditary prince had sent such instructions. Castalcicala's bluff was called and his earlier boast that he had given to Bentinck "a blow that will have broken his neck for good" was shown up for the bombast it was.⁹

All this took place in the first half of March. In early February (after signing the armistice) Bentinck had written a long letter to Castlereagh, setting out his case for the "dream." At the coming peace, so he told Castlereagh, Sicily would be faced with two alternatives. Either it would be

rejoined to Naples and see its liberty crushed by the crown ("it is not easy to conceive the terror universally felt at the unforgiving nature of their Majesties"), or its independence would be upheld—in which case it would fall the victim of a combination of self-seeking barons, the king, and a licentious people quite unable to govern themselves. If on the other hand Sicily were to be placed under British protection, the island could become "after Ireland, the brightest jewel in the British crown." With Murat secure on the throne of Naples, Sicily would need more than ever the protection afforded by British troops. A garrison of 5,000 men (the figure mentioned in 1806 when a draft treaty had been proposed by Howick) could be kept in Sicily in peacetime, while Sicily could as at present provide a contingent at the disposal of Britain. He thought that both the king and the prince would be glad to be rid of Sicily, provided they were offered attractive terms, and the queen had frequently said the same. He was only sorry he had made the suggestion without first obtaining cabinet approval, but the moment had seemed to him propitious and there had been no time to refer the matter to Castlereagh and the ministry.¹⁰ In addition to writing, he had also dispatched his secretary James Graham to Châtillon to interview Castlereagh personally, and this James Graham did on 21 February 1814. Graham, being both "young and romantic" (to use the words of Dr. Rosselli), convinced himself that Castlereagh sympathized with Bentinck's "dream," and reported him saying that if Murat proved treacherous and the Bourbons were to be restored to Naples, the British might keep Sicily; even if Murat stayed in Naples, the British would still need their army in Sicily after the signing of a peace. This however was not the impression Castlereagh retained of the interview, or perhaps did not wish to retain of it, once the matter was raised by Castelficala. He entirely disowned the views on the subject attributed to him by James Graham. As Rosselli charitably comments, his mind was then occupied by greater issues, and he may not have given to what Graham said the close attention Graham thought he had.¹¹

It was not until 3 April that Castlereagh finally wrote to Bentinck, sending him a mild reprimand. Dissociating the ministry entirely from the proposals of the "dream," Castlereagh emphasized the danger of making such unauthorized speculations, especially when one had to deal with "characters so suspicious and intriguing."¹² The last word upon the matter had really rested with Liverpool, the prime minister, who had written to Castlereagh in March:

Because Bentinck finds his constitution and the Sicilian court never likely to work together, he sees no way out save the annexing of Sicily. If there were no other objections, it would be very difficult to manage the island with such a constitution, but you know other Powers are more jealous of our obtaining power in the Mediterranean than in any other quarter. Circumstances have made it necessary for them to accept our retaining

Malta, but the idea of our possessing Sicily by an act which in its most favourable light must be considered *douce violence* could not fail greatly to revolt them.¹³

It was just such jealousy that the British had encountered twenty years previously in relation to Corsica and that was, in regard to the Ionian islands, to concede them a protectorate only, instead of the sovereignty that Bathurst had wanted.

Meanwhile events in Sicily were moving toward an unhappy conclusion so far as Bentinck and his friends were concerned. When he had toured the island in December, he had told local councillors that it was their duty to elect to parliament honest and enlightened representatives, and when the elections were held in June 1814, a lower House had been elected that was predominantly "constitutional"—a result obtained, almost certainly, by intimidation and corruption. But although the ministry now enjoyed the support of one House, it lost that of the other, because the nobles now turned to the king rather than submit to more losses of privilege. A political impasse had been reached, and although Bentinck counselled a coalition, the nobles made it clear that they would not accept one, the Belmontists being quite determined not to work together with the Castelnouvists.¹⁴ Finally the hereditary prince, at the request of Belmonte and others, asked the king to resume his powers as the only way of resolving the crisis. Belmonte's remarkable *volte face* in thus turning to his enemy the king was caused by his thinking he could only benefit personally from such a move. He thought the king would be duly flattered but did not believe he would ever accept or that the British would ever leave—in both of which respects he proved wrong. Bentinck refused to allow his name to be used by the prince in approaching the king and he refused to sign a written memorandum requesting the king to take over the reins, since he doubted the king's sincerity. But the king eventually expressed publicly his determination to forget the past, to reunite the political parties, and to complete the Sicilian constitution, on condition that he be released from the pledge he had given to Bentinck in March 1813 not to resume his powers again without the permission of the British minister. Bentinck released him from this bond, as there seemed to be little alternative, and the king therefore reassumed power on 5 July 1814.¹⁵

The king's sincerity was rightly in doubt. His attitude was currently being influenced by a wish to please the allied sovereigns, in whose hands it lay, at the Congress of Vienna, to return him to his kingdom in Naples. Both the Czar and the Austrian emperor, through the channel of the Duke of Orleans, had impressed on Ferdinand the need to adopt a more liberal attitude toward his subjects, if his claims were to be considered favorably. The restored Bourbon king of France, Louis XVIII, who had also found it necessary to accept a constitution in order to recover his throne, strongly advised him to do the same. There was however an additional reason for Ferdinand to show

a liberal face, and that was the fear of what Murat might do, the latter having proclaimed his intention of granting a constitution to Naples.¹⁶

British public opinion favored the return of Ferdinand to Naples, as Castlereagh told the Austrian ambassador, if only because he had lost his kingdom through having allied himself with Britain; it was a matter of national honor and dignity to see him restored. Metternich shared the view of Castlereagh about putting Ferdinand back on his throne. He told the Sicilian minister in Vienna in confidence that he did not intend that Murat should keep the throne of Naples and that Ferdinand must have his kingdom back, with Sicily, but not with a constitution. The Austrian emperor's invitation to Ferdinand to behave more liberally in future clearly therefore did not extend to his governing his kingdom with a constitution.¹⁷

Bentinck's reaction to Ferdinand's new posture may at first appear puzzling. Before leaving Sicily for good on 18 July 1814 (his position there as minister having been assumed by William A'Court), he penned a dispatch to Castlereagh in which he seemed to show satisfaction at the way events had turned out recently—surely the exact opposite of what he for so long had hoped and worked for, and of sentiments expressed in his journal as recently as a week before (“I never could think it desirable that the king should conduct the government” and “How could one suppose that a man who had governed ill for fifty years could all of a sudden change?”).¹⁸ But now, writing on 5 July, he congratulated Castlereagh on what he described as a happy ending to a long and embarrassing relationship between two allied governments, and he dwelt on the king's “sincere desire” to support the Sicilian constitution and to be reconciled to his political foes.¹⁹ Yet clearly Bentinck did not believe this; he was either seeking to deceive Castlereagh or was putting the best face he could on the matter. He had tried in vain to get the barons to work together for a compromise and now was disgusted at the outcome. He told his friends he would be glad to go away—“I owed nothing to the country which I despised.”²⁰ As A'Court (whom Bentinck thought “clever” and “honorable,” though he held very different political views) wrote privately to William Hamilton, “Having brought the comedy to the fifth act, he [Bentinck] seems to be by no means sorry to get away before the *dénouement* actually takes place.” He [A'Court] was grateful that the king had resumed power before he took over and that “it was Lord William and not I who did it, otherwise I should have been reproached.”²¹

Not surprisingly, the king now chose to employ as his ministers men who had been no friends to the party Bentinck had supported, indeed the very ones he had got rid of in the purge of March 1813. The British government had given assurances that there was to be no victimization, but not feeling at all confident about that promise being fulfilled, the duke of Orleans and Prince Belmonte both decided to seek safety in exile—in Paris, where they hoped, though vainly, to persuade Castlereagh to adopt a more liberal stance

toward Sicily.²² Yet the king was still unable to get a new parliament to vote him taxes (elected in August, its composition was much more democratic than the previous one), so for twelve months he had to subsist on taxes raised unconstitutionally and what remained of the British subsidy. Bentinck, when he had returned from Italy, had threatened to stop the subsidy altogether until the sums he had lent the prince were repaid, but realizing the embarrassment this would cause, decided the payments might continue if parliament made some reasonable arrangement.²³ It was here that Castlereagh intervened. According to the treaty of alliance, the subsidy was supposed to stop with the war, but withholding it for even six months would not liquidate the debts owed to Britain. Such was the state of the country's finances that the king might have to dismiss his army, and if this happened the bulk of the troops would almost certainly desert to Murat. A'Court was accordingly instructed that the British government would continue to pay one half of the subsidy agreed upon, until the Congress of Vienna ended or 1 March next, whichever was soonest.²⁴

This windfall of the half subsidy put new confidence into the ministry in their confrontation with parliament, but it disheartened the supporters of the constitution who regarded its payment as tacit approval of the king's unconstitutional measures. Even so, the Sicilian government was not preserved from bankruptcy. By the middle of March 1815 (the Congress of Vienna being still in session), the Sicilian army was about to dissolve. Without pay for the past six months, its officers were reduced to begging and even to robbery by night. The Sicilian government had tried for too long to keep up a style it could not afford, maintaining not only an expensive court, expensive embassies abroad, a host of civil servants, not to mention pensioners, but also an army far larger than it needed.²⁵ It had remained solvent only because Bentinck had succeeded in slimming the army and in lending the government money. Now that the subsidy was cut by half and further loans were no longer forthcoming (and were indeed due to be repaid), the harshness of fiscal reality must be faced.

All this time the British garrison still remained in Sicily. Orders had been issued in August for its immediate withdrawal, but the king had asked for it to stay. He was careful to avoid giving any hint that he needed it for internal security, but made out that it might be required for a possible future offensive against Murat. Castlereagh agreed to this request because the Congress was still deliberating and no decision had yet been reached about the future of Naples or Murat; but he used the occasion to point out to the king how unfounded all past suspicions had been of the British wanting to take over Sicily.²⁶

The escape of Napoleon from Elba in February and the beginning of the Hundred Days provided Sicily with a temporary respite in weathering its financial crisis. It also relieved Metternich of the problem posed by Murat's

claims to be recognized on the throne of Naples. On 15 March Murat once again took up arms against the Austrians, and a month later Bentinck declared that the armistice with Murat was at an end. On 17 May the king, having failed to get the parliament to grant him money to take his army across to Naples, finally dissolved it and named a commission for the task of reforming the constitution. Britain now stepped in to fill the gap, Castlereagh agreeing to renew the subsidy, provided it was used exclusively for offensive operations in Italy and that command of the expedition was entrusted to a British officer.²⁷

Accordingly, a mixed force (half of it Sicilian) set sail from Sicily in the middle of May under the command of General Macfarlane. When it arrived in the Bay of Naples it found its presence largely superfluous, as an Austrian army occupied the town and the British fleet lay anchored in the bay.²⁸ A fortnight later the king himself arrived back in his capital, having left behind the hereditary prince to act as lieutenant general of the island. The death of the queen the previous September had made his return considerably easier, since memories of her vindictiveness in 1799 were still very much alive. Needless to say, the king had not sought permission from parliament to leave Sicily, as by the terms of the constitution he was in strictness bound to do. The last chapter of Britain's occupation and protection of Sicily was about to begin.

The Dénouement

With the conclusion of the Hundred Days, the award by the Congress of Vienna of the kingdom of Naples to king Ferdinand, and the ignominious end of Murat, there was no longer any need for the presence of British troops in Sicily, and the last contingent left its shores on 9 October 1815. But there still remained the vexing question of how Britain was to extract herself with honor from Sicily's internal situation. She had for a period of almost three years committed herself to the support of the constitutional party in Sicily (it had come to be called "the British party") and had shouldered a moral obligation that could not lightly be cast off. Indeed any attempt to do so would stain Britain's name internationally, as well as cause an uproar at Westminster. Yet the king, who was now restored to Naples, was notoriously opposed to the constitution, had found it quite unworkable, and since June 1815 had tied his hands by a new treaty with Austria, a treaty that enabled him at last to be free of his long dependence on Britain. In return for a guarantee by Austria of military support for his dominions, he had pledged himself politically not to tolerate any institutions that were at variance with those permitted in Austria's Italian possessions. In other words, no responsible government. Now Austria was an ally of Britain; her support in upholding the Peace of Vienna was paramount in Castlereagh's eyes, and no scruples about the constitution could be allowed to stand in the way of establishing his principal goal, an enduring international settlement.

During the war, Castlereagh had been willing to go along with Bentinck's policy and permit him to work his political experiment. As he frankly admitted in May 1814, "I found the whole line of politics with respect of Sicily so completely chalked out that nothing was left for me to do but to let things take their course and to remain a spectator of the experiment which was to be made and to give it a fair trial."¹ But once the end of the war was in sight, he decided that Bentinck must be replaced in his civilian capacity by the more conservative William A'Court, then envoy extraordinary to the Barbary States and a man known to have little sympathy with popular assemblies in foreign countries. A'Court had presented for Castlereagh's eyes a memorandum of his views on the Sicilian situation based on his reading of the correspondence, and this had clearly impressed the foreign secretary. He was, A'Court wrote, quite convinced that, despite Bentinck's hopes for a new



William A'Court, Lord Heytesbury, by C. M. Eddis. (*Courtesy of the National Gallery of Ireland.*)

parliament due to be summoned in the spring, matters could not go on as they were. "It is possible that the presence of his Lordship with the sword in one hand and the purse in the other, may influence and control the factious spirit of the assembly"; but once the British army was removed from Sicily, either there would be a revolution carried out by the democrats, or the nobles and those who supported the king would combine with the mob and the royal troops to put the king back in his old position and do away with the constitution. Bentinck himself, A'Court pointed out, had in a private letter to Liverpool admitted that only British interference could save Sicily from internal convulsion. Yet the jealousy of Britain's allies would never permit her army to stay there, while intervention privately by the British minister in Palermo would merely compete with private intrigues by the ministers of other powers, and France for instance could scarcely desire a better field for activity than "that provided by an ignorant, profligate and . . . venal House of Parliament." A'Court had already made up his mind that a free constitution was not something in any way suited to the people of Sicily.²

A month later he was duly appointed to act as deputy for Bentinck as British minister at Palermo, during the latter's absence in Italy, in charge of military operations. And in his instructions from Castlereagh he was told that his most immediate task was to get the constitution modified. The original error, as Castlereagh saw it, had been making the king dependent on parliament in a country where the spirit of jealousy and faction was unfortunately all too prevalent. What A'Court had to attempt to do was to ensure that only men of property were represented in parliament, and that the crown was no longer dependent on parliament for its normal expenses.³

In a revealing interview Castlereagh gave to A'Court in May before the latter left for Sicily, Castlereagh told him, in reply to his question about what action he should take should the king resume power and the queen return, that the time for direct interference was past and that there could now be no warrant for behaving as Britain had done in the course of the war. As to Sicily's constitution, Castlereagh disclaimed all responsibility for it. Its success had been as great as might have been expected, but he thought nothing could save it now. "God knows," he went on, "it was never any principle of mine that we should meddle with the constitutions of other nations," but even had he wanted to, he would have been completely cured of any inclination to do so by what he had seen to happen in Sicily. He thought it would meet the same fate as the constitutions then forming in Europe, and the best thing that could happen was for Sicily's government to revert to its original form.⁴

A'Court's appointment had been canvassed for months by Castalcicala and the king, some time before the affair of the "dream." They had even tried to get A'Court accredited solely to the king, until informed by Castlereagh that the hereditary prince was the head of the state.⁵ But there was no question

but that A'Court would be far more acceptable to the king and prince than the constitutional dictator Bentinck.

A'Court did not take very long after arriving in Sicily to reaffirm his earlier view that the Constitution of 1812 had been a profound mistake for the island. The Sicilian people, he told Castlereagh, were quite unfitted to be entrusted with any sort of political power, and a strong monarchical government was the only one that was suitable for them. This view, in fact, is not all that different from the one Bentinck had been forced to adopt in his moments of greatest disillusion.⁶ "If I had known," the latter had written, "as much of the general character of the people as I did at present, I do not think I should ever have undertaken the business. I doubted whether these people were made for freedom."⁷ All would have been well, A'Court thought, if those who had drafted the constitution had contented themselves with limited aims—the improving of the administration, the abolition of feudal rights, establishing equality before the law, and the introduction of fairer taxation. But the great mistake, to his mind, had been to create deliberative assemblies endowed with legislative power; for this meant Britain had been forced to take sides and now found it difficult suddenly to withdraw. He felt it acutely embarrassing to have, in the name of British honor as well as of sheer humanity, to give support to individuals with whose principles he so disagreed. He painted a very gloomy picture of a bankrupt island whose old institutions had now become discredited, and whose new ones were not yet functioning. The best friends Britain possessed in Sicily were making haste to abandon the island, and they were not willing to return unless it became controlled by Britain. Thus it was that the British cabinet would have to make a crucial decision, either to support what Britain had created or to renounce British influence there altogether. It was extremely unfortunate, he thought, that Britain had ever interfered over the matter of a constitution: "We have done either too much or too little. . . . we satisfied ourselves with the shadow, when we should have seized the substance," and by this he meant forcing the king to abdicate (something that Bentinck had always wanted).⁸

For the king was now the principal difficulty, determined to ditch the constitution yet so untrustworthy and vindictive that he would, if permitted a free hand, soon establish a tyranny. Were it not for him, it would be quite easy for Britain to withdraw her support and "let the constitution sink into a form more adapted to the manners, vices and prejudices of this ignorant and profligate people." The only course that now seemed open was to get the king to agree to accept a constitution of some sort, before he eventually returned to Naples.⁹

But the whole affair of the constitution took on a completely new complexion with the terms of the treaty the king signed in June 1815 with Austria. Metternich proposed to A'Court that Britain should join with Austria to disown the Sicilian constitution, as they had already jointly disowned the

Republic of Genoa, revived by Bentinck. This however was considered impracticable, since the two cases were quite unlike. Castlereagh made clear to A'Court, writing in September 1816, that any concert between Austria and Britain would embarrass rather than help the king, might be wrongly construed in Europe, and would moreover make the two countries responsible for whatever was done. While it was right to advise the king, A'Court must not commit the British government. The best course would be to let the king carry out his projected scheme (or subterfuge) for modifying the constitution, while letting him know, privately, that Britain would tolerate neither the extinction of any of Sicily's ancient rights nor the persecution of any of those who had lent their support to British authority.¹⁰ This course was accordingly adopted, and A'Court wrote triumphantly on 5 November that the new, modified constitution on which his private advice had been taken (without committing his government) would ensure that nothing was done in Sicily that could be considered reactionary. He therefore congratulated Castlereagh on being now totally released "from all responsibility arising from the past."¹¹ The king was delighted and had awarded A'Court the highest decoration he had the power to confer (the Grand Cross of the Order of St Ferdinand), even though British protocol forbade A'Court from accepting it.¹² But from the Sicilian constitutionalists the latter earned the nickname of "William the Bad," in contradistinction to Lord William Bentinck, who of course was referred to as "William the Good."¹³

On 8 December 1816 the king declared the kingdom of Naples and the kingdom of Sicily to be one. The new constitution he promulgated effectively robbed the Sicilian parliament of any power to legislate or prevent the king from raising revenue, save for extraordinary purposes. Though the privileges granted by the crown were confirmed, freedom of the press was now abolished and a measure of conscription introduced.¹⁴ There was nothing left of the constitution over whose birth Bentinck had presided.

The policy in regard to Sicily that he had pursued during these two years Castlereagh defended vigorously in the House of Commons in 1821, when rejecting a motion put forward by Bentinck for a fresh intervention in Sicilian affairs. Castlereagh said that although the government felt strong affection and esteem for Sicily, it was not on that account or to secure its people's happiness that British troops had been stationed there—in fact it had been a military occupation. Britain's guarantee had not been to form a constitution, but to protect the dominions of its king. True, it had been necessary to intervene to impress on the mind of the Sicilian government the need for a modern constitution. Moreover if this had not been done, the government of the island could not have continued and the place would have been quite unfitted for its use as a British military base. It was never felt that Lord William Bentinck was entering into any arrangements with respect to the Sicilian constitution.¹⁵

Yet Bentinck clearly had believed that he was entering into an arrangement. How far then was he justified in suggesting that Britain's name and honor had been smirched by Castlereagh's *realpolitik*? As Professor Mack Smith has pointed out, the king, though he was later blamed for destroying a liberal experiment, had been supported in so doing by a large proportion of the people of Sicily and had only dissolved the Sicilian parliament for the last time in 1815, after the failure of four parliaments to vote the necessary taxes.¹⁶ Charles Macfarlane, who was in Sicily only six months after the British troops left, heard many complaints of pecuniary loss now that the freespending forces had gone, but heard no regrets for a constitution that people described as a kind of "madness."¹⁷ Earlier the king had told Bentinck, "The Sicilians are not Englishmen, the habits of this country are not the habits of yours. . . . You fancy that Sicilians can govern themselves like Englishmen. They cannot do it. Give them this constitution and you yourself will soon have cause to repent it."¹⁸ Ferdinand's words had proved prophetic.

Since, then, the maintenance of the constitution (the creation of an enlightened few) rested quiet clearly on British bayonets, to describe the withdrawal of such questionable support as being in some way "dishonorable" seems to stretch the meaning of the word too far. Nor could any such withdrawal be described as unreasonable. As Charles Macfarlane emphasized, writing a generation after the event, "Fond as they are of liberty, and prone to believe . . . that constitutions like our own are a panacea and fit for all countries and all peoples, the English would not have relished paying, for an indefinite number of years, an army of 10,000 men for the sole purpose of protecting a political experiment in Sicily."¹⁹ And an experiment, he could have added had he not made the point already, to which most Sicilians had proved indifferent. In any case, to keep troops on the island for that avowed purpose was bound to incur not only the anger of Austria but the risk of an open breach with that country.²⁰ No considerations of "honor" could have warranted taking such a risk.

Certainly it would have been dishonorable to permit the king to victimize those who had loyally supported the British, but Ferdinand here remained true to his pledge where higher officers were concerned. Settimo, who had been the minister for war, was even offered membership of the chancellery responsible for Sicilian affairs, though perhaps understandably he declined it. Belmonte had died earlier in Paris. Castelnuevo and other nobles associated with the 1812 Constitution, chose to retire into private life, a sort of *immigration intérieure*, in which they were allowed to remain undisturbed. Nor was it any longer true that native Sicilians were kept out of office in favor of Neapolitans. Indeed the latter complained of being swamped by a host of job-hungry Sicilians who had followed the king when he returned from Palermo.²¹ Giovanni Aceto in his history refers to the number of individuals

(none of whom he identifies by name), magistrates, and other officials who through their political affiliations were deprived of their posts after 1815, denied promotion, or persecuted.²² It could unfortunately well have been so, more especially in a country like Sicily where mutual jealousies could be so intense, but it would have been impracticable, indeed impossible, for the British government to have intervened in any such cases unless its official attention had been drawn to some specific cause of complaint.

Castlereagh had acquiesced in the constitution so long as it served its immediate purpose—keeping the island of Sicily quiet, so as to let the allied troops there be made available for service elsewhere. But it could have no relevance in peacetime to the foreign policy of Lord Liverpool's government. Yet even in wartime it had not been the entire success various ministries had hoped for. As has been shown in earlier chapters, Bentinck was twice compelled to recall a proportion of his army from Spain in order to cope with internal unrest, was forced to delay his own departure there, and once in Spain had had to return because of Sicily's turbulence.

If the question finally has to be asked whether, viewing the war as a whole, the military and financial investment Britain made in Sicily had been worthwhile, the answer must be a qualified yes; though undoubtedly the highest hopes entertained for it were never fulfilled. As a forward base from which to launch effective attacks on the enemy, whether in Egypt, the Dardanelles, Italy, the Adriatic, or Spain, there were few successes of which it could boast, the dramatic anticlimax of Maida being the one that deserves to be best remembered. At times there had been maintained in the island upward of 15,000 troops, yet never enough to intervene effectively or for very long in a continental enterprise that in any case if it were to succeed needed the help of Austria or Russia. In Spain there were some results to show, but internal troubles in Sicily and Bentinck's preoccupation with Italy had prevented their being more convincing, just as the danger from the court and its followers had earlier prevented more than a portion of the troops available from being used in Italy or being dispatched to the Dardanelles. At all times there had remained present the threat of invasion by the French, even if after 1810 that threat was never a very real one. And if the British cabinet did not take that threat very seriously after Murat's halfhearted, aborted thrust, the court and the generals and admirals did, and the king insisted that the minimum force of 10,000 effective British troops, guaranteed by treaty, be maintained on the island as long as the war with Napoleon lasted.

Yet looked at purely defensively, the occupation had been well worth the trouble. Without it, Malta would have been at risk—indeed Sir Alexander Ball once wrote to Castlereagh of “the disaster which must necessarily accrue to the inhabitants of Malta, should the French possess themselves of Sicily.”²³ And with Malta at risk, so also would be British command of the Mediterranean as well as Britain's commercial interests in the Levant and

North Africa. The British navy would not only have lost its harbors at Augusta and Syracuse, but also the fresh food and water that the island was able to provide. Without Sicily, its arduous role in the Mediterranean would have been hard to fill. Sicily was never a firm base, but all the same it was one Britain needed to sustain her effort in the war with Napoleon.

Of the legacy of British rule in Sicily, Louis Simond, a Frenchman, wrote in 1828:

The English, it must be acknowledged, have left here no honourable monument of a power paramount to sovereignty . . . the roads, the prisons, the hospitals, the corrupt and barbarous administration of justice, remained in just as wretched a state as before they interfered. It is true they saved the island from French dominion; from the violence and plunder which attended it at Naples and in Calabria; they kept strict discipline; they paid honestly and liberally for all they had; but they did not mix cordially with the people; they continued meddling, teaching, ruling, with a high hand and a supercilious pride, till all classes were tired out; and yet all classes regret them, simply because they saved them from Naples for a while.²⁴

Apart from the fact that the British did do something to improve the appalling roads in Sicily, certainly in the northeast tip of the island, this rather superficial judgment really misses the important point. As has been stressed so often in this book, the ministry in London was extremely loath to interfere in Sicily's internal affairs, and when eventually it was constrained to do so, its representative, Lord Wiliam Bentinck, spent his time trying to get the Sicilians to effect the needed reforms themselves. His lack of success in persuading them to work a system of parliamentary government induced them in the end to turn back to their king, who personified Neapolitan domination.

Appendix A

The Economic Implications of the British Occupation of Sicily

The presence of British troops in Sicily together with the payment of a British subsidy brought to the island an influx of capital and a vast increase of its purchasing power. The demand of the armed forces for meat meant that the price of cattle almost doubled, as did that of wool and corn. The wages of agricultural laborers did not keep pace with this inflation, and it was therefore the merchants and farmers and the landowners with their increased rents who benefited from this situation. The attempt by the Sicilian government to introduce a free trade in corn led in the summer of 1813 to such a huge increase in its price that serious riots broke out in Palermo, and not long after Lord William Bentinck was forced to reimpose price controls. When however the war ended and British troops were finally withdrawn, there was inevitably a collapse of prices and an end to the period of prosperity for those classes who had benefited by the British presence.¹

The interdiction of trade to Europe caused a wartime flowering of local industry—silk manufacture in Palermo, the manufacture of wool, hemp, and linen in new factories at Girgenti, and of linen at Caltanissetta. Hats, furniture, even harpsichords to rival the best products of France and Spain (if one witness is to be believed) were all being produced in Sicily during the wartime period, while new sulphur and asphalt mines were being successfully exploited.²

The contraband trade with the continent was very largely in the hands of the British, for whom Sicily became a vast entrepôt for British manufactures and for colonial goods. Britain's minister at Palermo was authorized by the British government to issue licenses for this trade to any vessels other than French, though in regard to the trade to Calabria there were difficulties with British cruisers who tended to stop any vessels crossing, purely on grounds of security; and on one occasion in 1808 the merchants of Leeds complained to the ministry that legitimate trade was being hampered through orders issued by the Admiralty.³

When during the outbreak of plague in Malta in the summer and autumn of 1813 the Sicilians imposed a rigorous quarantine, British merchants in Sicily found that their trade was badly hit. In consequence, Bentinck felt compelled to authorize a full-scale trade between Sicily and the Neapolitan

ports. Permission was given at the end of December for the export to Naples of Sicilian produce as well as British and colonial produce and of course British manufactures, while imports were no longer confined to iron, flour, and rice as hitherto, but could now include all the produce of Naples, only excluding French manufactures.⁴

By the treaty of alliance of 1808 the ports of Sicily were thrown open to the merchant ships of British subjects, and merchants were not required to pay duties on food or military stores imported for the use of British troops. Nevertheless some of these duties did continue to be levied, on the pretext that the royal right to collect them had been farmed out to private bodies. These commercial privileges granted the British were deeply resented by Sicilians, and once the war ended in 1814, although British troops still remained on the island until October 1815, there were complaints from British merchants that their privileges were being ignored and that delays continued to be imposed on the import of British goods. As A'Court wrote indignantly to one official: "It would seem that nothing could be more acceptable at the present moment than anything which may wear the appearance of hostility to the British interests."⁵

There were many British merchants in Sicily, most of them living in Palermo and Messina, though the firms of Woodhouse and Ingham were most closely linked with the port of Marsala where they virtually controlled the trade in wine and had kept Nelson's fleet supplied with it.⁶ How many English merchants there were, how much capital they had, in what sectors of trade they operated, and what was the extent of their profits are questions about which it is not yet possible to be precise. The petition of the merchants resident in Sicily made to the Council of Trade and Plantations on 27 May 1811 was signed by twenty-eight merchant firms or individuals trading on their own.⁷ These British merchants had protested against the tax on monetary transactions imposed by the king in 1811, though this was removed after Bentinck's arrival. They also protested that there existed no Anglo-Sicilian commercial treaty. It will be recalled that in 1806 the Ministry of All the Talents initially suggested that a clause be added to the subsidy treaty then being negotiated by which British merchants in Sicily should be given the position of most-favored nationals, but that fierce Sicilian opposition had caused the suggestion to be withdrawn. Two years later, Mellish impressed on Canning the need for some such commercial agreement, since British merchants in Sicily were in the position of those least favored, their goods being required to pay 36 percent more than the goods of other nations.⁸ Canning apparently took no action, because three years later Wellesley at the Foreign Office raised the matter again with the Board of Trade. Bathurst, then in charge of that department, replied that there were difficulties. Britain could not ask for commercial advantages simply because she was paying a subsidy (one she was bound by treaty to do). Sicily would seek reciprocity

and that meant reducing the duty on wine—not just Sicilian wine, but the wines of all wine-producing countries (other, of course, than the enemy France)—and this the Treasury could not afford.⁹ Only a month later, however, the Board of Trade did produce a *projet* for an Anglo-Sicilian commercial treaty that was designed to be included in the wider treaty of 1812.¹⁰ This however proved unnecessary since by the end of 1811 the main merchants' grievances had been removed. New instructions had been issued by the court in regard to the seizure of British ships and to improving the conduct of the prize court; steps had been taken to adjust the assessment of the value of British goods entering the country to keep pace with the lowering of prices, and an assurance had been given to London that in future British goods might be freely transhipped without the payment of any duty.¹¹ There is no doubt that British manufactures, despite the court's grudging attitude, enjoyed a wartime boom in Sicily, and one witness who was resident in Palermo through 1811 and 1812 writes of English cloth being universally worn, and every kind of household necessity being not only "on the English model" but "generally procured in England."¹² And certainly the British community could not complain of underrepresentation where consular services were concerned, since by 1812 there were functioning in Sicily no less than thirty vice-consuls and consuls.¹³ Not however until 1816 was a trade treaty finally signed between Britain and the Two Sicilies. This gave the subjects of both countries the status of most-favored nationals and remitted 10 percent of the duty paid on British imported goods in return for Britain abandoning the right of exemption from customs search.¹⁴

Sicilian merchants for their part benefited from British naval protection against French privateers and Barbary pirates. When the British navy arrived off Sicily at the end of the eighteenth century, a constant state of war obtained between the island and the Barbary states, and Sicilian trade was either confined to vessels plying a coastal traffic or to those of some other country whose flag the Barbary states respected. It was the British who, through the good offices of Admiral Fremantle in 1812 (acting on behalf of Lord William Beninck), concluded a treaty with the bey of Tunis. Four hundred-odd Sicilian subjects being held in slavery were cheaply ransomed, a truce was made between Sicily and Tunis to last as long as Britain was Sicily's ally and permission was given for boats from Sicily to fish coral along the North African coast.¹⁵ The economic benefits accruing from nearly ten years of close relations between Britain and Sicily were not the perquisite of one side only. And one major contribution to the Sicilian economy that the British occupation of Sicily made was to the island's merchant marine. Before 1806 Sicilian exports were carried to Europe in the foreign craft of France, Genoa, and Ragusa. The Sicilian merchant marine consisted largely of a few small vessels, principally engaged in a coastal trade, creeping from port to port in the kingdom, terrified of Barbary pirates but also ignorant of naviga-

tion. The masters of Sicilian craft seldom ventured out to sea or went beyond the Straits of Gibraltar. But during the British occupation, the ship repairs to the British squadron were carried out by Sicilian shipwrights and as a result there was created a considerable body of these skilled workmen. After the occupation ended, they began to build much larger vessels for the trade between Sicily and Naples than had been in use hitherto, and so laid the foundation for what became a very flourishing merchant fleet.¹⁶

Appendix B

Attempts Made from Sicily to Rescue Pope Pius VII

After February 1808, when French troops were quartered in Rome because the Pope had refused to join an offensive alliance against Great Britain, Pius VII was a virtual prisoner there—forced to dismiss his secretaries and to dissolve his personal guard. It was in these circumstances that Cardinal Gabrielli, pro-papal secretary of state until he was expelled by the French, concocted a plot with a Scottish prelate to get the British to rescue the pope and convey him safely to Sicily.¹ The Scottish prelate was Cardinal Erskine, the same cardinal who thirteen years earlier had endeavored to get the British government to recognize the papal court and to resume diplomatic relations with it in return for the then pope, Pius VI, accepting the Anglo-Corsican kingdom and being willing to sign a concordat with it. This time Erskine was more successful in obtaining a hearing at Westminster, and the government there sent instructions to Drummond, their minister at the court at Palermo, and to Admiral Collingwood, then commanding the British fleet in the Mediterranean, to set on foot a rescue operation.²

In mid-July 1808 Collingwood was ordered by the Admiralty to station a frigate off the Roman coast in order to receive on board the pope and any cardinals who might wish to accompany him, after first getting in touch with Drummond to coordinate plans for the operation.³ Meanwhile Drummond had heard from Canning that Collingwood had been so instructed. But Drummond had already discovered that the queen, entirely without his knowledge or indeed that of the king and Circello, had been involved in a plot of her own to rescue the pope and bring him to Sicily—perhaps at the prompting of that strange character the Irish-born painter Rogert Fagan. The latter had lived for a long time in Rome, where he had acted as the British agent. He knew the pope personally and had only recently been expelled from Rome on the express order of Napoleon. On arrival in Palermo he quickly succeeded in becoming a confidant of the queen. In June 1809 he was to become the British consul-general in Sicily. The queen had dispatched a Sicilian frigate with Fagan on board to the Roman coast with an invitation to the pope to come and seek refuge in Palermo. Needless to say, the operation, like everything else the queen undertook, had not been thought out sufficiently well. Fagan was told the pope would not leave unless he

received an invitation, written out in the king's own hand that, it was said, the pope would recognize. After three weeks Fagan returned, only to find himself out of favor both with the queen for having failed and with Drummond, who was extremely incensed that Fagan had not consulted him. And what was particularly galling was that surprise had now been lost. All Italy, in Drummond's view, must now know of the attempt, and this had made it doubly difficult to make another with hope of success.⁴

Collingwood had ordered the frigate *Alceste* under the command of Captain Maxwell to undertake the rescue task, but he wanted Drummond to find for him at least two reliable men to act as agents in contacting the pope. Drummond decided that no Sicilian would ever agree to accept such a role unless he knew that the king was behind him, and so he decided he must confide in the king and in Circello, whom he swore to secrecy, for on no account was the queen to be told. It was they who eventually procured four Catholic priests to sail on the frigate. Drummond writes of only three—a Jesuit and two monks or friars—while Maxwell, who must here be relied on, mentions four, though he called them all Jesuits (a term that he, as a good Protestant, was ready no doubt to apply indiscriminately). In addition there travelled on board the *Alceste* a Roman guide and a young nobleman, Count Canizzaro, a friend of Drummond and thought by him a suitable person to keep His Holiness company.⁵

The *Alceste* set sail on 26 August and after first calling at the island of Ponza to pick up a pilot who knew the area made for the coast at Fiumicino where one of the friars and the guide disembarked. The friar managed to reach Rome safely, had an interview with Cardinal Pacca, the papal secretary of state, and found the latter surprised and pleased to learn that an English ship had arrived. Although he looked like a Sicilian brigand, the friar's credentials were believed, even though he failed to carry on him the important letter written (as requested) in the king's own hand, unsigned and unaddressed, lamenting "the gradual decay of his friend's health" and inviting him "to try a change of air at his villa which was accounted very healthy."⁶

No direct answer was apparently forthcoming, but the friar was told to go back to the coast and wait there for the next three nights for a messenger with the pope's reply.

Maxwell then arranged to have waiting on shore every night his first lieutenant, to receive the expected messenger. No one arrived on the first two nights and the third night it blew a gale, so that no boat could approach the shore. Whether the messenger did arrive on the crucial third night is not known, but once the weather again permitted, a party was sent ashore each night to await the envoy who never came. Finally Captain Maxwell decided he must send someone again to Rome to find out what was happening. But here he found himself frustrated, since all the priests were too frightened to go and asked only to return to Palermo. Maxwell sent them back on a small

ship (the *Acorn*) together with the young Count Canizzaro—the only one to show any courage—with a message to Drummond to inform him of events.

Within a week Canizzaro was back, carrying with him on board the *Acorn* a Roman colonel by the name of Vanni who was nominated to go to Rome. Vanni set off but never returned, and Drummond learnt later from newspapers that he had been arrested and shot as a spy. Maxwell of course knew nothing of this and waited a further month off the Tiber, hoping to see the colonel return. The weather continued to worsen steadily and on only thirteen nights was it possible to put a boatload of men ashore. One night one of the launches was swamped and four of the sailors taken prisoner. Maxwell arranged an exchange of prisoners with the officer commanding Fiumicino fort, but when the time came to carry out this exchange the Neapolitan broke his word, and the first lieutenant of the *Alceste* and the party of men accompanying him ashore under flag of truce were marched off to the north.

How long Maxwell continued to remain at his fruitless task we do not know. Collingwood, on receiving his dispatch, must have decided to order him back. Maxwell had written on 15 October of rapid currents and frequent gales, rendering “this service rather arduous.” One cannot envisage Collingwood being prepared to run the risk of losing a frigate by continuing what was clearly a failed operation.⁷

The version of the story as recounted in his memoirs by Cardinal Pacca, the pope’s pro-secretary of state, tells us a slightly different tale. According to him, the Franciscan friar whose disguise made him look like a vagabond or bandit did not carry any letter to authenticate either him or his mission. He had, he admitted, been too frightened to do so—thinking (correctly) that were he arrested and the king’s letter found on his person, he would certainly be shot as a spy—the fate that awaited Colonel Vanni (who did carry a letter) a few weeks later. The friar referred Pacca to Cardinal Erskine, whom the friar had apparently seen already. Erskine’s reaction, when tackled by Pacca about the plan as revealed by the friar was to say the least equivocal. He disclaimed all personal responsibility, said he had been told of it by Gabrielli, but, having then heard no more of it, had assumed the idea to have been abandoned. As Pacca notes, it would appear that Erskine had now become alarmed and was trying to dissociate himself entirely from a plot initiated by himself.

When, the following day, Pacca saw the pope, the latter agreed that he knew of the plot, formulated by Gabrielli, but that he had never had the least intention of leaving Rome of his own free will. His reasons being, as Pacca adds, not merely the fear of provoking schism but his refusal to give Napoleon a pretext for annexing the Roman states to France by allowing himself to become a guest in a country controlled by France’s enemies. Nor would he agree to contemplate flight merely in order to secure his person.

In view of all this, why then did Pacca send the friar off with the idea that further contact would be made at the coast during the course of the next three nights, if he were already so sure that the pope had effectively vetoed the scheme from the start?⁸

It must be very frankly stated that the clergy do not emerge from these incidents with any very great measure of credit. Why, it may be asked, did Gabrielli allow the scheme to go ahead, if he knew that the pope was completely opposed to it? Even to the extent of encouraging Fagan (it was presumably he who saw Fagan) to try again, but this time bearing a letter? And why did he not inform his successor as pro-secretary of state of what he had done? And if he were hurried out of the kingdom before he had had time to inform Pacca, why had Erskine said nothing to Pacca? And again, if Pacca was so convinced that the pope had made up his mind for good (and Pius was not a man to be shaken, once he had formed his own opinion), why did he allow the Franciscan friar to think there was still a chance of some change in the papal attitude toward escape?

The result of what one can only call muddle, or perhaps even moral cowardice, in refusing to tell unpleasant truths, interwoven with clerical intrigue, was that the lives of all those on board the British frigate were needlessly risked, the life of the brave Colonel Vanni was forfeit, and the British were made for no good reason to hazard one of their valuable ships.

The second attempt to rescue the pope was made in the summer of 1810 when a ship was again dispatched from Sicily, though this time it was a Spanish operation, with the British ship acting as auxiliary only. There had been no orders sent out from England to instruct Amherst how he was to act, and he and Admiral Martin were content to rely on Canning's dispatch of June 1808 as an indication of British policy. It is true that there was now a new administration, but Perceval's ministry expressed no views, though it would doubtless have been delighted if the operation had been successful.

This time the initiative had come from the pope's almoner, acting (or so he wrote) on the pope's instructions, and taking the form of letters to Sicily addressed to a Sicilian prelate and to the Spanish minister in Palermo. These letters, which arrived in Holy Week and whose contents at first appeared innocuous, were found to contain a hidden message. This message was written in invisible ink and asked the letter's recipients to help rescue the pope and with the assistance of the British navy to arrange for his passage to and asylum in Malta. Given the known views of the pope, that he certainly had not become (as some think) Napoleon's bitter enemy, but rather that he clung to the hope that the latter would become a latter-day Charlemagne and emerge in the end as the Church's defender, it seems unlikely to say the least that he would have instructed his almoner to make the appeal set out in these letters.⁹ In view of the independent behavior of Cardinals Erskine and

Gabrielli during the summer of 1808 in formulating a plot to which they knew the pope was completely opposed, one may perhaps be allowed to doubt the truth of the papal almoner's statement that his letters were written on the pope's instructions.

Padre Gil, the Spanish minister, told Amherst he would like His Holiness to be taken if possible to Alicante. The latter was a secure resort and the presence of the pope in Spain would have an incalculable effect on the national struggle the Spanish were waging. The Spanish had a corvette they could send, but they would welcome the presence of a British warship to accompany it to Genoese waters, since it had been learned that the coast near Savona was strictly guarded by French privateers. Amherst then approached Admiral Martin, who expressed his willingness to detach a brig (the *Eclair*) to perform the task.

The two warships set sail in June, the Spanish warship having aboard someone who knew both the pope and Savona, and when they reached the Maddalena Islands, this person was sent on ahead of the rest to meet the pope and discover from him when the corvette had best appear. He was at the same time to offer the pope a choice of places to which he could go—first Alicante, second Minorca, and only Palermo as a last resort.¹⁰

Neither Amherst nor Admiral Cotton (now in command in the Mediterranean) ever had very much faith in the scheme, given the close watch maintained on the coast. And Cotton later wrote of its failure as one that had been "foreseen and expected."¹¹ The person sent from the Maddalena Islands did not succeed in reaching the pope until it was too late to take any action, for the long delay had led the Spanish with British agreement to abandon the plan. They had thought that although they might succeed in making a landing near Savona, they would never be able to get away; and an unsuccessful attempt of this sort could only endanger the life of the pope.

Amherst was convinced that lack of security had contributed largely to the failure of the mission. There was great reason to believe, he wrote, that the secret of the expedition had been divulged even before the two warships had set sail from Palermo roadstead.¹² And the same had been true in 1808 when, before the *Alceste* had sailed for the Tiber, its mission was being discussed in Malta.¹³ The court at Palermo was of course notorious for the presence of spies there and for careless talk.

A further attempt in 1811 to involve the British government in an attempt to free the pope was made by Queen Maria-Carolina through a Livornese banker called Gaspar Cifenti, but that plan very rapidly came to nothing. Napoleon's police got to know of the plot and Cifenti paid for it with his life.¹⁴

Whether the British in 1812 had any intention of trying again to take the pope away from Savona it is not possible to say. There is no documentary

evidence of it in the British Admiralty or Foreign Office files. But Napoleon certainly thought they had and that it was too dangerous to allow the pope to remain at Savona any longer, even though in the previous year its garrison had been reinforced. It was for this reason that Pius VII was removed to the safety of Fontainebleau.¹⁵

Notes

Abbreviations

ADM	Admiralty documents at the Public Record Office, Kew
Add. MS	Additional manuscript at the Department of Manuscripts, British Library, London
CO	Colonial Office documents at the Public Record Office, Kew
Dalrymple	Letterbook of Lady Dalrymple, in private hands at Broadoak, Dorset
FO	Foreign Office documents at the Public Record Office, Kew
PwJd	Portland Manuscripts at the Department of Manuscripts, University of Nottingham
WO	War Office documents at the Public Record Office, Kew

Chapter 1. Getting a Foothold

1. Sir A. W. Ward and G. P. Gooch, eds., *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy 1783–1919*, 3 vols. (Cambridge: 1922), 1: 238, 239n.3; C. H. D. Giglioli, *Naples in 1799* (London: Methuen, 1903), 48; J. Russell, *Nelson and the Hamiltons* (London: Blond, 1969), 18; Hamilton to Grenville, no. 35, 9 October 1796, no. 39, 22 November 1796, FO 70/9.

2. *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy*, 1: 579–80; A. B. Rodger, *The War of the Second Coalition 1798–1801* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1964), 76; Hamilton to St. Vincent 15 April 1798 copy FO 70/11; Grenville to Hamilton, no. 2, 20 April 1798, no. 3, 5 June drafts 1798 FO 70/11.

3. Grenville to Eden, no. 1, 16 January 1798, FO 7/51.

4. Eden to Grenville, no. 28, 16 April 1798, FO 7/51; Grenville to Hamilton, no. 2, 20 April 1798, FO 70/11; *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy*, 1: 578–80.

5. *Ibid.*, 287; Russell, *Nelson*, 27; Hamilton to Grenville, no. 14, 5 June 1798, FO 70/11.

6. Russell, *Nelson*, 28, 34–35; Hamilton to Grenville, no. 15, 18 June 1798, no. 18, 4 August 1798, no. 22, 21 August 1798, FO 70/11; *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy*, 1: 82, 582–3.

7. Russell, *Nelson*, 38, 51; H. Acton, *The Bourbons of Naples 1734–1825* (London: Methuen, 1956), 306, 309; Rodger, *Second Coalition*, 77.

8. *Cambridge History of British Foreign Policy*, 1: 288–89, 584.

9. Russell, *Nelson*, 56; Acton, *Bourbons*, 316–22.

10. Russell, *Nelson*, 63; Acton, *Bourbons*, 339–40.

11. N. E. Saul, *Russia and the Mediterranean 1787–1807* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1920), 75, 108–12.

12. *Ibid.*, 118–26.

13. Giglioli, *Naples*, 171–73; Acton, *Bourbons*, 345; H. Nelson, *Dispatches and Letters*, ed. Sir Nicholas H. Nicolas, 7 vols. (London: H. Colbourn, 1845–46), 3: 268.

14. Nelson to Stuart, 16 February 1799, copy FO 70/26.

15. Hamilton to Graham, 16 February 1799, copy FO 70/26; Hamilton to

Grenville, no. 8, 7 February 1799, no. 9, 13 February 1799, no. 14, 17 February 1799, FO 70/12.

16. V. Wortley, *Stuart, A Prime Minister to his son: correspondence of 3rd Earl of Bute with Sir Charles Stuart* (London: John Murray, 1925), 304.

17. Stuart to Dundas, 13 April 1799, FO 70/26; A. M. Delaroye, *Life of Thomas Graham, Lord Lynedoch* (London: Richardson; Marchant Singer, 1880), 164, 165, 167, 173.

18. Lynedoch MS, 3598 ff, 193–94, National Library of Scotland, Edinburgh. The statement Nelson made to Hamilton, in a letter of 13 October, that Dundas had earlier authorized the posting of Graham and his force to Valletta, but that he (Nelson) had kept back the order, is, on the evidence, completely untrue. One can only speculate on the reasons why Nelson told a deliberate falsehood. Presumably it was for the consumption of the court, who might have resented losing the troops. Nelson to Hamilton, 13 October 1799, *Nelson & Hamilton Papers*, ed. Morrison A. (London: privately published, 1894), vol. 2, no. 430).

19. Stuart to Dundas, 13 April 1799, FO 70/26.

20. P. Mackesy, *The War in the Mediterranean 1803–1810* (London: Longmans, 1957), 8–9; J. Holland Rose, *Select Dispatches relating to the Formation of the 3rd Coalition against France 1804–5* (London: Historical Society of Great Britain, 1904, 44–46).

21. Grenville to Hamilton, no. 1, 25 March 1799, draft FO 70/12.

22. Giglioli, *Naples*, 382–83; Acton, *Bourbons*, 428, 430; Rt. Hon. Sir A. B. Paget, ed, *The Paget Papers*, 2 vols. (London: W. Heinemann, 1886), 1: 190–2, 207–12, 238–42; M–H Weil, *Correspondance inédite de Marie–Caroline avec le marquis de Gallo* (Paris 1911) no. 344, 152; Grenville to Paget, 17 January 1800, additional instructions, draft FO 70/14; Paget to Grenville, 12 May 1800, FO 70/14.

23. Acton, *Bourbons*, 430. Paget was recalled in 1803, the court having earlier made a request that he be replaced by another minister. When five years later Canning attempted to reappoint Paget to the post, the court's protest was so insistent that the whole idea was quietly dropped. FO 70/34 ff 77, 98.

24. Paget to Grenville, no. 7, 4 July 1800, no. 10, 17 August 1800, FO70/14; Grenville to Paget, 10 October 1800, draft FO 70/14.

25. Grenville to Paget, no. 1, 28 February 1801, draft FO70/15.

26. Paget to Grenville, no. 6, 27 March 1801, FO70/15.

27. Drummond to Hawkesbury, no. 13, April 1802, FO70/17.

28. Paget to Grenville, no. 1, 15 January 1801, FO70/15; *Paget Papers* 265–66; Hawkesbury to Drummond, no. 2, 30 March 1802, draft FO 70/17; Drummond to Hawkesbury, no. 14, 19 April 1802, no. 24, 25 August, 1802, no. 25, 25 August 1802, private 10 September 1802, FO 70/18.

29. Drummond to Hawkesbury, no. 18, 3 March 1803, FO70/19.

30. A'Court to Hawkesbury, no. 7, 20 April 1803, FO 70/20.

31. A'Court to Hawkesbury, no. 14, 5 June 1803, FO 70/20.

32. A'Court to Hawkesbury, no. 15?, 11 June 1803, FO 70/20.

33. Nelson, *Despatches*, 5: 97–99.

34. *Ibid.*, 96–97.

35. Weil, *Correspondance*, no. 466, 463, no. 512, 588.

36. Acton, *Bourbons*, 476.

37. Add. MS 37268 ff 49–50

38. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 26–27.

39. D. Sultana, *Samuel Taylor Coleridge in Malta and Italy* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1969), 195–96; W. A. Miles, *Correspondence of W. A. Miles in the French Revolution 1789–1817*, 2 vols. (London: Longmans 1890), 2:335; Add MS 37268 f 50.

40. Sultana, *Coleridge*, 195–96.
41. C. Auriol, *La France, l'Angleterre et Naples de 1803 à 1806* 2 vols. (Paris, 1904), 1:488–93; Elliot to Nelson, 22 June 1803, 7 July 1803, copies FO70/21; Drummond to Canning, no. 20, 21 July 1808, FO 70/32 f 264; Hobart to Ball, 16 May 1803, 11 November 1803 draft; Ball to Hobart, no. 22, 26 July 1803, CO 158/7 ff 253, 295; Elliot to Ball, 10 July 1805, extract CO 158/8 f 98; Hawkesbury to Elliot, 11 November 1803, secret and confidential draft, FO 70/21.
42. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 54; Rose, *Select Dispatches*, 44–46, 60–61.
43. Auriol, *La France*, 1:368–71; Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 58, 400.
44. Elliot to Harrowby, 20 January 1805, most secret and enclos 27 March 1805; most secret and confidential, FO 70/24.
45. Harrowby to Elliot, no. 5, 5 November 1804, most secret draft, FO 70/23.
46. WO 6/56 ff 1–84
47. Mulgrave to Smith, 20 March 1805, FO 70/26; Smith to Craig, 17 August 1805, FO 70/26; Smith to Mulgrave, 24 October 1805, FO 70/26.
48. Countess of Minto Elliot-Murray-Knymound, *Memoir of Rt Hon Hugh Elliot* (London, 1868), 388–91; Elliot to Craig, 28 February 1806, extract FO70/27.
49. Acton, *Bourbons*, 524.
50. Nelson, *Dispatches*, 5:249; Add. MS 20176 ff 40–43.
51. Craig to Castlereagh, no. 24, 11 February 1806, WO 1/281 ff 81–95.
52. Craig to Castlereagh, no. 28, 16 February 1806, WO 1/281 ff 273–74.
53. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 92–93.

Chapter 2. Sicily as the British Found It in 1806

1. D. Mack Smith, *A History of Sicily: Mediaeval Sicily* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1968), xiii, 7–11.
2. *Ibid.*, xvi.
3. *Ibid.*, 26.
4. *Ibid.*, 115–21.
5. *Ibid.*, 74, 103.
6. Mack Smith, *A History of Sicily: Modern Sicily* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1968), 264.
7. H. Swinburne, *Travels in the Two Sicilies*, 2 vols. (London 1785), 2:212.
8. D. V. Denon, *Travels in Sicily and Malta* (trans) (London: Robinson, 1789), 144–45.
9. Mack Smith, *Mediaeval Sicily*, 16; Bentinck to Hippisley, extract, 13 January 1813, FO 70/62.
10. Nelson, *Dispatches*, 5:106–8.
11. Acton, *Bourbons*, 430–31. Lt. Gen. Sir H. Bunbury, *Narrative of Military Transactions in the Mediterranean 1805–1810* (London: privately printed, 1851), 36–37.
12. F. Renda, *La Sicilia nel 1812* (Caltanissetta 1963), 41.
13. J. Galt, *Voyages and Travels in 1809, 1810, and 1811* (London, 1812), 103; G. Bianco *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione inglese 1806–1815* (Palermo, 1902), 48–50.
14. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 272–74.
15. *Ibid.*; P. Brydone *A Tour through Sicily and Malta* (London: Strahan and Cadell, 1774, 1809 edition), 323.
16. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 274.
17. *Ibid.*, 276–80.
18. Elliot to Ball, extract, 12 March 1806, CO 158/12 f 203; J. C. Mellich, *La*

Cour de Sicile en 1809 par un diplomate anglais. Observations of Joseph Charles Mellish in Revue Historique diplomatique ed. Pingaud L. (Paris, 1894), 282; Robert Stewart, Viscount Castlereagh, *The Correspondence, Despatches and other papers of Viscount Castlereagh* 12 vols. (London, 1850–53), 8: 217–24.

19. Renda, *La Sicilia nel 1812*, 15. In 1855 the British consul at Palermo described Sicily's internal communications as a major obstacle to trade: "Palermo and Messina, 150 miles apart, have a pathless track between them 90 miles long. Palermo and Girgenti are connected only in part by a carriage road, and Girgenti and Marsala are separated by 80 miles of trackless waste." (Goodwin, *Accounts & Papers*), 9, 16, (1857) 553. R. Romeo, *Il Risorgimento in Sicilia* (Bari: Istituto Italiana per gli studi storici, 1950), 187; Galt, *Voyages*, 21–39, 41–42, 86, 96.

20. Bianco *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione*, 29–30.

21. J. Rosselli, *Lord William Bentinck and the British Occupation of Sicily 1811–1814* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press 1956), 2, 3, 172; D. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 316–31; C. Macfarlane, *Sicily and Her Constitutions* (London, 1849).

22. Drummond to Howick, 11 March 1807, private FO 70/30.

23. Sultana, *Coleridge*, 206.

24. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 29–30.

25. Bianco *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione*, 28–29.

26. Colonel Bunbury thought him a *faux bonhomme*—no match for his queen in talent and courage, but quite her equal in falsehood and treachery. (Bunbury, Sir H. *Military Transactions in the Mediterranean* (London: privately printed, 1851), 35–39.

27. Bianco, 23–24; J. Rambaud *Naples sous Joseph Bonaparte 1806–1808* (Paris, 1911), 36–38. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 335; Mellish, *Observations*, 128–32; Rosselli, *Bentinck* 8; A. Valente, *Gioacchino Murat e l'Italia meridionale* (Turin edition, 1965, first published 1941), 85.

28. Bentinck to Fagan, 11 June 1812, PwJd 2158 (Portland Manuscripts at University of Nottingham Library)

29. Sir J. F. Maurice, ed., *Diary of Sir John Moore*, 2 vols. (London: Edward Arnold, 1904), 191–92.

30. G. L. N. Collingwood, *Selection from the public and private correspondence of Vice Admiral Lord Collingwood interspersed with memoirs of his life* 4th ed. (London: James Ridgway, 1829), 498–500.

31. Bianco, *La Sicilia durante d'occupazione*, 23–25; R. M. Johnston, *The Napoleonic Empire in Southern Italy* 2 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1904) 1: 47, 164; Bentinck's Journal, 28 February 1812, 24 September 1812 PwJd 6254, 6256, Portland Papers at Nottingham University; Mellish, *Observations*, 124–25; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 8, 9, 175; Acton, *Bourbons*, 431; G. F. Leckie, *An Historical Survey of the Foreign Affairs of Great Britain* (London 1808), 98; Rambaud, *Naples*, 45–46; J. P. Garnier *Murat roi de Naples* (Paris, 1959), 113–19, 123.

32. Bianco, *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione* 23; Weil, *Correspondance de Marie-Caroline*, no. 445, p. 365; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 9; Rambaud, *Naples*, 45.

33. Drummond to Hawkesbury, no. 31, 19 October 1802, FO 70/18.

34. Auriol, *La France*, 1: 327–28, 667–73; Rambaud, *Naples*, 41; Johnston, *Napoleonic Empire*, 49; Elliot to Hawkesbury, no. 28, 15 June 1804, FO 70/22.

35. Elliot to C. J. Fox, no. 17, 7 June 1806, FO 70/27; Mellish, *Observations*, 285–88; Bentinck Journal, 30 January 1812, 2 March 1812 PwJd 6254.

36. Garnier, *Murat*, 117–18.

37. Bianco, *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione*, 26; A. Capograssi *Gli Inglesi in Italia durante le campagne napoleoniche* (Lord William Bentinck) (Bari: Biblioteca di Cultura Moderna, 1949), 29; Valente, *G. Murat*, 85–87.

38. Rambaud, *Naples*, 44.
39. Valente, *G. Murat*, 78, 79; Carbone to Bunbury, 22 June 1815, FO 70/73; Goulburn to Morier, 7 October 1815, copy FO 70/73.
40. Auriol, *La France* 1:401–6; Rambaud, *Naples*, 42n.2.
41. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 112–21.

Chapter 3. Problems of Defense

1. Jacques Rambaud, "Il tentativo di Murat contra la Sicilia nel 1810," *Archivio storico di Provincie Napoletane società di storia patria* (Naples, 1911), 435–36; Johnston, *Napoleonic Empire*, 1:118.
2. A. du Casse, *Mémoire et Correspondance politique et militaire du roi Joseph*, 4 vols. (Paris, 1853–54) 2:46, 62, 92, 123, 255, 286.
3. *Ibid.*, 3:167, 318, 388; 4:56.
4. Lt. Gen. H. Bunbury, *Narrative of Some Passages in the Great War with France* (London: Richard Bentley, 1854), 255; Stuart to Windham, 26 May 1806, WO 1/281 f 341.
5. Elliot to Collingwood, 2 March 1806, FO 70/27.
6. Elliot to Mulgrave, 9 April 1806, FO 70/27; Barrow to Hamilton, 21 December 1809, FO 70/38. According to Bunbury, the sailors exclaimed "Viva il re Giorgio, ma per il re Ferdinando no! no!" Lt. Gen. Sir Henry Bunbury, *Military Transactions*, 42.
7. H. Fox to C. J. Fox, 25 August 1806, private FO 70/29.
8. Rambaud, *Naples*, 60.
9. Bunbury, *Narrative The Great War*, 228–9.
10. Collingwood to Sidney Smith, 28 March 1806, copy ADM 1/412; Elliot to Collingwood, 29 April 1806, ADM 1/412.
11. Moore to Castlereagh, 23 August 1807, private 2 October 1807, WO 1/305 ff 177, 377.
12. Rambaud, *Naples*, 47–48.
13. Minto, *Memoir*, 398.
14. Elliot to H. Fox, 31 July 1806, FO 70/27; Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 128.
15. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 128–43; Maurice, *Diary*, 123.
16. H. Fox to C. J. Fox, 6 August 1806, very private FO 70/29.
17. Windham to Stuart, no. 6, 15 September 1806, WO 6/56 f 99; Historical Manuscripts Commission, British Library, Dropmore Papers (manuscripts of J. B. Fortescue, Esq. at Dropmore, 1892–1927), 8:313.
18. Bunbury, *Narrative, The Great War*, 232.
19. Moore, *Diary*, 126–28.
20. Add. MS 37852 f 187.
21. Elliot to C. J. Fox, 6 August 1806, private FO 70/27.
22. Add. MS 37847 f 111; Add. MS 37852 f 151.
23. H. Fox to C. J. Fox, 25 August 1806, private FO 70/29; Bunbury, *Military Transactions in the Mediterranean*, 86.
24. Add. MS 37050 f 48.
25. H. Fox to C. J. Fox, 12 September 1806, 9 October 1806, secret and confidential FO 70/29.
26. Collingwood, *Correspondence*, 240–41.
27. Add. MS 37050 f 53.
28. Fox to Howick, no. 5, 22 November 1806, FO 70/29.

Chapter 4. The Court, William Drummond, and the British Generals

1. Rambaud, *Naples*, 44–45.
2. Ibid.; Howick to Castelvica, 16 December 1806, FO 70/28; William Cobbett, *Parliamentary Debates from the Year 1803*, 41 vols. (London: Hansard), 1812–20), 8 (1806–7): 320, 359; *Cambridge History of Foreign Policy*, 1: 355.
3. Howick to Drummond, 3 October 1806, draft FO 70/30; Drummond to Howick, 11 March 1807, FO 70/30; Canning to Drummond, no. 3, 16 June 1807, no. 4, 15 August 1807, drafts FO 70/30, no. 4, 25 June 1808, draft FO 70/32 f 12.
4. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 160–61; Howick to Drummond, March 1807, draft FO 70/30; Drummond to Canning, no. 9, 26 March 1808, FO 70/32 f 185.
5. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 213; Drummond to Howick, no. 6, 11 March 1807, 11 March 1807, private FO 70/30; Canning to Drummond, no. 3, 16 June 1807, no. 4, 15 August 1807, no. 6, 26 December 1807, drafts FO 70/30.
6. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 182–84; Windham to Fox, November 1806, most secret draft, WO 1/281.
7. Fox to Windham, 14 May 1807, WO 1/304 f 339; Windham to Fox, June 1807, draft WO 1/304 f 371.
8. Add. MS 37050 f 140.
9. Ibid., ff 146–56; Fox to Windham, 5 April 1807, WO 1/304 f 177.
10. Add. MS 37050 ff 169, 176.
11. Castlereagh to Fox, 21 May 1807, draft WO 6/56 f 128.
12. Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 314, 445; Add. MS 37050 f 160; Fox to Castlereagh, 2 July 1807, secret and confid WO 1/305 f 83.
13. Add. MS 37050 ff 81, 133; Drummond to Howick, 11 March 1807, 9 April 1807, FO 70/30.
14. Add. MS 37050 ff 75, 103.
15. Drummond to Canning, 24 February 1808, FO 70/32 f 124.
16. Drummond to Canning, no. 14, 27 April 1808, FO 70/32 f 206.
17. Drummond to Howick, 11 March 1807, private FO 70/30.
18. Paget papers, *The diplomatic and other correspondence of the Rt. Hon. Sir Arthur Paget* ed Sir Augustus Paget 2 vols. (London, 1896), 2: 338; Moore, *Diary*, 162–66, 182.
19. Thornborough to Moore, 27 August 1807, WO 1/305 f 271.
20. Paget, *Papers*, 302–5.
21. Drummond to Canning, nos. 4, 5, 8, 27 January 1808, 24 February 1808, 25 March 1808, FO 70/32 ff 120, 124, 181; Canning to Drummond, no. 7, 26 December 1807, draft, no. 7, 25 June 1808, no. 9, 3 August 1808, secret, no. 10, 22 September 1808, FO 70/32 ff 14, 30, 41; Add. MS 20190 f 18.
22. Collingwood to Pole, no. 1, 6 January 1808, ADM 1/414; Thornborough to Pole, nos. 7 and 8, 29 February 1808, ADM 1/414; Drummond to Canning, no. 8, 25 March 1808, FO 70/32.
23. Castelvica to Canning, 12 February 1808, FO 70/34 f 28; Perry to Castelvica, 17 May 1809, copy FO 70/37 f 50; Castelvica to Perry, 22 May 1809, copy FO 70/37 f 54; Gibbs to Canning, 17 June 1809, private FO 70/38 f 79.
24. Castelvica to Canning, 22 August 1808, FO 70/35; G.F. Leckie, *An Historical Survey of the Foreign Affairs of Great Britain* (London, 1808), 9, 83–7, 98, 106.
25. Drummond to Canning, no. 16, 6 July 1808, FO 70/32 f 232.
26. Drummond to Canning, 31 May 1808 separate, 7 June 1808 separate, FO 70/32 ff 210, 212.
27. Drummond to Canning, no. 21, 24 July 1808, FO 70/32 f 275.
28. Canning to Drummond, no. 5, 25 June 1808, draft FO 70/32 f 14.

29. Canning to Drummond, no. 9, 5 August 1808, secret draft, FO 70/32 f 30.
30. Drummond to Canning, 7 July 1808 separate, no. 21, 24 July 1808, no. 31, 20 October 1808, FO 70/32 ff 236, 275, 324; Drummond to Circello, 12 July 1808, copy FO 70/32 f 260.
31. Canning to Drummond, no. 10, 22 September 1808, 2 March 1809, FO 70/32 ff 41, 64.
32. Drummond to Canning, 27 August 1808 separate, no. 25, 27 September 1808, FO 70/32 ff 294, 303.
33. Castalcicala to Canning, 5, 9 September 1808, FO 70/35 ff 54, 65; Canning to Castalcicala, 20 September 1808, draft FO 70/35 f 81.
34. Canning to Castalcicala, 20 September 1808, secret draft, FO 70/35 f 93.
35. Moore to Castlereagh, 13, 27 July, private, 10 August 1807, WO 1/305 ff 103, 127, 145.
36. Moore, *Diary*, 188–90.
37. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 222; Moore to Castlereagh, 13 July 1807 private, 10, 23 August 1807, 18 September 1807, secret, 2 October 1807, WO 1/305 ff 103, 145, 177, 213, 377.
38. Castlereagh, *Correspondence*, 8: 89–91.
39. Bunbury, *Narrative of Transactions in the Mediterranean*, 130–145; Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 264.
40. Add. MS 19426 f 6; Castlereagh to Stuart, 7 February 1808, drafts WO 1/306 f 9.

Chapter 5. Threats of Invasion

1. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 234–40; Casse, *Mémoire et Correspondance*, 4: 56.
2. Sherbrooke to Castlereagh, 8 January 1808, 8, 23 February 1808 and enclosure WO 1/306 ff 1–38; Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 332; Sir John William Fortescue, *A History of the British Army*, 13 vols. (London: Macmillan, 1910–30), 6: 108–9.
3. Casse, *Mémoire et correspondance*, 4: 135.
4. *Ibid.*, 168–70, 217–20; Rambaud, *Naples*, 186–87.
5. Stuart to Castlereagh, 25 May 1808, WO 1/306 f 139.
6. Stuart to Castlereagh, 20 September 1808, WO 1/306 f 431.
7. Stuart to Castlereagh, 22 September 1808, WO 1/306 f 441.
8. Marshal Joachim King of Naples Murat, *Lettres et Documents pour servir à l'histoire de Joachim Murat, publiés par le prince Murat*, 10 vols. (Paris, 1908–13), 6: 3506.
9. Mellish to Canning, no. 1, 5 November 1808, FO 70/33 f 12. Collingwood was scathing about its value. “The only advantage that could be derived from it was the probability of getting intelligence of what was doing at Naples, and I have never yet found the accounts received from thence were true.” In the present instance, he went on, the preparations of the numerous flotilla that had brought the invading troops from Naples seems to have been entirely unknown to the officer commanding the Capri garrison until it actually appeared. Collingwood to Pole, 14 November 1808, ADM 1/414 no 260.
10. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 292; Drummond to Canning, no. 28, 18 October 1808, FO 70/32 f 316 Collingwood, *Correspondence*, 500–502.
11. Murat, *Lettres*, 6: 3536, 3570, 3788, 3828; Napoleon I, *Correspondance publiée par ordre de l'Empereur Napoleon III*, 32 vols. (Paris, 1858–70), 18: 14493.
12. Drummond to Canning, no. 10, 27 March 1808, FO 70/32 f 189.

13. Canning to Drummond, no. 6, 25 June 1808, secret draft, FO 70/32 f 20.
14. Castlereagh to Stuart, June 1808, 6 July 1808, drafts WO 1/306 ff 191, 199.
15. Add. MS 20190 ff 115, 118, 120.
16. Collingwood, 437, 450.
17. Add. MS 20190 f 141; Stuart to Castlereagh, 26 August 1808, 3, 6 October 1808, 14 December 1808 WO 1/306 ff 379; Murat, *Lettres*, 6: 3775.
18. Murat, *Lettres*, 6: 3591, 3795.
19. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 288; Canning to Drummond, no. 14, 4 November 1808, draft FO 70/32 f 57; Mellish to Canning, no. 13, 31 December 1808, FO 70/33 f 46; Stuart to Castlereagh, 26 December 1808, 15 February 1809, WO 1/306 f 637, WO 1/307 f 25.
20. Castlereagh to Stuart, 24 May 1809, WO 6/56 f 165.
21. V. Gallavresi and V. Sallier de la Tour Marquis de Cordon *Le Maréchal Sallier de la Tour* (Turin, 1917), 70–83; Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 311.
22. Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 91–92; Stuart to Castlereagh, 27 April 1809, WO 1/307 f 121.
23. Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 102–5; Collingwood, *Correspondence*, 529–30.
24. Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 107–18; Stuart to Castlereagh, 24 May 1809, WO 1/307 f 161.
25. Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 327–30; Bunbury, *Military Transactions in the Mediterranean*, 164–65.
26. Stuart to Castlereagh, 9 June 1809, WO 1/307 f 165; Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 316.
27. Valente, *G. Murat*, 133–34.
28. Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 139–41.
29. Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 375; Murat, *Lettres*, 7: 4409.
30. Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 378–81; Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 139–41; Collingwood, *Correspondence*, 529–30.
31. Gallavresi, *Le Maréchal*, 160.
32. *Ibid.*, 165–68, 182; Amherst to Canning, 24 September 1809, FO 70/36 f 164.
33. Collingwood, *Correspondence*, 530–39, 544–46; Collingwood to Stuart, 15 July 1809, 2 August 1809, 1 September 1809, Stuart to Castlereagh, 26 September 1809, WO 33/12.
34. Add. MS 38245 f 295; Liverpool to Stuart, 29 November 1809, 30 December 1809, WO 33/12.

Chapter 6. Growing Impatience with the Court

1. Canning to Amherst, no. 1, 3 March 1809, no. 10, 16 August 1809, drafts FO 70/36 ff 1, 34; Amherst to Wellesley, 5 February 1810, FO 70/39 f 31.
2. Canning to Amherst, no. 1, 3 March 1809, draft FO 70/36 f 1.
3. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 51, 24 August 1810, FO 70/39 f 175; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 175, citing Cobbett, *Parliamentary Debates*, 11: 1140.
4. Amherst to Canning, no. 2, 13 May 1809, FO 70/36 f 72; Amherst to Stuart, 17 April 1810, WO 1/308 f 213.
5. Stuart to Castlereagh, 9 July 1809, private WO 1/307 f 239.
6. Amherst to Wellesley, 6 February 1810, FO 70/39 f 37; Stuart to Liverpool, 6 February 1810, WO 1/308 f 9.
7. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 12; Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 378; Stuart to Amherst, 13 January 1810, copy WO 1/308 f 21.

8. Drummond had had the poorest opinion of Sicilian nobles as potential ministers. He told Fox in April 1807 that he had made some attempt to get Prince Belmonte included in the cabinet and went on, "But who is there in the country, with the exception of Belmonte (of whom I could not think favourably, from the many reports I have heard) who could have been brought into the Government? Pantelleria is our avowed enemy, Cassaro is governed by Brissac, General Acton is hated by the whole country; Butera is shallow and without principles; Sambuca is too old; Trabea is a buffoon; Tommasi is a man of low birth, with great knowledge is capable of playing any game, and therefore, if he could be useful, he might be dangerous." Drummond to Fox, 28 April 1807, Bunbury, *Military Transactions*, 117–18 and n.

9. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 39, 11 June 1810, no. 40, 19 June 1810, secret, FO 70/39 ff 98, 102.

10. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 176; Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 397; Add. MS 20190 f 329.

11. P. Balsamo *Sulla historia moderna del Regno di Sicilia. Memorie Segrete* (Palermo, 1848), 6–7, 29–36.

12. Add. MS 37292 ff 51, 97.

13. Rambaud, "Il tentativo di Murat," 439–40.

14. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 39, 11 June 1810, no. 45, 14 July 1810, no. 49, 28 July 1810, FO 70/39 ff 98, 143, 167; Stuart to Liverpool, 25 June 1810, WO 1/308 f 463.

15. Salemi, *I trattati anti-napoleonici dell'Inghilterra con le due Sicilie* (Palermo, 1937), 83 n.3, 85.

16. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 49, 28 July 1810, no. 51, 24 August 1810, FO 70/39 ff 167, 175.

17. Stuart to Liverpool, 18 April 1810, WO 1/308 f 141; Amherst to Wellesley, no. 41, 22 June 1810, no. 45, 14 July 1810, no. 57, 23 September 1810, FO 70/39 ff 132, 143, 240.

18. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 41, 22 June 1810, no. 45, 14 July 1810, FO/70/39 ff 132, 143; Bunbury, *Narrative the Great War*, 399.

19. Salemi, *I trattati*, 84; Stuart to Amherst, 22 July 1810, copy WO 1/309 f 107.

20. Johnston, *Napoleonic Empire*, 239; Fortescue, *History of the British Army*, 7: 316–9; Reade to Stuart, 11 June 1810, copy WO 1/308 f 385; Stuart to Liverpool, 29 July 1810, WO 1/309 f 87; Fagan to Baker, 30 July 1810, copy FO 70/41; Martin to Cotton, 14 August 1810, copy (enclosed with no. 355 Cotton to Croker 12 September 1810) ADM 1/417.

21. Castlereagh to Stuart, no. 3, 18 April 1810, no. 9, 1 May 1810, no. 11, 3 July 1810, no. 13, 7 September 1810, drafts WO 6/60 ff 59, 83, 99, 115.

22. Fortescue, *History of the British Army*, 7: 316–19; Add. MS 19424 f 19.

23. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 58, 25 September 1810, FO 70/39 f 246; A. Espitalier *Napoléon et le roi Murat 1808–1815* (Paris, 1910), 64–65, 77, 82; Rambaud, "Il tentativo di Murat," 444–46, 705; Johnston, *Napoleonic Empire*, 239; Valente, *G. Murat*, 158–67; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 42.

24. Espitalier, *Napoleon et Murat*, 82; Rambaud, "Il tentativo di Murat" 703–8; Napoleon I, *Correspondance*, 17042, 18265.

25. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 66, 25 October 1810, FO 70/39 f 335; Stuart to Liverpool, 15, 16 October 1810, WO 1/309 ff 235, 281; Mackesy, *War in the Mediterranean*, 374; Fortescue, *History of the British Army*, 7: 320–22.

26. Salemi, *I trattati*, 84.

27. Add. MS 37292 f 313; Ayscough to Martin, 7 October 1810, (enclosed with no. 432 Cotton to Croker 20 November 1810) ADM 1/418.

28. Memorandum on Sicily, n.d. 1811, FO 70/49.

Chapter 7. Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage One

1. Balsamo, *Memorie*, 6–7, 29–36; Salemi, *I Trattati*, 96–97; Douglas to Wellesley, no. 13, 14 June 1811, FO 70/43; Castalcicala to Wellesley, 5 September 1811, FO 70/47.
2. Salemi, *I Trattati*, 87–88; Amherst to Wellesley, no. 71, 8 February 1811, no. 80, 28 March 1811, FO 70/42.
3. Wellesley to Amherst, no. 1, 25 February 1811, draft FO 70/42.
4. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 18–19.
5. Salemi, *I Trattati*, 106; Bentinck's Journal, 15 June 1812, PwJd 6255.
6. R. M. Johnston, *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* Harvard Historical Studies, vol. 16. (Massachusetts, 1912), 223 n; Valente, *G. Murat*, 216.
7. Castalcicala to Wellesley, 17 August 1810, FO 70/40 f 114; *Morning Post*, 14 August 1810; Castalcicala to Wellesley, 2 May 1811, FO 70/46.
8. Add. MS 41766 ff 134, 136, 143.
9. C. W. Pasley, *Essay on the Military Policy and Institutions of the British Empire* (London, 1810), 64–66, 88–90.
10. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 20, 178.
11. Add. MS 37292 f 313.
12. *Ibid.*, f 356.
13. Wellesley to Bentinck, no. 1, 20 May 1811, draft FO 70/44.
14. Douglas to Wellesley, 22 June 1811, private FO 70/43.
15. Bentinck to Wellesley, nos. 2, 3, 23 August 1811, FO 70/44.
16. Maitland to Wellesley, no. 1, 21 September 1811, FO 70/45.
17. Circello to Maitland, 25, 27 November 1811, copies FO 70/53; Maitland to Circello, 1 December 1811, copy FO 70/53.
18. Circello to Bentinck, 11 December 1811, copy FO 70/53.
19. Bentinck to Circello, 12 December 1811, copy FO 70/53; Circello to Bentinck, 19 December 1811, copy FO 70/53.
20. It is possible that he was "framed" by Carbone in order to protect those in high places. Angela Valente takes the view that he was almost certainly made a scapegoat. Valente, *G. Murat*, 214.
21. Maitland to Liverpool, no. 5, 15 September 1811, no. 8, 5 October 1811, no. 15, 15 November 1811, WO 1/310 ff 247, 309, 367; Maitland to Wellesley, nos. 1, 6, 21 September 1811, 24 October 1811, FO 70/45; Maitland to Circello, 3 December 1811, copy FO 70/53; Salemi, *I Trattati*, 110; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 49, 67–68; Johnston, *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 67–73, 75 n.2; Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 22, 19 March 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck Journal, 5 May 1813, PwJd 6257.
22. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 68. The Queen, it must be said, in her correspondence with Serra Capriola in Petersburg and with Castalcicala in London throughout the course of 1811 always denied she had ever had any correspondence with Napoleon, "whom no one hates more than I do," she wrote. If Napoleon were to make her an offer, she would, she went on, refuse to accept it, "since I consider him to be the greatest traitor and the greatest scoundrel." (E. Corti, *Ich eine Tochter Maria Theresa* (Munich, 1950), 608–9.
23. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 68; Castlereagh to Bentinck, no. 4, 9 February 1813, FO 70/56; Bentinck Journal, 26 October 1812, PwJd 6256.
24. Lady Dalrymple, *Letterbook*, 31 August 1811, f 72.
25. *Ibid.*, 24 January 1812, f 87.
26. *Ibid.*, 6 February 1812, f 88.
27. Wellesley to Bentinck, no. 12, 17 October 1812, secret draft FO 70/44.
28. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 12, 11 January 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck to Oakes,

27 December 1811, CO 158/13; Oakes to Bentinck, 15 December 1811, copy CO 158/13; J. Rosselli *Lord William Bentinck. The Making of a Liberal Imperialist 1774–1839* (London: Chatto & Windus for Sussex University Press, 1974), 110–11; Bentinck 25; Fagan to Bentinck, 29 September 1811, PwJd 2075.

29. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 12, 11 January 1812, FO 70/51.

30. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 80.

31. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 23, 17 March 1812, FO 70/51.

32. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 13, 11 January 1812, no. 14, 25 January 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck's Journal, 17 January 1812, PwJd 6254.

33. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 23, 17 March 1812, no. 25, 21 March 1812, FO 70/51.

34. Bentinck's Journal, 2 June 1812, PwJd 6255. Ascoli had been urging the king to take measures to embarrass the British by demobilizing 8,000 troops, stopping the pay of serving soldiers, and reducing the salaries of higher officials by as much as 20 percent, on the grounds that the British had withheld the subsidy. He also advised introducing new laws to stop the British contraband trade. Valente, *G. Murat*, 87.

35. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 32, 6 May 1812, secret and confidential, FO 70/51; Bentinck's Journal, 18 March 1812, 5 January 1813, 26 October 1813, 7 November 1813, PwJd 6254, 6257, 6258; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 31, 36.

36. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 22, 19 March 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck's Journal, 21 June 1812, PwJd 6255.

37. Bentinck to Wellesley, no. 16, 29 January 1812, FO 70/51; Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 27, 30 March 1812, secret, no. 37, 30 June 1812, and enclosed FO 70/51.

38. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 39, 9 July 1812, and enclosed FO 70/52.

39. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 45, 25 July 1812, FO 70/52.

40. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 45, 25 July 1812, FO 70/52; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 57–63.

41. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 4–5; Bentinck's Journal, 8 June 1812, PwJd 6255; Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 37, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51.

42. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 54–55.

43. *Ibid.*

44. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 57, 13 September 1812, FO 70/52; Bentinck's Journal, 1 August 1812, PwJd 6255.

45. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 40, 27 May 1813, FO 70/58; Bentinck's Journal, 13 February 1813, PwJd 6256.

46. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 88–94; Bentinck's Journal, 27 March 1812, 19 May 1812, 7, 22 July 1812, 22 October 1812, PwJd 6254, 6255, 6256.

47. Bentinck's Journal, 24 January 1813, PwJd 6257.

48. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 63, 24 October 1812, secret, no. 65, 26 October 1812, no. 74, 9 December 1812, FO 70/52; Bentinck's Journal, 29 June 1812, PwJd 6255; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 72.

49. Castlereagh to Bentinck, no. 3, 9 February 1813, secret draft, FO 70/56.

50. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 3, 18 January 1813, secret and confidential, FO 70/57; Bentinck's Journal, 17 October 1812, PwJd 6257.

51. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 3, 18 January 1813, secret and confidential, FO 70/57; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 84–86.

52. Bentinck's Journal, 28 October 1812, 2 November 1812, 16, 27 December 1812, PwJd 6256, 6257.

53. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 15, 10 March 1813, no. 16, 18 March 1813, FO 70/57; Johnston, *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline*, 216, 218 n.1, 223 n.

54. *Ibid.*, 225, n.1, 239–40; N. Niceforo, *La Sicilia e la Costituzione di 1812*,

Archivio storico Siciliano, (Palermo, 1922) ch. 4, 146–49; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 87; Bentinck's Journal, 10 March 1813, PwJd 6257.

55. Bentinck's Journal, 5 March 1813, PwJd 6257.

56. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 16, 18 March 1813, FO 70/57; Bentinck's Journal, 16 March 1813, PwJd 6257; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 95; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 83–84. H.M.S. *Edinburgh*, a 74-gun battleship, was also anchored in such a position that her broadside commanded the gate of San Felice and the whole of Palermo's main waterfront. Dalrymple, *Letterbook*, 24 March 1813, 111.

57. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 18, 4 April 1813, FO 70/58; Bentinck's Journal, 21 March 1813, PwJd 6257.

58. Bentinck's Journal, 27 March 1813, PwJd 6257.

59. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 18, 4 April 1813, FO 70/58.

60. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 19, 7 April 1813, FO 70/58; Salemi, *I trattati*, 125–26.

61. C. W. Crawley, "The Sicilian Constitution of 1812," *English Historical Review* (1940): 266, citing private diary of Sir Robert Wilson, 48.

62. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 30, 14 May 1813, FO 70/58.

63. Historical Manuscripts Commission. Bathurst Earl. The Manuscripts of the 7th Earl Bathurst. (London: Her majesty's stationery office, 1903), 208.

64. Castlereagh to Bentinck, no. 11?, 23 May 1813, FO 70/56.

65. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 68, 7 November 1812, FO 70/52, nos. 40, 41, 27 May 1813, FO 70/58.

66. Bentinck's Journal, 26 May 1813, PwJd 6258.

67. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 106.

Chapter 8. Bentinck and British Intervention, Stage Two

1. Balsamo, *Memorie*, 108.

2. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 108.

3. H. M. Lackland, "The Failure of the Constitutional Experiment in Sicily," *English Historical Review* (1926): 222.

4. Lady Dalrymple described how her carriage was surrounded in Palermo by a hostile crowd uttering cries "not loud *but deep*" of "maladetti Inglesi, Bestie, Pagani" [accursed English, brutes, infidels]. Dalrymple, *Letterbook*, 23 July 1813, 125.

5. Montgomerie to Castlereagh, no. 4, 20 June 1813, no. 20, 11 August 1813, FO 70/59; Macfarlane to Bathurst, no. 2, 20 June 1813, no. 3, 12 July 1813, WO 1/314 f 241, 249; Macfarlane to Hereditary Prince, 12 July 1813, WO 1/314 f 273; Murray to Bathurst, 28 August 1813, WO 1/314 f 335; Murray to Bentinck, 14, 25 August 1813, copies WO 1/314 ff 339, 343; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 214.

6. Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 221; Montgomerie to Castlereagh, no. 15, 22 July 1813, FO 70/59; Rosselli, *Liberal Imperialist*, 246.

7. Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 214, 219.

8. Bentinck's Journal, 11 October 1813, PwJd 6258.

9. Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 213; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 109; Montgomerie to Castlereagh, no. 11, 18 July 1813, FO 70/59; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 27 August 1813, secret, FO 70/59. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 348–49.

10. Montgomerie to Castlereagh, no. 20, 11 August 1813, no. 21, 26 August 1813, FO 70/59; Lackland, *Constitutional Experiment*, 224.

11. Bentinck to Montgomerie, 7 August 1813, copy FO 70/59.

12. Montgomerie to Castlereagh, no. 21, 26 August 1813, nos. 22, 23, 6 September 1813, FO 70/59; Smith's Journal, 15 June 1813, PwJd 6259.
13. Bentinck to Bathurst, 30 August 1813, secret, WO 1/314 f 51; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 108, 113.
14. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 107–8. In the words of Lady Dalrymple: "So great is his [Bentinck's] personal influence with the Sicilians, and so well grounded their opinion of his indomitable firmness and probity, that most sanguine hopes are entertained of his being able very soon to restore all things to tranquillity and order." Dalrymple, 13 September 1813, Letterbook, 127.
15. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 116; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 227–30.
16. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 45, 5? November 1813, no. 49, 10 November 1813, FO 70/59; Rosselli *Bentinck*, 116–20.
17. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 19 October 1813, private FO 70/59; Rosselli, *Liberal Imperialist*, 162.
18. Fagan to Bentinck, 5 September 1813, PwJd 2263a, October 1813, PwJd 2267; Bentinck to Hamilton, 25 January 1815, private FO 70/71.
19. Bentinck's Journal, 24 June 1812, PwJd 6255.
20. Bentinck's Journal, 3, 14 October 1812, 21 October 1813, PwJd 6256, 6258.
21. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 348–49; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 212, citing Smith's Journal, 21 June 1813.
22. Bentinck to Castlereagh, 19 October 1813, FO 70/59.
23. L. Giardina, "Lord Bentinck e il suo Sicilian Journal 1812–1814," *Archivio storico per la Sicilia orientale* (Catania, 1975) anno 71 fasc II–III 380–82; Bentinck's Journal, 29 May 1812, 16 March 1813, PwJd 6255, 6257; Smith's Journal, 30 June 1813, PwJd 6259.
24. Castlereagh to Bentinck, 19 October 1813, draft FO 70/56.
25. E. Sciacca, *Riflessi del Costituzionalismo europeo in Sicilia 1812–1815* (Catania: Studi risorgimentali, 1966), 129–30.
26. *Ibid.*, 184–85, citing Lackland, 223; G. Aceto, *De la Sicile et de ses rapports avec l'Angleterre à l'époque de la constitution de 1812* (Paris, London, 1827), 153.

Chapter 9. Sicily as a Base for Offensive Operations

1. Douglas to Wellesley, no 8, 31 May 1811, FO 70/43; Liverpool to Bentinck, 24 June 1811, draft WO 6/61 f 17.
2. Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 2, August 1811, WO 1/310 f 183; 25 January 1812, secret, no. 15, 20 May 1812, WO 1/311 ff 9, 315; Douglas to Wellesley, no. 16, 24 June 1811, secret FO 70/43; Hamilton to Bunbury, 6 January 1812, draft FO 70/55; Bentinck Journal, 2 March 1812, PwJd 6254.
3. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 37, 30 June 1812, FO 70/51; no. 44, 14 July 1812, no. 58, 13 September 1812, FO 70/52; no. 7, 23 January 1813, FO 70/57; Bentinck to Liverpool, no 15, 20 May 1812, WO 1/311 f 319; Bentinck to Bathurst, 2 November 1812, copy FO 70/62; E. Blaquière, *Letters from the Mediterranean*, 2 vols. (London: Henry Colbourn, 1813), 1:422.
4. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 53, 13 September 1812, FO 70/52; Castlereagh to Bentinck, no. 21, 22 October 1812, draft FO 70/50.
5. Stuart to Castlereagh, 4 February 1804, 25 September 1809, WO 1/307 ff 13, 273; Stuart to Liverpool, 11 February 1810, WO 1/308 f 103; Bentinck to Bathurst, 4 October 1812, secret WO 1/312 f 367; Lady Dalrymple, Letterbook, privately held, 21 December 1808, f 18. Carbone made out that the numbers recruited fell far

short of the figure expected and that the British had been anticipating as many as 7,000 enlistments. Like all statements by Carbone, it must be regarded with suspicion. Valente, *G. Murat*, 116.

6. J. Rosselli, "Il Progetto italiano di Lord William Bentinck, 1811–1815," *Rivista storica italiana* (Naples, 1967), 366–70, 377.

7. Liverpool to Bentinck, 4 June 1811, draft WO 6/61 f 1; Rosselli, *Il Progetto italiano*, 367, 371; Bentinck to Wellesley, 2 June 1811, Add. MS 37293 f 35.

8. Memorandum for Bentinck, September 1811, FO 70/44; Wellesley to Bentinck, no. 17, 21 October 1811, secret draft, FO 70/44; Liverpool to Bentinck, 12 October 1811, draft WO 6/61 f 81.

9. Hill to Castlereagh, 29 March 1812, secret, FO 67/43; Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 11, 15 March 1812, and enclosed WO 1/311.

10. Bentinck to Liverpool, 25 January 1812, WO 1/311 f 9.

11. Liverpool to Bentinck, 4 March 1812, draft WO 1/61 f 149; Pellew to Croker, no. 175, 15 April 1813, ADM 1/422.

12. Stuart to Liverpool, 29 February 1811, WO 1/310 f 23; Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 7, 10 February 1812, WO 1/311 f 67; Cotton to Croker, no. 724, 18 June 1811, ADM 1/419.

13. A. Parry, *Admirals Fremantle* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1971), 101–2; Pellew to Croker, 22 June 1812, and enclosed ADM 1/423, no. 230 A.

14. Parry, *Fremantle*, 102–09.

15. Duke of Wellington, *Dispatches*, compiled by Lieut. Col. Gurwood, 13 vols. 2d ed. (London: John Murray, 1844–47, 5: 743–45; Duke of Wellington, *Supplementary Dispatches*, ed his son, Duke of Wellington, 15 vols. (London, 1858–72), 7: 401; Sir Charles Oman, *A History of the Peninsular War*, 7 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1900–30), 5: 342–43.

16. Wellington, *Supplementary Dispatches*, 7: 374–77.

17. Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 22, 29 June 1812, WO 1/311 f 437.

18. Fagan to Bentinck, 2, 20 May 1812, PwJd 2139, 2149; Bentinck to Liverpool, 9 June 1812, secret, WO 1/311 f 355; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 25 June 1812, secret, FO 70/51.

19. Wellington, *Dispatches*, 5: 743.

20. Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 22, 29 June 1812, WO 1/311 f 437.

21. Oman, *Peninsular War*, 5: 347, 566.

22. Wellington, *Supplementary Dispatches*, 7: 374–77.

23. Bentinck to Bathurst, no. 19, 15 March 1813, WO 1/313 f 231.

24. Bathurst to Bentinck, no. 29, 13 October 1812, draft WO 6/61 f 253.

25. Bentinck Journal, 18, 28 August 1812, 4 September 1812, PwJd 6256.

26. Bentinck to Hereditary Prince, 30 June 1814, copy FO 70/64.

27. Bentinck to Bathurst, no. 8, 23 January 1813, WO 1/313 f 91; Sir William Napier, *History of the War in the Peninsula*, 7 vols. (London, 1836), 6: 616; Halliwell to Pellew, no 649, 11 February 1813, ADM 1/425.

28. Bentinck to Macfarlane, 24 May 1813, secret copy, WO 1/313 f 395; Bentinck to Bathurst, 24 February 1813, secret and separate, WO 1/313 f 157; Laurie to Pellew, 16 February 1813, extract enclosed with no 93, ADM 1/425; Napier to Laurie, 27 February 1813, copy enclosed with no 115, ADM 1/425.

29. Bentinck to Bathurst, no. 31, 20 May 1813, WO 1/313 f 353.

30. Lamb to Hamilton, 25 May 1813, FO 70/62.

31. Wellington, *Dispatches*, 10: 383–84; Rosselli, "Il Progetto italiano," 394.

32. Macfarlane to Bentinck, 25 May 1813, copy WO 1/313 f 403; Bentinck to Macfarlane, 27 May 1813, copy WO 1/313 f 407; Bentinck's Journal, 3 October 1812, PwJd 6256; 22 December 1812, PwJd 6257.

33. Bentinck to Pellew, 18 June 1813, copy WO 1/314 f 1; Pellew to Bentinck, 18 June 1813, copy WO 1/314 f 15; Napier, *History*, 7:692.
34. *Annual Register* 1814 (London: Rivington, 1815), 148–52; Bentinck to Bathurst, no. 46, 27 December 1813, and enclosed WO 1/313 f 46; Bentinck's Journal, 16, 22 November 1813, PwJd 6258; Rowley to Pellew, 15 December 1813, enclosed with no 53, ADM 1/428.
35. Bentinck to Bathurst, 8, 14 January 1814, secret, WO 1/315 ff 1, 9.
36. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 125–33; Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 32, 20 May 1813, secret, 10 June 1813, secret, FO 70/58; Castlereagh to Bentinck, 7 August 1813, draft FO 70/56.
37. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 50, 26 December 1813, FO 70/59.
38. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 52, 4 January 1814, FO 70/63.
39. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 1, 14 January 1814, FO 70/63.
40. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 4, 6 February 1814, FO 70/63; R. M. Johnston, "Lord William Bentinck and Murat," *English Historical Review* (1904): 273–74.
41. Douglas to Castlereagh, no. 5, 1 April 1814, FO 70/73.
42. R. J. Rath, *The Fall of the Napoleonic Kingdom of Italy (1814)* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1941), 51–54.
43. *Ibid.*, 56–59.
44. *Ibid.*, 159–70.
45. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 138, 141, 151, 209; Castlereagh, *Correspondence*, 9:427.

Chapter 10. Speculation on the Future of Sicily and Naples

1. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 129, 213, citing Historical Manuscripts Commission, Dropmore, 8:196; Pasley, *Essay on the Military Policy and Institutions of the British Empire* (London, 1810), 168–71.
2. Castlereagh, *Correspondence*, 8:224–32; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 11.
3. *Ibid.*, 127; Bentinck's Journal, 18 November 1813, PwJd 6258.
4. Rosselli, *Bentinck* 128; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 232; Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 157–59.
5. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 162.
6. *Ibid.*, 163.
7. *Ibid.*, 164.
8. Castalcicala to Castlereagh, 6, 9, 13 March 1814, FO 70/67; Bathurst to Castalcicala, 8 March 1814, draft FO 70/67.
9. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 165–67, 300; Bathurst to Castalcicala, 14 March 1814, draft FO 70/67; Castalcicala to Castlereagh, 15 March 1814, FO 70/67; Bentinck to Castlereagh, 10 May 1814, private FO 70/64 f 106.
10. Castlereagh, *Correspondence*, 9:238.
11. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 132–33.
12. *Ibid.*, 429.
13. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 173 n.28, citing Sir C. Webster, *The Foreign Policy of Castlereagh 1813–1822*, 2 vols. (London: G. Bell, 1934), 1:526.
14. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 34, 4 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 142; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 233; Acton *Bourbons*, 621.
15. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 34, 4 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 142; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 234–35, citing Bentinck's Journal, 16, 22 June 1814.
16. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 34, 4 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 142; Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 148.
17. W. Maturi, *Il congresso di Vienna e la Restaurazione dei Borboni a Napoli* Rivista storica italiana (Naples, 1958) 3: fasc IV 14–21.

18. Bentinck's Journal, 27, 29 June 1814, PwJd 6260.
19. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 36, 5 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 172.
20. Rosselli, *Liberal Imperialist*, 167; Bentinck's Journal, 22 June 1814, PwJd 6260.
21. A'Court to Hamilton, 3 July 1814, private FO 70/65 f 31; Bentinck's Journal, 1 July 1814, PwJd 6260.
22. Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 4, 4 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 142; Lackland, "Constitutional Experiment," 235, n. 3, citing Michel Palmieri di Micciche *Pensées et souvenirs historiques et contemporains* (Paris, 1830) 1:21.
23. Bentinck to Villafranca, 30 June 1814, copy FO 70/64 f 139; Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 35, 4 July 1814, FO 70/64 f 165.
24. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 3, 16 July 1814, FO 70/65 f 37; Castlereagh to A'Court, no. 6, 7 September 1814, FO 70/65 f 15.
25. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 7, 4 March 1815, FO 70/69 f 68.
26. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 16, 21 September 1814, FO 70/65; Castlereagh to A'Court, no. 8, 14 October 1814, draft FO 70/65 f 23.
27. Castlereagh to A'Court, nos. 7, 8, 9, 7 June 1815, drafts FO 70/69 ff 12, 14.
28. Macfarlane to Bathurst, no. 11, 24 May 1815, WO 1/285 f 93.

Chapter 11. The Dénouement

1. Rosselli, *Liberal Imperialist*, 150, citing Add. MS 41515 f 62.
2. Memorandum by A'Court, February 1814, FO 70/68.
3. Castlereagh to A'Court, 14 March 1814, draft FO 70/65 ff 1, 3.
4. Memorandum by A'Court cited above in note 2.
5. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 168–69.
6. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 4, 23 July 1814, FO 70/65 f 39.
7. Rosselli, *Liberal Imperialist*, 162.
8. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 4, 23 July 1814, no. 10, 17 August 1814, FO 70/65 ff 39, 87.
9. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 9, 6 August 1814, FO 70/65 f 80.
10. A'Court to Castlereagh, 22 August 1816, remarks on Prince Metternich's dispatch, FO 70/75; Castlereagh to A'Court, nos. 10, 11, 6 September 1816, drafts FO 70/75.
11. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 35, 5 November 1816, FO 70/75.
12. A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 14, 15 July 1815, FO 70/70.
13. Capograssi, *Gli Inglesi*, 241.
14. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 352–53; A'Court to Castlereagh, no. 35, 5 November 1816, FO 70/75.
15. Rosselli, *Bentinck*, 154–55, citing *Parliamentary Debates*, 25 vols. (London: Hangard, 1820–30), 5: 1234 ff.
16. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 352.
17. Macfarlane, *Sicily*, 33.
18. Macfarlane, *Sicily*, 44. Very similar words were used by the king in a letter he wrote to Castelcicala in August 1814: "I am more than ever convinced that the new constitution is unsuited to the great differences that exist between Sicilians and English in character, inclination, habits, public spirit, education and customs." Valente, *G. Murat*, 82 n. 3.
19. *Ibid.*, 31.
20. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 353.
21. Macfarlane, *Sicily*, 35.

22. G. Aceto, *De la Sicile et de ses rapports avec l'Angleterre a l'époque de la constitution de 1812* (Paris, London, 1827), 177.

23. Ball to Castlereagh, 30 November 1807, CO 158/13 f 459.

24. L. Simond, *A Tour in Italy and Sicily* (London, 1828), 535, cited by R. Trevelyan in *Princes under the Volcano* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1972), 24.

Appendix A. Economic Implications

1. E. Loncaio, *Il lavoro e le classi rurali in Sicilia durante e dopo il Feudalismo* (Palermo 1800), 85–86; L. Bianchini, *Della Storia Economico-civile di Sicilia* 2 vols. (Naples, 1841) 2: 239; Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 338–39; Galt, *Voyages*, 40.

2. V. Titone, *La Costituzione del 1812 e l'occupazione inglese della Sicilia* (Bologna, 1936), 116; Galt, *Voyages*, 21; Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 338–39.

3. Fawkenner to Hammond, 5 November 1808, FO 70/35 f 141.

4. Graham to Fagan, 25 October 1813, FO 70/73.

5. Add. MS 4156 ff 74, 102, 171, 189, 205, 232; Bentinck to Castlereagh, no. 43, 30 October 1813, no. 45, 5 November 1813, FO 70/59.

6. Ingham's commercial interests were diverse and by 1815 included banking. He made his business headquarters at Palermo while maintaining his *baglio* at Marsala. Raleigh Trevelyan, *Princes under the Volcano* (London: Macmillan, 1972), 6, 15, 24.

7. R. Lentini, "Note su un operatore commerciale in Sicilia, Abraham Gibbs (1799–1902)," *Nuovi Quaderni del Meridione* (1976): 387.

8. Mellish to Canning, no. 2, 6 November 1808, FO 70/33 f 15.

9. Bathurst to Hamilton, 3 December 1811, FO 70/49.

10. Chetwynd to Hamilton, 17 January 1812, and enclosed FO 70/55.

11. Judith B. Williams *British Commercial Policy and Trade Expansion 1750–1850* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1972), 212–13, citing Fagan to Hamilton, 28 September 1811, 19 November 1811, FO 70/45, and Castalcicala to Liverpool, 24 February 1812, FO 70/53.

12. W. H. Thompson, *Sicily and its Inhabitants. Observations made in 1809 and 1810* (London, 1813).

13. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 338–39.

14. W. R. Rawson, "On the Sulphur Trade of Sicily and the Commercial relations between that country and Great Britain," 5 vols., *Journal of the Statistical Society of London*, 1839 2: 450–56. Petition of 5 merchants copy 1811 FO 70/43.

15. Mack Smith, *Modern Sicily*, 338–39; Bentinck Journal, 11 May 1812, PwJd 6255; Parry, *Fremantle*, 98–99; Thompson, *Sicily*, 27; Bey of Tunis to Prince Regent, June 1813, enclosed with no 258, ADM 1/426; Bentinck to Liverpool, no. 14, 20 July 1812, and enclosed WO 1/311 f 299.

16. Consul Goodwin, *Supplement to the commercial report on Sicily*, 23 November 1835, FO 70/143.

Appendix B. Attempts to Rescue Pope Pius VII

1. E. Y. Hales, *The Revolution and the Papacy 1769–1846* (London: Eyre and Spottiswoods, 1960), 188.

2. Collingwood to Pole, no 160, 13 July 1808, ADM 1/414; Canning to Drummond, June 1808, FO 70/32; Drummond to Canning, no. 24, 29 August 1808, secret, FO 70/32 f 299.

3. Collingwood to Pole, no 160, 13 July 1808, ADM 1/414.

4. Drummond to Canning, no. 24, 29 August 1808, secret FO 70/32 f 299; R.

Trevelyan, "Robert Fagan, an Irish Bohemian in Italy," *Apollo Magazine* (October 1972): 298–302.

5. Drummond to Canning no. 24, 29 August 1808 secret FO 70/32 f 299.

6. Ibid.

7. Maxwell to Collingwood, 15 October 1808, ADM 1/414 (enclosed with no 242); Drummond to Canning, no. 29, 19 October 1808, FO 70/32 f 318.

8. Hales, *Revolution and Papacy*, 188; B. Cardinal Pacca, *Notes on the ministry of Cardinal B. Pacca*, (trans.) (Dublin: J. Cumming, 1843), 42–50.

9. I am indebted to the late Mr. E. E. Y. Hales for this information.

10. Amherst to Wellesley, no. 36, 6 May 1810, FO 70/39 f 86; Mayol de Lupé, *La captivité de Pie VII* (Paris, 1912), 345, 356, 404, passim.

11. Cotton to Croker, no 317, 26 July 1810 ADM 1/417; Amherst to Wellesley, no. 42, 5 July 1810, FO 70/39 f 135.

12. Ibid.

13. Drummond to Canning, no. 24, 29 August 1808, secret, FO 70/32 f 299.

14. Mayol de Lupé, *La captivité*, 422.

15. Ibid., 597 n.3.

Bibliography

Original Sources

Manuscripts

Public Record Office, Kew

Foreign Office Naples and Sicily FO 70/11-75
Sardinia FO 67/43

War Office WO 1/303-315
WO 1/280, 281, 285
WO 6/56, 57, 60, 61

Admiralty ADM 1/412-428

Colonial Office Malta CO 158/7, 8, 11-13, 15, 18, 21, 22

British Library (Department of Manuscripts)
Add. MSS. 14273-14279 (Collingwood)
19424 (Annesley)
20176, 20190 (Hudson Lowe)
36730 (Fagan)
37050 (Bunbury)
37268 (Letters of Sir Alexander Ball)
37292 (Wellesley)
37847, 37852 (Windham)
38245 (Liverpool)
41514, 41516 (Heytesbury)
41766 (Pasley)

Nottingham University Library

Portland Manuscripts PwJd 6254-6258, 6260 Sicilian Journal of Lord William Bentinck

PwJd 6259 Journal of Joseph Smith

PwJd 2072-2294 Correspondence of Robert Fagan with Lord William Bentinck and with Queen Maria Carolina

Private Letters of Lady Dalrymple, Broadoak, Bridport

Printed Sources

Bathurst, Earl. *The Manuscripts of the 7th Earl Bathurst*. Historical Manuscripts Commission. London: Her Majesty's Stationery Office, 1913.

Casse, Pierre Emmanuel Albert du. *Mémoire et correspondance politique et militaire du roi Joseph*. 4 vols. Paris, 1853-54.

———. *Supplément à la correspondance de Napoleon I^{er}*. Paris, 1887.

Castlereagh, Robert Stewart Viscount. *The Correspondence, Despatches, and other Papers of Viscount Castlereagh*. 12 vols. London, 1850-53.

- Cobbett, William. *Parliamentary Debates from the year 1803*. 41 vols. London: Hansard, 1812–20. Vols. 12, 16, 19, 22, 25.
- Collingwood, George Lewes Newnham. *Selection from the public and private correspondence of Vice Admiral Lord Collingwood interspersed with memoirs of his life*. 4th ed. London: James Ridgway, 1829.
- Cresceri, Giacomo von. *Memorie Segrete des Freiherrn Giangiacomo von Cresceri*. Edited by Freiherrn von Helfert. Wien, 1892.
- Damas, Count Roger de. *Mémoires*. Edited by Jacques Rambaud. Paris, 1913.
- Dropmore Papers. The manuscripts of J. B. Fortescue, Esq. at Dropmore. Historical Manuscripts Commission, (1892–1927). British Library. Vol. 8.
- Mayol de Lupé, Count. *La Captivité de Pie VII*. Paris, 1912.
- Moore, Sir John. *Diary of Sir John Moore*. Edited by Sir John Frederick Maurice. 2 vols. London: Edward Arnold, 1904.
- Morrison, Alfred. *The Collection of Autograph Letters and Historical Documents formed by A. Morrison*. Nelson and Hamilton Papers. Vol. 2. Privately printed 1893, 1894.
- Murat, Marshal Joachim King of Naples. *Lettres et Documents pour servir à l'histoire de Joachim Murat*. Publiés par le prince de Murat. 8 vols. Paris, 1908–13. Vols. 6–8.
- Napoleon I. *Correspondance publiés par l'ordre de l'Empereur Napoléon III*. 32 vols. Paris, 1858–70.
- Nelson, Horatio. *The Despatches and Letters of Vice-Admiral Lord Nelson*. Edited by Sir Nicholas Harris Nicolas. 7 vols. London: H. Colbourn, 1844–1848. Vols. 5–7.
- Paget, Sir Arthur. *The Diplomatic and other correspondence of the Rt Hon Sir Arthur Paget*. Edited by Sir Augustus Paget. 2 vols. London: Heinemann, 1896.
- Parliamentary Debates*. New series. 25 vols. London: Hansard, 1820–30.
- Picard, Ernest. *Unpublished correspondence of Napoleon I preserved in the War Archives*. London: E. Picard, 1913.
- Rose, John Holland. *Select Dispatches relating to the formation of the 3rd Coalition against France 1804–1805*. London: Historical Society of Great Britain, 1904.
- Stuart, John, 3rd Earl of Bute. *A Prime Minister to his son: Correspondence of the 3rd Earl of Bute and of Lt General the Hon. Sir Charles Stuart*. Edited by Mrs. E. Stuart Wortley. London: John Murray, 1925.
- The Wellesley Papers. The Life and Correspondence of Richard Colley Wellesley 1760–1842*. Edited by L. S. Benjamin. 2 vols. London: Herbert Jenkins, 1914.
- Wellington, The Duke of. *Dispatches*. Compiled by Lt. Col. Gurwood. 13 vols. 2d ed. London: John Murray, 1844–47. Vol. 5.
- . *Supplementary Dispatches*. Edited by his son, the Duke of Wellington. 15 vols. London 1858–72. Vol. 7.
- Windham William. *The Life and Correspondence of the Rt. Hon. William Windham 1750–1810*. Edited by L. S. Benjamin. 2 vols. London: Herbert Jenkins, 1913.

Secondary Sources

- Aceto, Giovanni. *De la Sicile et de ses rapports avec l'Angleterre à l'époque de la constitution de 1812*, Paris, London, 1827.
- Acton, Harold. *The Bourbons of Naples*. London: Methuen, 1956.
- Adair, Rt. Hon. Sir Robert. *Historical Memoir of a Mission to the Court of Vienna in 1806*. London: Longman, 1884.

- Anonymous. *Sicily and England A Sketch. Events in Sicily in 1812 and 1848*. London: James Ridgway, 1849.
- Auriol, Charles. *La France, l'Angleterre et Naples de 1803 à 1806*. 2 vols. Paris, 1904.
- Balsamo, Paolo. *Sulla historia moderna del Regno di Sicilia. Memorie segrete*. Palermo, 1848.
- Bianchini, Cav. Ludovico. *Della storia economico-civile di Sicilia*. 2 vols. Naples, 1841.
- Bianco, Giuseppe. *La Sicilia durante l'occupazione inglese 1806–1815*. Palermo, 1902.
- Blaquière, Edward. *Letters from the Mediterranean*. 2 vols. London: Henry Colbourn, Vol. 1.
- Borch, M. J.. *Lettres sur la Sicile et sur l'île de Malte*. 2 vols. Turin, 1782.
- Browning, Oscar. "Hugh Elliot at Naples," *English Historical Review* (1889): 209–27.
- . "Queen Caroline of Naples." *English Historical Review* (1877): 490–572.
- Brydone, Patrick. *A Tour through Sicily and Malta*. 2 vols. London: W. Straham and D. Cadell, 1773.
- Buckland, Charles Stephen. *Metternich and the British Government*. London: Macmillan, 1932.
- Bunbury, Lieutenant General Sir Henry. *Narrative of some Passages in the Great War with France from 1799–1815*. London: Richard Bentley, 1854.
- . *Narrative of Military Transactions in the Mediterranean 1805–1810*. London: privately printed, 1885.
- Butterfield, H. *The Peace Tactics of Napoleon 1806–1808*. Cambridge: University Press, 1929.
- Caldora, Umberto. *Calabria napoleonica. 1806–1815*. Naples: Collana, 1960.
- Capograssi, Antonio. *Gli Inglesi in Italia durante le campagne napoleoniche (Lord William Bentinck)*. Bari: Biblioteca di cultura moderna, 1949.
- Cockburn, G. *Voyage to Cadiz and Gibraltar etc in 1810, 1811*. London, 1815.
- Colletta, Pietro. *History of the Kingdom of Naples 1734–1825*. Translated by S. Horner. 2 vols. Edinburgh: T. Constable, 1858.
- Coquelle, P. *Napoleon and England 1803–1813*. Translated by Gordon D. Knox. London: George Bell and Sons, 1904.
- Corti, Conte Egon. *Ich eine Tochter Maria Theresas*. Munich, 1950.
- Crawley Charles W. "The Sicilian Constitution of 1812." *English Historical Reviews* (1940): 251–74.
- Delayoye, Alexander M. *Life of Thomas Graham Lord Lynedoch*. London: Richardson, Marchant Singer, 1880.
- Denon, Dominique V. *Travels in Sicily and Malta*. London: Robinson, 1790.
- Driault, J. Edouard. *Napoléon en Italie (1800–1812)*. Paris, 1906.
- Espitallier, Albert. *Napoléon et le roi Murat 1808–1815*. Paris, 1910.
- Fortescue, Sir John William. *A History of the British Army*. 13 vols. London: Macmillan, 1910–1930. Vols. 6–9.
- Gallavresi, Giuseppe, et Sallier de la Tour, Victor Amédée. *Le Maréchal Sallier de la Tour*. Biblioteca di storia Italia recente. Turin, 1917.
- Galt, John. *Voyages and Travels in 1809, 1810 and 1811*. London, 1812.
- Garnier, Jean-Paul. *Murat roi de Naples*. Paris, 1959.
- Giardina, Lisetta. "Lord Bentinck e il suo Sicilian Journal 1812–1814." Archivio

- storico per la Sicilia Orientale. Catania: Istituto Universitario, 1975. Anno 71 fasc II–III, 359–435.
- Giarizzo, Giuseppe. "Riflessioni sulla fazione dominante e su la condotta del nuovo ministero in Sicilia (1814)." *Archivio storico per la Sicilia Orientale*. Catania Istituto Universitario, 1971. Anno 67 fasc II–III, 261–331.
- Giglioli, C. H. D. *Naples in 1799*. London: Methuen, 1903.
- Hoare, Sir Richard C. *A Classical Tour through Italy and Sicily*. 2 vols. London, 1819.
- Johnston, Robert Matteson. "Lord William Bentinck and Murat." *English Historical Review* (1904): 263–80.
- . *The Napoleonic Empire in Southern Italy*. 2 vols. London: Macmillan, 1904. Vol. 1.
- , ed. *Mémoire de Marie-Caroline* Harvard Historical Studies, vol 16. Massachusetts, 1912.
- Lackland, H. M. "The Failure of the Constitutional Experiment in Sicily." *English Historical Review* (1926): 210–35.
- La Lumia, Isidora. *Carlo Cottone Principe di Castelnuovo*. Storie Siciliane 4 vols. Palermo, 1883. Vol. 4.
- Leckie, Gould Francis. *An Historical Survey of the Foreign Affairs of Great Britain*. London, 1808.
- Loncao, Enrico. *Il lavoro e le classi rurali in Sicilia durante e dopo il Feudalismo*. Palermo, 1900.
- Lord Walter, Frewen. *England and France in the Mediterranean 1660–1830*. London: Sampson Low, 1901.
- Macfarlane, Charles. *Sicily and her Constitutions*. London, 1849.
- Mack Smith, Denis. *Modern Sicily after 1713*. London: Chatto and Windus, 1968.
- Mackesy, Piers. *The War in the Mediterranean 1803–1810*. London: Longmans, 1957.
- Maturi, Walter. "Il Congresso di Vienna e la restaurazione dei Borboni a Napoli." *Rivista storica italiana*. Naples, 1958. Vol 3, fasc iv.
- . *Il Principe di Canosa*. Studi e document: di storia del Risorgimento. Firenze, 1944.
- Mellish, Joseph Charles. "La Cour de Sicile en 1809 par un diplomate anglais, observations of Joseph Charles Mellish," edited by L. Pingaud. *Revue historique diplomatique* (1894):281–88; (1895):124–32.
- Miles, William A. *Correspondence of W. A. Miles on the French Revolution 1789–1817*. 2 vols. London: Longmans, 1890. Vol. 2.
- Monk, Winston Francis. *The British in the Mediterranean*. London: Hutchinson, 1953.
- Mozzillo, Anastasio. "La Sicilia nel giudizio dei viaggiatori inglesi." *Nuovi Quaderni del Meridione* (1978):51–68.
- Napier, Sir William F. P. *History of the War in the Peninsula and the South of France*. 7 vols. London, 1836. Vol. 5.
- Neu, Irene D. "An English Businessman in Sicily 1806–1861." *The Business History Review* no. 4 (Winter 1957): 365–75.
- Niceforo, N. "La Sicilia e la costituzione del 1812" *Archivio storico siciliano* (1922): 70–151.

- Oman, Sir Charles. *A History of the Peninsular War*. 7 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1900–30). Vol. 5.
- . *Studies in the Napoleonic Wars*. London: Methuen, 1929.
- Pacca, Bartolomeo Cardinal. *Notes on the ministry of Cardinal B. Pacca*. Translated from the Italian. Dublin: J. Cumming, 1843.
- Palmeri, Niccolò. *Saggio storico e politico sulla costituzione del regno di Sicilia infino al 1816*. Edited at Lausanne, 1847.
- Parry, Anne. *Admirals Fremantle*. London: Chatto and Windus, 1971.
- Pasley, Sir Charles W. *Essay on the Military Policy and Institutions of the British Empire*. London, 1810.
- Pontieri, Ernesto. *Il riformismo borbonico nella Sicilia del sette e dell' ottocento*. saggi storici. Rome, 1945.
- Rambaud, Jacques. *Naples sous Joseph Bonaparte 1806–1808*. Paris, 1911.
- . “Il tentativo di Murat contra la Sicilia nel 1810.” *Archivio storico di Provincie Napoletane società di storia patria* (1911): 434–50, 695–709.
- Rath, R. J. *The Fall of the Napoleonic Kingdom of Italy*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1942.
- Renda, Francesco. *La Sicilia nel 1812*. Caltanissetta, Rome, 1953.
- Rodger, A. B. *The War of the Second Coalition*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1964.
- Romeo, Rosario. *Il Risorgimento in Sicilia*. Bari: Istituto Italiano per gli studi storica, 1950.
- Rosselli, John. *Lord William Bentinck and the British Occupation of Sicily 1811–1814*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1956.
- . *Lord William Bentinck. The Making of a Liberal Imperialist 1774–1839*. London: Chatto & Windus for Sussex University Press, 1974.
- . “Il Progetto italiano di Lord William Bentinck 1811–1815.” *Rivista storica italiana* (Naples, 1967): 355–404.
- Russell, J. *Nelson and the Hamiltons*. London: Blond, 1969.
- Salemi, Leonardo. *I trattati anti-napoleonici dell'Inghilterra con le due Sicilie*. Palermo: Istituto Nazionale Fascista di Cultura, sezione di Palermo, 1937.
- Saul, N. E. *Russia and the Mediterranean*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1970.
- Sciacca, Enzo. *Riflessi del costituzionalismo europeo in Sicilia 1812–1815*. Catania: Studi risorgimentali, 1966.
- Shupp, P. F. *European Powers and the Eastern Question 1806–1807*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1931.
- Sultana, D. *Coleridge in Malta and Italy*. Oxford: Blackwell, 1969.
- Swinburne, Henry. *Travels in the Two Sicilies 1777–80*. 2 vols. London, 1795.
- Tarle, E. *Le Blocus Continental et le Royaume d'Italie*. Paris, 1928.
- Thompson, W. H. *Sicily and its inhabitants. Observations made in the years 1809 and 1810*. London, 1813.
- Titone, Virgilio. *La Costituzione del 1812 e l'occupazione inglese della Sicilia*. Bologna, 1936.
- Travelyan, Raleigh. *Princes under the Volcano*. London: Macmillan, 1972.
- . “Robert Fagan, an Irish Bohemian in Italy.” *Apollo Magazine* (1972): 298–309.

- Tuzet, Hélène. *Voyageurs français en Sicile au temps du Romantisme*. Etudes de littérature étrangère et comparée. Paris, 1947.
- Valente, A. G. *Murat e l'Italia meridionale*. Turin: Einaudi, 1965 ed. First published Milan, 1941.
- Webster, Sir Charles. *The Foreign Policy of Castlereagh 1813-1822*. 2 vols. London: G. Bell, 1934. Vol. 1.
- Weil, Maurice H. *Ferdinand IV et le Duc d'Orleans*. Paris: Revue de Paris, 1898.
- . *Le Prince Eugène et Murat*. 5 vols. Paris, 1902. Vols. 1, 3.
- , ed. *Correspondance de Maria Carolina avec de Gallo*. Paris, 1911.
- Williams, Hugh N. *The Life and Letters of Admiral Sir Charles Napier*. London: Hutchinson, 1917.
- Wilson, Sir Robert Thomas. *Private Diary*. Edited by H. Randolph. 2 vols. London, 1861.

Index

- Aberdeen, George Hamilton-Gordon, fourth earl (British envoy at Vienna): presses Bentinck to sign armistice, 119
- Aci, Giuseppe Reggio, prince of: becomes minister, 96; his differences with Bentinck, 97; dismissed, 102; incompetence of, 97
- A'Court, William (later baronet and first baron Heytesbury, secretary of legation at Naples 1801, envoy extraordinary at Palermo and Naples 1814–22): advises King Ferdinand on constitution, 133; appointed deputy minister, 131; decorated by King Ferdinand, 133; his interview with Castle-reagh 1814, 131; nicknamed by Sicilians, 133; his political sympathies, 129; protests on behalf of British merchants, 138; replaces Bentinck as minister, 126; his views on Sicilian constitution and British intervention, 130–32
- Acton, Sir John (minister at the court of Naples and Palermo), 24, 28, 58; his ability, 42–43; his Anglophile policy, 26; his influence on king, 26; recovers influence 1806, 43; removed to Sicily, 43; his retirement, 42; urged by Nelson not to risk Sicily, 27
- Addington, Henry (later first viscount Sidmouth, prime minister 1801–4): orders Nelson to protect Sicily, 27
- Alexandria: captured by British 1807, 60
- Amherst, William Pitt, second baron and first earl (minister at court of Palermo 1809–11): deplores lack of guidance from London, 82; favors British intervention in Sicily, 82–84; involved in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 144–45; protests at queen's "secret undertakings," 82; replaces Drummond as minister, 79; requests unified command in Sicily, 89; resigns, 91; suspects court of treachery, 78, 84, 88
- Amiens, Treaty of, 1802, 26
- Ascoli, Troiano Morulli, duke of: accompanies Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67; accompanies Prince Leopold to Ischia, 76; as agent of King Ferdinand, 43–44; his character, 43; exiled, 96; his influence at court, 43, 99; his relations with British, 43–44
- Augusta, port of, 19, 33, 48, 59, 136
- Austria, 11, 99; Bentinck seeks to forestall in Italy, 115; causes French to withdraw troops from south Italy, 73; conquers Naples 1815, 128; defeated in 1796, 15; defeated in 1805, 33; disapproves Neapolitan aggression 1798, 18; invites King Ferdinand to behave more liberally, 124; makes peace at Lunéville 1801, 24; proposes Britain disown Sicilian constitution 1815, 132; reenters war against France 1809, 75; seeks British assistance in Italy 1809, 75–77; signs treaties with King Ferdinand, 17, 129, 132; treats with Murat 1814, 119; willingness to defend Naples 1798, 17. *See also* Francis II; Metternich, Clemens Wenzel Lothar, prince of Austria-Este, Francis, Archduke, 111
- Ball, Captain (later Rear Adm.), Sir Alexander (governor of Malta), 20, 22, 26, 30; advocates British annexation of Sicily, 28; his management of Malta grain supply, 38; prepares to send troops to Messina, 27; stresses importance of Sicily to Malta, 135; supplies *Thunderer* to take Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67
- Balsamo, Abbate, 37; attributes troubles in 1813 to Bentinck's absence, 104;

- designs reformed tax system, 83; drafts constitution 1812, 97
- Bathurst, Henry, third earl (president of Board of Trade 1807–9, secretary of state for foreign affairs 1809, secretary of war and colonies 1812–27), 114, 115, 116; calls Castelficala's bluff, 123; gives Sicily priority, 114; rejects idea of trade treaty with Sicily, 138–39; supports Bentinck against Liverpool, 113; tells Bentinck that ministry opposes Italian expedition, 116
- Belmonte-Pignatelli, Antonio Francesco, prince of: appeals to British 1811, 88; his arrest and deportation, 88; asks for king to resume powers, 125; becomes minister, 96; his character, 100; his death, 134; his differences with Castelficala, 105, 125; dislikes Bentinck leaving Sicily 1813, 103; goes into exile, 126; his lack of ability as minister, 100; loses confidence of Bentinck, 100, 107; as political turncoat, 105, 125; released from prison, 95; his resignation, 101; his self-interest paramount, 107; sponsors reformed tax system, 83; tells Bentinck Sicilians desire contradictions, 116; urges Bentinck to be more ruthless, 107
- Bentinck, Lieutenant General, Lord William Cavendish: advises Montgomerie to be cautious, 106; advocates coalition in Sicilian government, 125; appointed commander-in-chief and minister plenipotentiary, 44, 89; his attitude to new Sicilian constitution of 1812, 97–98, 108, 132–33; authorizes Sicilian trade with Naples, 137–38; becomes military dictator, 103, 106–7; as captain general in Sicily, 95; his career, 89, 120; his character, 89; concludes treaty with Tunis, 139; confides in Orleans, 96; declares end of armistice with Murat, 128; disillusion with Sicilians, 100, 107–8, 126, 132; doubts king's sincerity, 125; "Dream," 28, 120–25; favors British intervention in Sicilian affairs, 24, 91–92, 95, 107, 131, 132; finances king and hereditary prince, 103, 109, 127; his first arrival in Sicily, 92; forces queen to leave Sicily, 102–3; given option to send troops to Spain or Italy, 111, 113; handicapped over operations in Spain by Sicily, 135; his handling of evidence of plots and treachery, 93–95; hesitates to conclude armistice with Murat, 119; impressed by British unpopularity 1813, 104; instructions to, 1811, 92; involvement in Sicilian government, 102; justifies constitutional change in military terms, 114; lack of success in persuading Sicilians to work own reforms, 100, 136; leaves Sicily to command in Spain 1813, 103; his memorandum on Sicily 1811, 91; and military occupation of Palermo, 95; negotiates with Murat at Ponza, 119; nicknamed by Sicilians, 133; his opinion of queen's alleged treachery, 94; opposes offering crown of Naples to Murat, 118–19; plans to intervene in Montenegro, 112; plans to send expedition to Calabria, 1813, 116; plans to use Italian Levy, 110, 114, 116–17; and proclamation to Italian people to rise, 120; projects cooperation with Sardinia and Austria in Italy 1811, 111; his quarrel with Murat in Italy, 120; and reform of royal army, 97; refuses to send back troops to Spain, 115–16; reimposes price control, 105, 137; rejects offer to become "Grand Chancellor," 102; his relations with hereditary prince, 96; his relations with King Ferdinand, 95, 101; his relations with Queen Maria-Carolina, 42, 95, 96, 99, 102–3; releases king from pledge 1814, 125; his reluctance to cooperate with Murat, 119–20; replaced as minister, 120; reprimanded by Castlereagh, 103, 120; resumes payment of subsidy, 96; returns from Spain to Sicily 1813, 106; Russia tries to secure his cooperation in Adriatic, 114; sends army to Spain, 113; sends force to Leghorn, 116–17; sends force to Lissa, 112; sends Lamb to Castlereagh with memorandum, 115; signs armistice with Murat, 118; takes army to Italy 1814, 119–20; uses force

- against Sicilian court, 95, 101; his views on military expedition to liberate Italy, 110–11, 114–18, 120; his views on usefulness of army from Sicily in Spain, 113, 115; withholds subsidy, 95, 97, 98
- Biancamano, Francescantonio: claims to represent Italian patriot leaders, 73; distrusted by Stuart, 74
- Bonaparte, Joseph (king of Naples 1806–8): becomes king of Naples, 34; prepares invasion of Sicily 1808, 71–72; pressed by Napoleon to take Sicily, 45; recalled to take over throne of Spain, 72; regards Queen Maria-Carolina as unscrupulous, 42
- Bonaparte, Napoleon (first consul, then emperor of the French): abdicates, 120; anger at abandonment of Scilla, 76; appoints brother Joseph king of Naples, 34; attempts to involve Naples in seizure of Malta, 26; his attitude toward Murat's plans to invade Sicily, 86–87; his concern at Russian threat to Turkey, 71; his defeat at Leipzig prejudices Murat, 119; demands dismissal of Acton, Elliot, and Damas, 27; directs publication of disinformation about Sicily, 73; escapes from Elba, 127; expels Austria from north Italy 1796, 15; loses interest in taking Sicily, 72; orders withdrawal of St. Cyr from Neapolitan kingdom, 33; plans invasion of Sicily 1808, 71; proclaims end of Bourbon rule in Naples, 34; reinforces Corfu, 71; seeks to bluff British over his plans for Sicily, 87; threatens Naples, 29; urges Joseph to take Sicily, 45; his victory at Jena, 53; his victory at Marengo, 24; his victories at Ulm and Austerlitz, 34; his victory at Wagram, 76; wants to use Sicily as trap for British forces, 109
- Bourcard, Gen. Emanuel de (commander of Neapolitan army in Sicily): criticized, 30, 47; sent to coordinate defense with Stuart, 1810, 85
- British merchants in Sicily: angry at restrictions on trade, 104; benefit from trade with Sicily, 138–39; complain British navy interferes with trade, 137; grievances of, removed, 138–39; press for British intervention in Sicilian government, 89; protest at privileges being ignored, 138; protest at taxation, 88, 138; suffer from quarantine regulations, 137–38; unfavorable position of, relative to other nationals, 138
- British press: attacks of, on Sicilian government, 65, 89
- Brydone, Peter, 37
- Bunbury, Colonel (later Lt. Gen.), Sir Henry Edward (quartermaster-general then chief of staff to commander-in-chief Sicily 1805–8, under secretary of state for war 1809–16), 103; comments on Sicilian welcome of British 1806, 37; comments on strength of Sicilian militia, 47; deplores decision to recall Moore and troops from Sicily, 70; dubious of quality of Italian resistance, 74; favors British intervention in Italy, 110; supports idea of landing army on coast of central Italy, 110
- Butera-Branciforte, Ercole Michele, prince of, 37, 40
- Calabrian Free Corps: formation and incorporation into Italian Levy, 110; soldier of, is executed for treachery, 93
- Campbell, Lieutenant Colonel (later Lt. Gen.), Sir James (adjutant general to British forces in Sicily): criticizes Sicilian court, 83
- Canizzaro, Count: his role in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 142–43
- Canning, George (secretary of state for foreign affairs 1807–9): authorizes attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141; decides not to send Howick's instructions on Sicily, 59; defends British refusal to let Prince Leopold land at Gibraltar, 67–68; discourages Sicilian claim to Spanish regency, 66; rebukes Drummond, 65; recalls Drummond, 67; unwilling to interfere in Sicilian internal affairs, 59, 79
- Canosa, Antonio Capace Minutolo, prince of, 43
- Capri, island of: capture criticized by Collingwood, 56; captured by Murat,

- 72; captured by Sidney Smith, 48; loss of, affects Sicilian morale, 74; value of, to British, 72
- Caracciolo, marquis of (viceroys of Sicily 1781–86), 39
- Carbone, Colonel (adviser of Queen Maria-Carolina), 43; organizes *masse*, 44; and raids on Calabrian coast, 72; his relations with British commanders, 44
- Cassaro, Don Francesco Statello, prince of, 19; accompanies Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67; becomes minister, 96; dismissed, 102; divides ministry, 99; signs undertaking regarding queen, 99; supports court against would-be reformers, 84
- Cassetti, Capt. Giuseppe: implicated in plots, 94
- Castelcalà, Fabrizio Ruffo, prince of, 94, 99; canvasses appointment of A'Court as minister, 131; corresponds with hereditary prince, 98; his pledge on unified command, 79; plots to have Bentinck recalled, 123; protests at articles in British press, 65–66; protests at refusal of British to let Prince Leopold land at Gibraltar, 67–68; and regency of Spain for King Ferdinand, 66–67; tells court Bentinck lacks ministerial support, 101
- Castelnuovo, Carlo Cottone, prince of, and duke of Villa Ermosa: appointed minister, 96; his arrest and exile, 88; his differences with Belmonte, 105, 125; favors free trade, 105; released from captivity, 95; his retirement, 134; his views on making democrats ministers, 108
- Castlereagh. *See* Stewart, Robert, Viscount Castlereagh
- Castrone, Giuseppe, marquis of (chief of police in Palermo), 88; adviser of queen, 43–44; imprisoned, 96
- Catania: radical ideas flourish in, 97; rivalry with Messina, 39
- Catinelli, Lt. Col. Carlo (commander of 3rd Italian regiment): leads expedition to Tuscany 1813, 116, 118
- Cattolica, Prince: derided by Damas, 47; plans to enlist Sicilian army, 47
- Cavaignac, Gen. Jean-Baptiste: lands force south of Messina 1810, 86–87
- Circello, Tommaso di Somma, marquis of, 67, 89; his ability, 43; accompanies Prince Leopold to Ischia, 76; deprived of influence, 102; fears British may abandon Sicily 1806, 58; involved in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 142; presses British commanders to invade Italy, 54–56; his relations with British, 43; remains minister under hereditary prince, 96; his role in claiming Spanish regency for King Ferdinand, 67; signs undertaking relating to queen, 99
- Collingwood, Adm. Cuthbert, Lord (commander-in-chief British fleet in the Mediterranean 1805–10): approves abandonment of Gaeta, 56; attempts to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141–44; critical of capture of Capri, 56; critical of expedition to bay of Naples, 56, 75, 76, 77; forced to leave Mediterranean 1805, 33; impatient with complaints of lack of naval protection for Sicily, 72–73; his opinion of Queen Maria-Carolina, 41; persuades Stuart to seize Ionian Islands, 77; provides squadron to guard Sicily, 46, 73; sceptical of Italian resistance, 74; urges Stuart to aid Austria in Italy, 75; warns Stuart of danger from French fleet 1809, 76–77
- Congress of Vienna 1814–15, 125, 127, 129
- Constitution of 1812: approved by Sicilian parliament, 97; associated with British rule, 104; attitude of court toward, 97–99; commission set up to modify, 128; disapproved of by A'Court, 130–32; modelled on English constitution, 96–97; provides for independent Sicily, 122; supplanted by new constitution 1816, 133; terms of, 97; unregretted in Sicily, 134; viewed by Bentinck, 97–98, 108; viewed by Castlereagh, 131; viewed by King Ferdinand, 96–98, 128–29, 132
- Corfu, island of: French take over, 70; reinforced by Ganteaume 1808, 71; Russians send troops from, to Naples 1805, 29; seizure authorized by Liver-

- pool, 111; value placed on, by Napoleon, 71; Wellesley forbids attack on 1810, 77
- Corsica, island of, 121; Bentinck contemplates use of, as base for invading Italy, 111–12, 118
- Cotton, Admiral, Sir Charles, 85, 145
- Craig, General, Sir James Henry, 45; defends Sicily 1806, 46–48; his differences with Elliot, 33; frustrates French hopes of crossing straits of Messina, 45; instructions to, 30; lands army near Naples, 32–33; persuades ministry to reinforce Sicily, 48; reembarks army, 33; resigns command, 48
- Cutò, Prince, 102
- Dalrymple, Colonel, Sir John: commands Calabrian Free Corps, 110; his wife's comments on plots and alleged treachery, 94–95
- Damas, Roger, Count (commander of army in kingdom of Naples 1805–6), 33; defeated by French, 34, 43, 45; his dismissal demanded by Napoleon, 27; favorite of Queen Maria-Carolina, 43; leaves Sicily, 43; his opinion of officers in royal army in Sicily, 47
- Danero, General (commander of Messina garrison 1799), 20
- Drummond, Sir William (British minister at Palermo 1807–9): appointed minister, 56; believes he can influence king to effect reform, 59, 61; contacted by Biancamano, 73; criticized, 61, 63; defends British policy over peace negotiations, 58; his deviousness, 63; disapproves plan to invade Italy, 56; gets Tatischeff removed, 65; involved in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141–42; liked by queen, 42; persuades King Ferdinand to declare war on Russia, 65; recalled, 67; renews payment of subsidy, 59; strained relations with British generals, 58, 59, 60–61, 63; supports claim of King Ferdinand to Spanish regency, 66–68; suspends subsidy to Sicilian court, 59; urges Fox to invade Italy 1807, 60; his views on ability of Acton, 43; his views on Circello, 43; his views on state of Sicily in 1807, 39; voices court's complaints about lack of naval protection, 72
- Duckworth, Admiral, Sir John Thomas: commands expedition to Constantinople, 60
- Egypt: British expedition to, in 1807, 60
- Elba, island of: Bentinck contemplates use of, as base for invading Italy, 111–12
- Elliot, Hugh (British minister to court of Naples and Palermo 1803–7), 30; complains of actions of Sidney Smith, 48, 53; criticizes Sicilian government, 38; his differences with British army and navy commanders, 28, 33–34; disapproved by Napoleon, 27; sent as minister to Naples, 26; as spokesman for views of queen, 27, 33, 42; stresses importance of navy in Sicily's defenses, 46; urged by Nelson not to take risks over Sicily, 27
- Erskine, Cardinal, 141, 143–44
- Erskine, Lieutenant General, Sir James St. Clair, 23
- Fagan, Robert: as agent for British in Rome until expelled, 141; appointment of, as consul-general in Palermo, 141; his attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141–42, 144; as confidant of Queen Maria-Carolina, 41–42, 141; suspended from functions, 88; urges Bentinck to use force, 95; his views on queen, 41
- Faro, 86, 87; plot to seize fort at, 93
- Ferdinand IV (king of Naples) (Ferdinand III, king of Sicily): adopts new constitution 1816, 133; advises his son to procrastinate, 96; allows British generals to inspect royal army, 47; amnesty to Calabrians abused, 82; appoints commission to revise constitution, 128; assumes command of royal army, 79; attempts to resume power, 100–101; his attitude toward 1812 constitution, 96–98, 128–29, 132; awarded Kingdom of Naples by Con-

- gress of Vienna, 129; convasses appointment of A'Court as minister, 131; his character and tastes, 40, 99; his claim to regency of Spain, 66–68; his claim to sovereignty of Malta, 11, 26; condemns those seeking to divide allies, 93; delegates power to hereditary prince, 95, 101, 110; his determination to recover throne of Naples, 11, 40, 119; his financial dependence on British, 11, 23, 79, 103, 109, 127; gives hostile reception to draft treaty 1807, 59; grants unified command of armed forces, 95; his handling of alleged plots 1811, 93–94; honors pledge not to victimize Sicilians, 134–35; his inability to manage royal finances, 40, 83; invited to behave more liberally 1814, 125–26; involved in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 142–46; leaves Naples for Sicily, 18, 34; his loyalty to British alliance, 11, 26, 89, 93; offended by Maitland over handling of plots, 93; his offer to abdicate, 95; opposes reduction of British garrison, 74–75; plots to have Bentinck recalled, 123; promises not to resume powers without permission, 101; punishes Neapolitan rebels 1799, 23; raises taxes by decree, 88; refuses to grant unified command, 85; rejects French offer of military alliance 1802, 26; his relations with Bentinck, 89, 95, 101; his relations with Queen Maria-Carolina, 99; his reluctance to help British defend Sicily 1810, 84–85; his reluctance to return to Naples 1800, 24; requests British army stay in Sicily 1814, 127; his resumption of power 1814, 125; returns to Naples, 1815, 128; sends troops to Malta 1802, 26; sensitive to attacks in British press, 65; signs treaty of Florence 1801, 25; signs treaty with Austria 1815, 129, 132; his sincerity doubted, 125, 132; surrenders to Bentinck's demands, 95, 101; suspicious of British intentions, 11, 28, 59; unifies kingdoms of Naples and Sicily, 133; his views on Sicilians, 98, 134; welcomed to Sicily 1798, 19; welcomes Charles Stuart to Sicily 1799, 22. *See also* Naples, kingdom of
- Ficuzza (royal shooting lodge), 99
- Florence, treaty of, 1801, 25
- Fox, Charles James (secretary of state for foreign affairs 1806): conducts peace negotiations, 58
- Fox, Gen. Henry Edward (commander-in-chief of British forces in Mediterranean 1806–7), 23; appointed to command in Mediterranean, 51; his contempt for royal family of Sicily, 61; critical of Gen. John Stuart, 53; deplores futility of Hesse's expedition 1807, 61; his differences with Drummond, 58–59, 60–61; his dual role as minister and commander, 56, 89; his limitations, 51; his opinion of Neapolitan troops, 47; ordered to prepare landing in Calabria, 61; refuses to send army to Italy, 55–56, 60, 61; his reliance on Moore, 51; sends Moore to investigate Sidney Smith's activities, 53; specifies force needed to hold Egypt, 60; his views on size of garrison needed to hold Sicily, 23
- France: conquest of Naples by, 11, 34; naval preparations of, for attack on Sicily, 17; and threats to Messina 1801, 26; and threats to Naples 1798, 17; tries to bluff over threat to invade Sicily 1813, 116; withdraws troops from Naples 1799, 23; withdraws troops from southern Italy 1809, 75. *See also* Bonaparte, Joseph; Bonaparte, Napoleon; Murat, Joachim
- Francis (hereditary prince of Naples and Sicily): accepts principle of compensation for Naples 1813, 118; appointed inspector general of royal army in Sicily, 61; asks king to resume power, 125; becomes vicar general, 42, 95; his character, 42, 98–99; distrusts his ministers, 96; his fear of Bentinck, 98; his financial dependence on Bentinck, 103, 109, 127; influenced by his parents, 42, 96; his lack of enthusiasm for new constitution, 98; as lieutenant general of Sicily, 128; his obstructive

- tactics, 97; his procrastination, 96, 98; his reaction to Bentinck's "Dream," 122–23
- Francis II (emperor of Austria): his attitude to queen coming to Vienna, 99; marries daughter of Queen Maria-Carolina, 42; urges King Ferdinand to adopt more liberal attitude 1814, 124; urges prince regent to send army to Spain not Italy, 113
- Fraser, Maj. Gen. Alexander Mackenzie: commands expedition to Egypt, 60
- Fremantle, Adm. Thomas F., 112, 139
- Frilli, Colonel, 99, 102
- Gabrielli, Cardinal: concerned in plan to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141, 143, 145
- Gaeta, fortress of: holds out against French, 45; refusal of Stuart to reinforce, 51; surrenders to French, 45
- Ganteaume, Adm. Honoré: his fleet's incursion into Mediterranean 1808, 71
- Gazzetta Britannica* (Messina), 85
- Graham, Lt. Col. James (aide-de-camp to Lord William Bentinck): sent to allied headquarters 1813, 119; sent to interview Castlereagh 1814, 124
- Graham, Lieutenant Colonel (later Brig. Gen.), Sir Thomas: commands Messina garrison 1799, 22, 23; his views on British garrisoning Sicily, 20, 22
- Great Britain: advises Naples to make peace, 24–25; attitude of, toward Sicilian constitution, 133; benefits economically from alliance with King Ferdinand, 11; claim of, to Malta, 26; cooperates with Russia in Italy 1805, 29–30, 32; dependence of, on ports of Naples and Sicily, 11, 12; determination of, to deny Sicily to France, 12; disowns schemes to annex Sicily, 121–25, 127; finances second coalition, 19; gives priority to peninsula over Sicily, 77–78, 87, 109–12, 114; gives priority to Sicily and Malta over Ionian Islands, 78; gives priority to Sicily over Egypt, 60; guarantees Sicily to King Ferdinand, 11, 133; inability of, to support Naples with land force 1801, 24; insists on no victimization of Sicilians 1814, 126, 135; interest of, in developing Sicily's military potential, 29; military action of, in Mediterranean 1809–10, 77; occupies Messina 1806, 34; pays subsidies to King Ferdinand, 11, 23, 79, 103, 109, 127; persuades King Ferdinand to send troops to Malta 1802, 26; policy of, regarding support for Italian resistance, 73, 111–12, 116; proposes new treaty with Sicily 1807, 58–59; public opinion of, favors restoration of King Ferdinand to Naples, 126; reluctance of, to interfere in Sicily, 44, 79, 89, 92; renews war 1803, 26; retains Malta, 26; sends army to Egypt, 60; sends fleet to Dardanelles, 59–60; signs treaty of Amiens 1802, 26; supports Ferdinand's claim to Sicily in peace negotiations 1806, 58; suspected of intention to annex Sicily, 29, 122–23; suspicious of loyalty of Sicilian court, 12, 68; and treaties signed with King Ferdinand, 11, 15, 23, 26, 28, 110; urges return of king to Naples 1800, 24; value of Sicily to, 135; withdraws army from Egypt, 60; withholds guarantee of Naples to Ferdinand, 11, 79. *See also* Canning, George; Stewart, Robert, Viscount Castlereagh; Fox, Charles James; Grey, Charles, second earl Howick; Jenkinson, Robert Banks, second earl Liverpool; Pitt, William, the Younger; Wellesley, Richard Colley, marquis of
- Grenier, General: his role in frustrating invasion of Sicily 1810, 86
- Grenville, William Wyndham (secretary of state for foreign affairs 1791–1801, prime minister 1806–7), 24; appeal to, to garrison Messina 1799, 20; envisages Sicily becoming British protectorate, 121; persuades Pitt to send fleet to Mediterranean, 17
- Grey, Charles, second earl Howick: proposes new treaty with Sicily 1807, 58–59, 121, 124
- Guillichini, General (commander of Messina garrison), 30

- Hamilton, Sir William (British minister at court of Naples and Palermo 1764–1800): liked by queen, 42; reassures Nelson about opening of ports to British fleet, 18; urges British to defend Messina 1799, 20; urges British to reconquer Naples, 22; urges Neapolitan court to attack French in Italy 1798, 18
- Harrowby. *See* Ryder, Dudley, first earl, second baron Harrowby
- Hereditary prince. *See* Francis
- Hesse, Luigi (prince of Hesse-Philippstadt): his ability and courage, 47; commands garrison at Gaeta, 45; defeated at Mileto, 47, 60; deprived of influence at court, 102
- Howick. *See* Grey, Charles, second earl Howick
- Ionian Islands, 86, 121, 125; assault on, by Stuart's forces 1809–10, 77–78; as base for Russian army and navy, 29; Calabrian Free Corps sent to, 110; troops from, allotted to Montenegrin expedition, 112
- Ischia, island of, 20; abandoned by British, 77; surrenders to British, 76
- Italian Levy: Bentinck's plans to use, 114; expedition of, to Tuscany, 116–17; formation of, 109; morale of, 114; sent to Spain, 110
- Italian resistance: Biancamano and leaders of, 73; British ministers lack faith in, 111, 116; strength of, depreciated by British, 73–74; strength of, depreciated by Murat, 74
- Jenkinson, Robert Banks, second earl Liverpool (secretary of state for foreign affairs 1801–4, secretary for war 1809–12, prime minister 1812–27): considers Ionian Islands of secondary importance to Sicily and Malta, 78; disapproves Bentinck's "Dream," 124–25; favors sending troops from Sicily to Catalonia, 110; gives Bentinck option of sending army to Spain or Italy, 111; overrules Stuart over not sending troops to Spain, 87; wants to reduce British garrison in Sicily, 109
- Lacey, Gen. Maurice de: commands Russian army in Italy 1805, 30
- Lamb, Frederick (secretary to Lord William Bentinck), 115
- Layard, Colonel, 28
- Leckie, Gould Francis (British consul at Syracuse): farms in Sicily, 27–28, 37; publishes *Historical Survey*, 65; urges British intervention in Sicily, 28, 65–66, 89, 121; views on Sicilian nobles, 39
- Leopold, Prince (youngest son of King Ferdinand and Queen Maria-Carolina): proclaimed viceroy at Ischia, 76, 82; sent to Gibraltar to claim Spanish regency, 66–68.
- Lissa, island of: occupied by British force from Sicily, 112
- Liverpool. *See* Jenkinson, Robert Banks, second earl Liverpool
- Louis XVIII (king of France 1814–24): advises King Ferdinand to adopt more liberal attitude, 125
- Lowe, Lieutenant Colonel (later Lt. Gen.): commands British garrison at Capri, 73
- Macfarlane, General: defies quarantine regulations, 105; ensures queen's departure from Sicily, 102; implores Bentinck to return to Sicily 1813, 106; joins Bentinck's army in Italy 1814, 119; resists Bentinck's plan for attack on Calabria, 116; reviews royal army with Bentinck, 110; takes contingent to Naples 1815, 128
- Macfarlane, Charles, 134
- Maida, battle of, 45, 51, 135
- Maitland, General, Sir Frederick: his handling of plots and suspected treachery, 92–94; sent with army from Sicily to Spain, 113–14
- Malta, island of: Britain gets Naples to send troops to, in 1802, 26; claim of king of Naples to sovereignty of, 11, 26; dependence of, on Sicily, 23, 135; markets well supplied with corn, 38; Napoleon's plan to seize, in 1802, 26; Neapolitan troops leave, 28; plague in, affects Sicily, 104, 137; siege of, 20–

- 23; supplies Sicily with guns and troops, 46, 48
- Manhès, Gen. Charles-Antoine, Count, 119
- Maria-Carolina (queen of Naples and Sicily): advisers of, 43; agrees to leave Sicily, 34, 99; agrees to Stuart having overall command 1809, 75; allies Naples with Russia, 29; her anger at British withdrawal from Naples 1805, 33; and anger at British withdrawal from bay of Naples 1809, 77; her attempts to treat with Napoleon 1805, 33; her attempt to enlist *masse*, 47; her attitude toward British, 33, 41–42, 73; her attitude toward constitution of 1812, 98; her attitude toward hereditary prince, 41; character of, 40–41; children of, 42; complains of lack of naval protection, 72–73; controls foreign policy, 28–29; death of, 102, 128; her devotion to Saint Clair, 43–44; her dislike of Paget, 24, 42; her dislike of Sicily and Sicilians, 19, 41, 124; dissuades king from abdicating, 95; employs agents and spies, 41; evidence of treachery of, 84–85, 88–89, 93–95; extravagance of, 83; favorites of, 43; favors La Tour's plan 1809, 75–77; fears British will provoke Napoleon, 27; hopes for Russian support 1799, 19; insists on king commanding royal army, 81–82; intrigues with Tatishcheff, 43, 65; leaves Sicily, 102; misuses British subsidy, 79; opposes appointment of vicar general, 95; opposes return of king to Naples 1800, 24; organizes attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 141–142, 145; plans to send Moliterno to Calabria, 82; and political intrigues, 96; puts views on British generals to Paget, 63; her readiness to dispose of Sicily, 124; her relations with Bentinck, 89, 96; her reluctance to leave Sicily, 96, 99, 102; sends Leopold to Spain, 67; sensitive to attacks in British press, 65; spreads rumors about Belmonte, 96; supports Hesse's expedition 1807, 53–57; supports punishment of rebels 1799, 23; suspected of giving secret instructions to Schiara, 82; suspected of influencing delays in reform, 96; urges attack by British to reconquer Naples, 54–55, 63; urges attack on French in Italy 1798, 18
- Martin, Admiral, Sir George: detailed to protect Sicily 1808, 73; given more frigates for offense 1809, 75; harasses Murat's preparations for invasion, 85; opposes queen's plan to send Moliterno to Calabria 1810, 82; his role in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 144–45
- Masse*: contempt of, for Neapolitan troops, 47; crushed by French 1807, 46; encouraged by Stuart 1806, 51; lack of discipline of, 47; organized by Carbone, 44; plan of queen to raise 1810, 82; Sidney Smith ordered to stop making promises to, 53; uselessness of, 61
- Masséna, Marshal André, 56, 110
- Maxwell, Captain: attempts rescue of Pope Pius VII, 142–43
- Medici, Luigi, Cavaliere di (minister of finance at court of Palermo): goes to England, 96; plots to get Bentinck recalled, 123; his views on English constitution, 98
- Mellish, Joseph Charles (British chargé d'affaires at Palermo 1810): presses King Ferdinand to help defend Sicily, 85; urges need for commercial treaty with Sicily, 138
- Messina: contingency plans for British to seize, 1803–5, 26; defense of, 1810, 86–87; and garrison's loyalty, 20; occupied by British, 22, 34; plot to suborn garrison of, 93–95; proposed status of, in treaty proposals 1807, 59; and rivalry with Catania, 39; strength of fortress of, 20, 22, 28, 30; under threat from French 1801, 26
- Metternich, Clemens Wenzel Lothar, prince of (chancellor and foreign minister of Austria): favors restoration of Naples to Ferdinand without a constitution, 126; proposes to Britain that Sicilian constitution be disowned, 132–33
- Milazzo, 59, 87

- Mileto: Hesse's army defeated at, 47, 60
- Minorca, island of, 20, 22, 23
- Moliterno, Don Girolamo Pignatelli, prince of: banished from Sicily, 102; his character and ability, 44, 74; distrusted by British, 44, 74; plan of queen to send to Calabria, 82; poses as leader of Italian resistance, 97; his relations with queen, 43; supposed to support Murat, 84
- Montenegro: abortive plan to send British troops to, 112
- Montgomerie, Gen. Archibald, Lord: deputed for Bentinck, 103; his handling of political and constitutional crisis in Sicily, 106; implores Bentinck to return to Sicily, 106; intervenes over observing quarantine regulations by army, 105
- Moore, Lieutenant General, Sir John, 89; allowed to inspect royal troops, 69; appointed second in command to Fox, 51; attempts to win over the queen, 68–69; criticizes Drummond, 63; criticizes Sidney Smith, 51, 53; driving force behind Fox, 52–53; his opinion of queen, 41, 42, 69; opposes expedition to recover Naples, 59–60, 68–69; orders Sidney Smith to desist from encouraging *masse*, 53; his pessimism about defending Sicily, 48, 69; posted from Sicily, 69–70, 71; recommends Britain take over government of Sicily, 69, 121; refused unified command, 69; his verdict on Hesse's defeat, 60–61; his views on royal army, 46–47, 69
- Morning Chronicle*: article in, attacking Sicilian government, 65; reports speech critical of Sicilian government, 89
- Morning Post*: letter in, suggesting Britain annex Sicily, 89
- Murat, Joachim (king of Naples 1808–14): abandons invasion of Sicily, 86–87; announces intention to grant Naples a constitution, 126; attacks Austria 1815, 128; captures Capri, 72; his character and ability, 72; his claim to throne of Naples, 118, 124, 126, 128; his death, 129; makes approaches for armistice, 119; negotiates with Bentinck at Ponza, 118; plans invasion of Sicily, 72–73, 84–86; sceptical of Italian resistance, 74; sides with allies, 118; signs armistice, 118–19; strengthens defenses of Naples 1809, 76
- Murray, General, Sir John: commands Sicilian forces in Spain, 114; sends back 2,000 troops from Spain to Sicily, 114
- Naples, kingdom of: alliance of, with Great Britain, 11, 15, 23, 26, 28; alliance of, with Russia 1798, 19; alliance of, with Russia 1805, 29; appeals to Britain for help, 17; assists Britain 1794–96, 15; becomes Parthenopian Republic, 19; defeated by French, 18; double-crosses France 1805, 29; makes peace 1796, 15; makes peace 1801, 25; opens ports to British fleet, 17–18; reconquered by Ruffo, 23; reinforces Messina 1803, 28; sends troops to Malta 1802, 26. *See also* Ferdinand IV; Maria-Carolina; Sicily, kingdom of
- Neapolitans: as disloyal subjects, punished 1799, 23; retain bitter memories of 1799, 74; unpopularity of, in Sicily, 19; untrustworthy as troops in Sicily, 46–47, 69, 87
- Neipperg, Adam Albrecht, Count (Austrian envoy at court of Naples), 119
- Nelson, Adm. Horatio, Lord, 30; arrives off Naples 1798, 17; complains of governor of Syracuse, 17; considers Elliot gullible, 33; gets British troops sent to Messina 1799, 20; his hostility to Russian fleet in Mediterranean, 19; imprisons Rossi, 105; keeps warship in bay of Naples, 28; ordered to protect Sicily 1803, 27; orders burning of Neapolitan fleet 1798, 19; punishes Neapolitan rebels, 23; his relations with Sicilian court, 41; retains fleet off Sicily, 20; sends Troubridge to bay of Naples, 20; his sympathy with Sicilian aspirations, 19; takes Neapolitan court to Sicily, 18–19; urges attack by Naples on French 1798, 18; urges dispatch of Messina

- garrison to Naples and Malta, urges risks not be taken over Sicily, 27; his views on backwardness of Sicily, 36–37; welcomed at Naples 1798, 18
- Nugent, Colonel, 111, 113
- Orleans, Louis-Philippe, duke of, 85, 101, 125; accompanies Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67; accused of aiming at regency of Sicily, 96; dislikes Bentinck leaving Sicily, 103; his friendship with Bentinck, 96; goes into exile, 126; implores Bentinck to return to Sicily 1813, 106; urges firmness on Bentinck, 100
- Pacca, Cardinal: his role in attempted rescue of Pope Pius VII, 142–44
- Paget, Sir Arthur (minister at court of Naples and Palermo 1800–1803): argues interdependence of Malta and Sicily, 26; fails as mediator between Drummond and British generals, 63; favors British intervention in Sicily 1800, 37; unpopular with queen, 24, 42; urges King Ferdinand to return to Naples 1800, 24; his views on Sicily's condition, 37
- Pasley, Captain (later General): influence of his "Military Policy," 89, 91, 121
- Pellew, Admiral, Sir Edward, first viscount Exmouth, 116
- Perceval, Spencer (prime minister 1809–12): critical of Bentinck's memorandum on Sicily 1811, 91
- Perry (proprietor of *Morning Chronicle*): apologizes for attack on Sicilian government, 65
- Pitt, William, the Younger (prime minister 1783–1801, 1804–6): decides to send fleet to Mediterranean, 15; his realism as statesman, 121–22; withdraws fleet from Mediterranean, 15
- Pius VII (pope 1800–1823): attempt to rescue, 141–46
- Ponza, island of, 20, 142; captured by British 1813, 114; prince of Canosa sent to, 43; projected use of, as base for operations against Italy, 117; scene of Bentinck's negotiations with Murat, 118–19
- Procida, island of: captured then abandoned by British 1809, 76–77
- Reggio di Calabria: captured by French 1808, 46, 70; garrisoned by British 1806, 46, 48
- Régnier, General: defeated at Maida, 51, 56; his role in plan to invade Sicily, 71
- Rossaroll, Capt. Andrea, 94
- Rossi, Emmanuele: radical programme of, 105; tactics of, in Sicilian parliament, 106
- Royal army in Sicily: attempts to improve, 97; British equipment for, 109–10; constitutes political danger in Sicily, 115–16; discipline and quality of, 46–47, 69, 87, 97, 109–10, 115, 127; numbers of, reduced, 109, 127; size of, 87, 109; starving without pay, 127
- Ruffo, Fabrizio, Cardinal, 23
- Russia: alliance of, with France 1807, 70; alliance of, with Naples, 19, 29; cooperation of, with British in Naples 1805, 29–30, 32; czar of, urges king to adopt more liberal attitude 1814, 124; fears French attack on Turkey, 19; fleet of, arrives off Palermo 1799, 19; help of, sought by queen to mediate with Napoleon, 65; lands force at Manfredonia 1799, 19; leaves second coalition, 24; campaign of, in 1812 draws French troops from Italy, 113; negotiates peace terms affecting Sicily 1806, 58; seeks Bentinck's support in Adriatic, 114; suspicious of British intentions, 29, 33, 99; threat posed to Sicily to warships of, 70; urges British to invade Italy, 60; war declared on, by Sicily, 65
- Ryder, Dudley, first earl, second baron Harrowby (secretary of state for foreign affairs 1804): envisages Sicily as source of military manpower, 29
- Saint Clair, Charles, marquis of: accompanies Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67–68; accompanies Prince Leopold to Ischia, 76; appointed aide to hereditary prince, 61; his character and ability, 44; disliked and distrusted by Brit-

- ish, 44, 68; loses post at court, 59; his relations with Queen Maria-Carolina, 43-44
- St. Cyr, General, 33
- Saliceti, Antoine Christophe (chief of police in Naples), 41
- Sardinia-Piedmont, kingdom of: projected role of, in campaign of 1809 in Italy, 75, 77; role of, in projected campaign 1811 in Italy, 111
- Schiara, marquis of: actions of, while civil governor of Reggio 1809, 82
- Scilla, fortress of: captured by French 1808, 46, 70; French garrison withdrawn from 1809, 76; garrisoned by British, 46, 48
- Sherbrooke, Major General, Sir John: disapproves raids organized by Carbone, 72; withdraws garrison from Scilla, 71
- Sicilian flotilla: augmented 1810, 84; colonel of, arrested, 93; crews of, 46, 84-85; formation of, 46; successful actions of, 85
- Sicilian militia: attempt by British to embody, 47; condition of, 46; strength of, 46-47
- Sicilian people, 39; assist British defend Sicily, 86; their desire for British intervention in administration, 82, 92; their discontent with rule by Naples, 30, 37; their discontent with government of Palermo, 83; their dislike of French, 19, 30, 37; their dislike of Neapolitans, 19; enlist in British army, 110; their liking for British, 86; nobles of, 36, 39-40, 107-8; oppose conscription, 47, 116; peasants of, 37, 39; views of A'Court and Bentinck on, 132; welcome King Ferdinand 1798, 19. *See also* Sicily, kingdom of
- Sicily, kingdom of: agriculture of, 37-38; backwardness of, 36-37; as base for British contraband trade, 23; Catholic Church in, 36; as cause of prolonging war, 58; civil unrest in, 83; commerce of, 36, 137-39; constitution of, 39, 97-99, 128-32; declares war on Russia, 65; defense of, against invasion, 30, 34, 46-48; distinct from Italy, 35; émigrés in, 40; extravagance of court of, 40; government of, attacked in British press, 65; importance of, to British fleet, 11, 17, 23, 33, 58; inability of, to exist independently, 122; industry of, 38, 137; judiciary of, 38-39; merchant marine of, 140; nobility of, 36, 39-40, 107-8; parliament of, 35-36, 39-40; power of crown in, 36; proposals for treaty with Britain rejected, 58-59; taxation in, 40; and treaties of alliance, 52, 89, 110; vulnerability of, to attack, 11, 70, 87. *See also* Constitution of 1812; Ferdinand IV; Royal army in Sicily; Sicilian flotilla; Sicilian militia; Sicilian people
- Smith, Lieutenant Colonel: report of, on Sicily's defenses, 30, 46
- Smith, Joseph (secretary to British minister in Sicily 1813), 106-7
- Smith, Admiral, Sir William Sidney: appointed to command in central Mediterranean, 48; and capture of Capri, 48; his character, 48; his cooperation with Stuart in operation in Italy 1806, 48, 53; criticized by Elliot, 48, 53; criticized by Moore, 53; criticized by Stuart, 51; justifies policy in Calabria, 53; and raids on Calabrian ports, 48, 51; his relations with Queen Maria-Carolina, 41; and relief of Gaeta, 48; reproved by Admiralty, 53; viceroy of Calabria, 51
- Spain: army from Sicily sent to, 110, 113-15; Bentinck hesitates to send army to, 113; Bentinck leaves Sicily to take command in, 103; quits to return to Sicily, 106; Bentinck refuses to send back from Sicily troops to, 115; Joseph Bonaparte sent to, 72; British ministerial policy of, toward reinforcing from Sicily, 74-75, 87, 110, 112; claim by King Ferdinand to regency of, 66-68; Napoleon's interest shifts from Sicily to, 72; resistance movement in, 74; Stuart fails to send troops to, 74-75, 87; troops sent back from, to Sicily, 114; Wellington's campaigns in, 114-16
- Stewart, Robert, Viscount Castlereagh (secretary of war and colonies 1807-9,

- secretary of state for foreign affairs 1812–22), 101, 108; agrees to British army remaining in Sicily 1814–15, 127–28; agrees to continue payments to Sicilian court 1814–15, 127–28; his attitude to granting Sicily a constitution, 131, 133, 135; believes queen is involved in treachery, 94; countermands order to send troops to Spain 1809, 75; decides queen must leave Sicily, 94, 99; disapproves Austrian proposal to disavow Sicilian constitution, 133; favors modification of Sicilian constitution, 131, 133; forbids use of force in Sicily, 103; hopes Stuart will assist Austria in Italy 1809, 75; instructs Bentinck to conclude armistice with Murat, 119; opposes use of force against queen, 99; orders invasion of Calabria 1807, 61; his reaction to Bentinck's "Dream," 123–25; his realism over value of Sicily to Britain, 121–22; recommends recall of Moore from Sicily, 69–70; reinforces Sicily 1808, 70; reprimands Bentinck for conduct in Italy 1814, 120; repudiates commitment to Sicilian constitution, 129; his view on encouraging resistance movements in Europe, 111; wants to divert troops from Sicily to Spain, 74, 85–86
- Stuart, Lieutenant General, The Hon. Sir Charles: commands in Minorca, 20; sends troops to Sicily 1799, 22; his views on importance of Sicily to Britain, 23
- Stuart, Major General, Sir John: his attitude to Sicilian court, 42, 82; captures Ischia and Procida, 76; cooperates with Sidney Smith, 48, 51; coordinates defense plans with royal army, 85; declines to send troops to Spain, 85–87; forms Calabrian Free Corps 1809, 110; instructed on how to assist Italians, 73; objects to Sidney Smith's appointment as viceroy, 51; and offensive operations against Calabrian coast, 72; originates *Gazetta Britannica*, 85; plans to invade Italy 1809, 75; and preparations to defend Sicily, 48, 85–87; pressed to send troops to Spain, 74, 85–86; proclamation to *masse* 1806, 51, 76; his proclamation to Sicilian people, 85; recruits Sicilians into British army, 48; refuses to reinforce Gaeta, 51; reluctant to invade Italy 1808–9, 74–77; replaces Moore as commander in Sicily, 70; resigns command 1806, 51; resigns command 1810, 87, 91; retires from bay of Naples 1809, 77; revises attitude to British intervention in Sicilian affairs, 82; sends force to Ionian Islands, 77–78; succeeds Craig as commander, 48; victory at Maida, 45, 51; his views on Italian resistance, 74
- Syracuse, port of, 136; garrisoned by British troops, 48; status as free port proposed, 59; used by Nelson 1798, 17
- Tatischeff, Count (Russian ambassador to court of Naples and Sicily), 33; ordered to leave Palermo, 65; urges British to invade Italy 1807, 60
- Thornborough, Captain (later Admiral), Sir Edward: criticizes Drummond, 63; wants to attack Russian frigate at Palermo, 65
- Tilsit, treaty of, 1807, 45, 65; its effect on British in Sicily, 69
- Tommasi: accompanies Prince Leopold to Gibraltar, 67; accompanies Prince Leopold to Ischia, 76; deprived of influence at court, 102
- Tour, Sallier de la, Count: tries to coordinate Austrian and British plans for campaign in Italy 1809, 75–77
- Trabia, Prince, 19
- Troubridge, Rear Admiral, Sir Edward Thomas, 20, 24
- Ushakov, Admiral, 19–20
- Vaccaro, Gaspare: radical programme of, 105
- Valletta. *See* Malta, island of
- Vanni, Colonel: his role in attempt to rescue Pope Pius VII, 143–44
- Villettes, Lt. Col. William (commander of British garrison in Malta): ordered

to be ready to send troops to Messina,
27, 28

Wellesley, Richard Colley, marquis of
(secretary of state for foreign affairs
1809–12), 92–93; commissions mem-
orandum on Sicily by Bentinck, 91;
favors British intervention in Italy,
110–11; forbids attack on Corfu, 77
Wellington, Field Marshal, Arthur Welles-

ley, first duke of: his anger at Ben-
tinck's change of plan regarding send-
ing troops to Spain, 113; convinced of
uselessness of British expedition to
Italy, 115–16; disapproves Bentinck
leaving Spain, 106; favors dispatch of
troops from Sicily to Spain, 110; re-
fuses to believe Sicily is in danger,
116; unable to depend on Sicilian con-
tingent in Spain, 114
Wilson, Sir Robert, 102

**Bibliothèques
Université d'Ottawa
Echéance**

**Libraries
University of Ottawa
Date Due**

--	--

22 CE



a39003 014156268b

